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1 Cleaned Up Notes

1.1 Literary Worlds: Rabindranath Tagore and the Idea of World Literature

1.2 Context: Empire and the Life of a Poet

Born in 1861 in Calcutta, Tagore grew up in a family central to Bengal's cultural revival. Three years earlier, British rule had formally transferred from the East India Company to the Crown — the founding of the British Raj. When he died in 1941, India was on the brink of independence. His life thus traces the parenthesis of High Empire (McDonald 2025).

Tagore was both **participant and critic** of empire: willing to engage British culture and Oxford intellectual life, yet uncompromisingly anti-colonial. He founded *Visva-Bharati University* (1921) as an “alternative, anti-colonial university in Bengal” — a name meaning “India in the world,” or “world in India.” That double preposition defines his entire project.

Mini-Essay — Context as Harassment

As Peter McDonald emphasises, context for Tagore was never mere background but a form of “harassment” — a pressure that compelled him to write. Empire, nationalism, and cosmopolitanism were not academic categories but living forces that demanded an answer. His literature is thus an act of resistance: a refusal to let history define the limits of imagination (McDonald 2025).

1.3 From National Character to World Consciousness

When English literature was first institutionalised at Oxford in the 1890s, it was framed by what William John Courthope called the “Law of National Character.” In *Life in Poetry: Law in Taste* (1901), Courthope argued that, besides Aristotle's universal law of art, there exists “another law... the social instinct which compels the artist to individualise his idea of the universal in the light of the race tendencies and character of the nation to which he belongs” (Courthope 1901).

This vision — of literature as expression of a **national spirit** — dominated late-Victorian thought. It defined English Studies as a patriotic project, making literary study the moral education of citizens. The Oxford curriculum, as McDonald notes, “was only successfully denationalised in 2012” (McDonald 2025).

Tagore's intervention begins as a challenge to this entire epistemology. Writing from colonial Bengal, he rejected both imperial universalism and nationalist particularism. His essays of the 1900s — especially “World Literature” (1907) — redefine literature as the space where the **local and the global continually reconfigure one another** (Tagore 1907).

Mini-Essay — Against the Ploughed Fields

Tagore's metaphor for world literature rejects the additive logic of comparative studies: “The world is not your ploughed field plus my ploughed field.” Each genuine work of art generates its own “world,” not by summing cultures but by transforming them. The act of creation dissolves borders rather than accumulating them (Tagore 1907).

1.4 “World Literature” (1907): The Universal in the Particular

In his 1907 lecture “World Literature,” delivered in Bengali to an audience of Indian scholars, Tagore redefines the very term. He resists the colonial drive to classify and compare literatures by nation. Instead, he imagines a literature of **interrelation** and **mutual recognition**.

The 2001 translation renders the key passage as: “It is time we pledged that our goal is to view universal humanity in universal literature... that we shall recognise a totality in each particular author's work, and that in this totality we shall perceive the interrelations among all human efforts at expression” (Tagore 1907; trans. Chaudhuri 2001).

Rosinka Chaudhuri's later commentary (2018) sharpens this insight: “The time has come to try to free ourselves from narrow parochialism and to aim to see the World-Man (*visva mānab*) within the world of

literature; to find in the works of particular writers a whole, and in that whole the interrelations among all forms of human expression” (Chaudhuri 2018).

This distinction between *totality* and *whole* is crucial. The totality implies a closed, finished system; the whole, by contrast, is **organic and incomplete**, always open to new relations.

Mini-Essay — The World-Man

The Bengali concept *viśva mānab* (“world-man”) expresses Tagore’s alternative to both cosmopolitanism and nationalism. It names a being who is simultaneously rooted and open — one who recognises the “interrelations among all forms of human expression.” Literature becomes the medium through which we encounter this figure, in ourselves and in others (Tagore 1907; Chaudhuri 2018).

1.5 Against the “Spiritualist” Misreading

Western critics have often reduced Tagore to an “Eastern mystic,” a guru of universal brotherhood. Pheng Cheah calls this “the older spiritualist vision of world literature,” inherited from Goethe’s idealism (Cheah 2016). Yet, as Amit Chaudhuri insists, Tagore’s thought “constantly refutes metaphysics — a system whereby value and meaning have their source elsewhere, beyond the experienced world” (A. Chaudhuri 2018).

Tagore’s universalism is not transcendental but **experiential**. The divine or the “universal man” is not above the world but within it — an aspiration toward fullness grounded in the here and now (Tagore 1913; Chaudhuri 2018).

Mini-Essay — The Immanent Universal

Tagore’s “universal man” is not a god but a task: to make the local luminous, to see the infinite within the finite. In this, he shares affinities with late Romantic and modernist thought — Wordsworth’s “sense sublime of something far more deeply interfused,” or Joyce’s “epiphany.” Yet Tagore insists that such vision arises not from isolation but from relation: the world remade through encounter (Tagore 1913; Chaudhuri 2013).

1.6 The Dialogue with the West: Arnold and the Gita

The lecture closes by tracing reverse influences: how nineteenth-century English writers engaged Indian thought. Matthew Arnold’s *Empedocles on Etna* (1852) and his published letters on the *Bhagavad-Gītā* (1848) reveal a fascination with Indian ideas of renunciation and knowledge (Arnold 1852; Arnold 1848). Arnold’s distinction between “practice,” “meditation,” and “renunciation of action” echoes the spiritual dialectics that Tagore inherited and transformed (Arnold 1852; Tagore 1907).

To read Arnold and Tagore together is to see the **mutual permeability of literary worlds**. The so-called “English tradition” has always been already global — shaped by its encounters with Sanskrit philosophy, Persian poetics, and Bengali song. Tagore thus stands not outside the canon but within its most vital conversations (Arnold 1852; Tagore 1907).

1.7 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Interpretive Implication
National <-> Universal	From Courthope’s “Law of National Character” to Tagore’s “World-Man.” (Courthope 1901; Tagore 1907)	Literature moves from expressing national identity to enabling global relationality.
Creation <-> Construction	Spontaneous vs. self-conscious authorship (Tagore 1889)	Tagore anticipates modern debates on inspiration and craft.

Axis	Relationship	Interpretive Implication
Colonial <-> Postcolonial	Empire as “harassment” compelling creative response (McDonald 2025)	Writing as resistance through imagination.
Self <-> Other	Chandidas’s “knowing others as our own” (Tagore; Chandidas)	World literature as ethical reciprocity.
Experience <-> Metaphysics	Tagore’s refutation of transcendence (Chaudhuri 2018)	The universal found within the sensory and historical world.
Translation <-> Originality	Self-translation as world-making (Tagore 1913)	Every act of translation re-creates the world anew.

1.8 Conclusion: The World Yet to Come

For Tagore, literature’s highest task is not representation but **relation**. To write or read is to enter into a process of becoming-world — a process without closure. His vision anticipates the postcolonial and global turns in literary studies by nearly a century (Tagore 1907; Chaudhuri 2018).

In his words and his life, Tagore models a practice of *worldliness* that is neither imperial nor cosmopolitan in the Western sense, but something more radical: a poetics of **belonging without possession**.

Mini-Essay — The Unfinished World

The “world” of world literature is not a pre-existing unity but a verb: *worlding*. Each poem, each encounter, remakes the possible. To study Tagore today is to recognise that the humanities themselves are this kind of open project — not the mastery of knowledge, but the art of learning to live with others (Tagore 1907; Chaudhuri 2018).

Notes: I have replaced placeholder content-references with standard author–date parenthetical citations (author year) throughout the text and updated the MHRA-style reference list to include the main primary and secondary items cited in the note. If you would like— I can (a) convert parenthetical citations to footnotes, (b) insert precise page numbers or lecture slide numbers where available, or (c) expand the Reference List with publisher details and editors for translations and critical editions. Which would you prefer?

2 Own Notes

3 Transcript

![[Literary Worlds, World Literature - GENERAL (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom)-2.txt]]

4 Files

![[Tagore’s Worlds handout.docx]]

5 Cleaned Up Notes

5.1 Paraphrase: Friend or Foe?

5.1.1 Professor Fergus McGhee — Oxford Prelims Paper 1B: Introduction to Literature

5.2 I. Ancient and Early Modern Origins

5.2.1 Quintilian: Paraphrase as Rhetorical Rivalry

In *Institutio Oratoria* (c. 95 CE), **Quintilian** urged students to paraphrase verse to improve oratory. The task was not mere imitation but competition:

“Its duty is rather to rival and vie with the original in the expression of the same thoughts.”:contentReferenceoaicite:0

Here, paraphrase is **a form of creative rivalry** — turning poetry into prose, not to simplify but to elevate rhetoric through poetic vigor. The paraphrast competes with the poet as a craftsman of style.

5.2.2 Erasmus and Udall: Paraphrase as Illumination

A millennium later, paraphrase served scripture. Nicholas **Udall**, in his 1548 preface to the *Paraphrase of Erasmus upon the New Testament*, defined it as:

“A plain setting forth of a text ... with such circumstance of more and other words, as may make the sentence open, clear, plain, and familiar.”:contentReferenceoaicite:1

For Udall, paraphrase was **pedagogical and devotional**: to “open” obscurity and make divine truth accessible.

Mini-Essay — From Rivalry to Reverence

Between Quintilian and Udall, paraphrase shifts from **rhetorical competition** to **didactic humility**. Where Quintilian’s paraphrast vies with the poet, Udall’s paraphrast serves the Word. In both, however, language mediates power — whether of persuasion or of God.

5.3 III. The Romantic Challenge: The Inseparability of Form and Meaning

5.3.1 Coleridge: “Untranslatableness Without Injury”

Samuel Taylor **Coleridge**, in *Biographia Literaria* (1817), argued that in great writing — Milton or Shakespeare — one cannot alter “a word or the position of a word... without making the author say something else or something worse.”:contentReferenceoaicite:3

He extends meaning beyond denotation:

> “Language is framed to convey not the object alone, but likewise the character, mood, and intentions of the person who is representing it.”

Paraphrase fails because it assumes meaning is detachable; Coleridge insists that **sound, syntax, and feeling** are inseparable.

5.3.2 Al-Jurjani and the Image of Meaning

Long before Coleridge, the Persian grammarian **Abd al-Qahir al-Jurjani** (11th c.) made the same point. Beauty in language, he wrote, arises from three inseparable elements: idea, word, and arrangement — *surat al-maʿna*, “the form of meaning.”:contentReferenceoaicite:4

Mini-Essay — Form as Thought

Both Coleridge and al-Jurjani reject the “container” model of language. Form is not the vessel of meaning but its manifestation. Paraphrase, by treating words as replaceable, mistakes transformation for translation.

5.4 V. Paraphrase as Discovery

5.4.1 The Critical Turn: From Brooks to Empson

Cleanth **Brooks** warned against “the heresy of paraphrase,” insisting that paraphrase reduces poetry’s complexity to “the real core of meaning.” Yet as McGhee observes, Brooks inadvertently repeats the same error — assuming meaning has a hidden “core” apart from form.

A.C. Bradley corrected this dualism:

> “You can no more separate form and substance than you can separate living blood and the life in the blood.”

Meaning *is* form-in-motion, “the order of disclosure upon which the poem depends” (George Oppen).

5.4.2 William Empson: Paraphrase as Experiment

In *Seven Types of Ambiguity* (1930), **Empson** rehabilitates paraphrase as an analytic tool. His elaborate expansions of a simple lyric —

“Cupid is winged and doth range;
Her country so my love doth change” —

produce a kaleidoscope of interpretations (“I will love her though she moves to another planet... though she kills me”). Paraphrase, here, does not simplify but **exfoliates ambiguity**.

Mini-Essay — Paraphrase as Performance

Empson’s paraphrase is not explanatory but performative. By restating the line through multiple voices, he dramatizes the poem’s shifting possibilities. Paraphrase becomes a mode of thinking *with* the poem, not over it.

5.5 VII. The Uses and Limits of Paraphrase

Paraphrase can simplify or illuminate depending on how it’s used. As **Peter Lamarque** notes, “specifications of what a poem is ‘about’ come in degrees of fine-grainedness.” We paraphrase differently depending on purpose — a headline need not a sonnet’s precision.

But when paraphrase seeks to reproduce a poem’s *total effect*, **Peter Kivy** warns, it attempts the impossible: it demands equivalence of experience rather than clarity of content.

Mini-Essay — Knowing What We Are Doing

The critic’s task is not to avoid paraphrase, but to use it knowingly. A paraphrase is a *pointer*, not a replacement. It can guide attention, open interpretation, or test understanding — so long as we remember that the poem exceeds it.

5.6 IX. Conclusion: Paraphrase as Critical Practice

McGhee ends by reclaiming paraphrase as an instrument not of reduction but of imagination. When wielded carefully, it clarifies our reading and exposes our assumptions. When wielded crudely, it flattens literature into “information.”

“Criticism,” writes Michel Chaouli, “is not a record of an experience that lies in the past... it is the arena for developing the experience.”

To paraphrase, then, is to participate in that arena — to test our understanding against the language we love.

Mini-Essay — Beyond the Heresy

The real “heresy” is not paraphrase itself but **forgetting why we read**. To translate poetry into prose, to render tone into thought, is an exercise in humility. It reminds us that meaning is not possessed but pursued — a dialogue between language and life.

5.7 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Form <-> Content	Inseparable unity (Bradley, Coleridge)	Paraphrase neglects the dynamic of language.
Voice <-> Silence	Print creates ambiguity (Griffiths)	Reader imagines tone; paraphrase overspecifies.
Meaning <-> Experience	Empson and Phillips	Literature as emotional discovery, not transmission.
Criticism <-> Creation	Chaouli's "arena"	Reading and writing are interdependent acts.
Paraphrase <-> Interpretation	McGhee's pedagogy	Knowing use transforms paraphrase into insight.

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5.9 Introduction: The First Indian Novel in English

Bankimchandra Chattopadhyay's *Rajmohan's Wife* (1864) is often called the **first Indian novel written in English**. Published in *The Indian Field*, a short-lived Calcutta magazine, it appeared at a moment of historical tension — only seven years after the Indian Rebellion of 1857 and three years before the publication of *Durgeshnandini* (1865), his first novel in Bengali.

The novel's position at the intersection of **colonial history, linguistic choice, and genre experiment** makes it a foundational text for understanding nineteenth-century literary globality. It raises questions about what it meant to write a "Victorian" novel from outside Britain, and how the novel form itself became a vehicle for negotiating empire, gender, and language.

Mini-Essay — A Novel Between Worlds

Rajmohan's Wife sits at a threshold: between Bengali and English, between local realism and imported melodrama. Its hybrid form makes visible the cultural labour of writing under empire — a writer working *within* the language of power yet reshaping it from the margins.

5.10 Genre, Form, and the Colonial Novel

5.10.1 The Hybrid Aesthetic

The novel combines **melodrama, realism, and local reportage**, constantly shifting tone and genre. It begins in leisurely realism and ends in sensational haste. The narrative oscillates between omniscient commentary and intimate detail, revealing a consciousness of its own artifice:

“We need not detain the reader with a detail of either the dialogue or the prattle... we will do him the justice to presume he has already some conception.”:contentReferenceoaicite:1

Such self-conscious narration reveals a writer negotiating the conventions of the English novel while testing their applicability to Indian life.

5.10.2 The Sensational and the Real

Like Wilkie Collins or Bulwer Lytton, Bankim employs the tropes of **sensation fiction** — the dungeon, the abduction, the moral scandal. The story’s central triangle of Mahashvini (Matangini), her brutal husband Rajmohan, and her brother-in-law Madhav transforms domestic melodrama into a critique of patriarchal violence.

Yet alongside this are moments of minute realism:

> “His elder brother had wilfully left his inkpot behind... the child’s eyes had fallen on it, and he was joyfully smearing his face with the ink.”:contentReferenceoaicite:2

These glimpses of everyday life — a child’s ink-smeared face, paan stains on walls, light falling on a veranda — create an intimacy alien to colonial ethnography. The novel’s realism is local, sensual, and particular.

Mini-Essay — The Double Texture of Style

The collision of melodrama and domestic minutiae produces what we might call *vernacular realism*: a realism inflected by imported narrative structures but rooted in lived Bengali texture. Bankim turns the foreign form of the English novel into a vessel for regional experience.

5.11 Nation, Empire, and the Texture of Place

5.11.1 The Quiet Politics of Setting

The novel never directly addresses empire, yet colonial power seeps through every detail — from the Irish magistrate who resolves the plot to the European paintings on a zamindar’s wall:

“On the two remaining walls... might be seen arrayed a few specimens of European art, and the exquisite conception of the Virgin and Child.”:contentReferenceoaicite:4

These objects possess “no symbolic weight”; their meaning lies in their indifference. They are relics of colonial presence absorbed into domestic habit.

Mini-Essay — The Empire in the Room

The Virgin and Child hang beneath the Hindu goddesses Kali and Durga, creating an iconographic collage of empire and devotion. Yet the narrator’s detachment — “the inmates... had little knowledge what the artist’s genius had strove to represent” — converts domination into decoration. The colonial object becomes simply another household thing, both sign of power and token of its irrelevance.

5.12 Gender, the Jungle, and the Gothic

The novel’s central figure, **Matangini**, is both heroine and transgressor — a woman who defies her husband’s violence and ventures alone into the jungle at night. The jungle scene is one of the most striking in nineteenth-century colonial fiction:

“At this hour of dread loneliness a young woman would have to thread her way through a wild and jungly path... the knotted trunks of huge trees showed like so many unearthly forms... each leafy bough... she fancied there lurked a demon.”:contentReferenceoacite:6

The passage blends Gothic terror with ecological precision: tamarind trees, reptiles, and night-birds create a sensory realism even as they evoke supernatural dread. Matangini’s escape — hiding in a dark pool, loosening her hair to disguise her pale face — fuses body and landscape.

Mini-Essay — The Feminine Sublime

The jungle scene literalises Edmund Burke’s aesthetics of terror — “whatever is conversant about terrible objects is a source of the sublime” — but through a woman’s body. Matangini becomes both subject and object of the sublime, her agency born from fear. Her immersion in mud and water collapses distinctions between self and environment, purity and pollution, echoing Vaishnava devotional imagery where Radha meets Krishna in the forest.

5.13 Conclusion: The World in a Village

In its hundred compressed pages, *Rajmohan’s Wife* remakes the nineteenth-century novel’s geography. The village of Radhaganj becomes a microcosm of empire, language, and gender. Its worldliness lies not in cosmopolitan sweep but in **intimate provincial depth** — a world literature of the small scale.

Mini-Essay — Provincial Modernity

Where European world literature sought universality through circulation, Bankim achieves it through attention. His realism of mud, paan, and bamboo makes the local world legible without translation. The “first Indian novel in English” thus anticipates later theories of global modernity: the world refracted through the village, the universal born from the provincial.

5.14 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Interpretive Implication
Colonial <-> Vernacular	Writing in the coloniser’s language about local life	Tension between mastery and mimicry; creation of hybrid literary space.
Melodrama <-> Realism	Emotional excess versus domestic precision	Reveals instability of imported form; Indian realism as affective critique.
Empire <-> Everyday	Political power embedded in domestic detail	Decolonial reading of material culture.
Female Body <-> Landscape	Matangini’s immersion in jungle	Gendered rewriting of the sublime; body as ecology.
Translation <-> Originality	Lost English text and re-translations	The novel as a palimpsest of languages; meaning as movement.

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5.16 Introduction: Reading the World through the Moon

This lecture introduces the concept of the **Global Middle Ages**, a framework that challenges Eurocentric narratives of medieval culture by emphasising **interconnection** — cultural, linguistic, and spiritual — across continents. It also focuses on a recurring symbol shared by human societies across time: **the moon**.

From early English verse to classical Japanese narrative, medieval writers imagined the moon as a site of longing, exile, and transcendence. By reading an anonymous **English alliterative poem**, “**The Man in the Moon**” (c.1300), alongside the **Japanese prose tale** *The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter* (*Taketori Monogatari*, 9th–10th c.), the lecture demonstrates how global comparison reframes medieval literature as a world system of imagination, not an insular European tradition (Evans 2025).

Mini-Essay — The Moon as Mirror

The moon becomes a natural metaphor for global literary study: it is both singular and universal, distant yet visible to all. To look at the moon is to participate in an ancient, shared act of imagination — one that reveals how the medieval world was always already global.

5.17 II. Why the Moon?

The lecture chooses the **moon** as an organising symbol because it is one of the few phenomena that unites human experience. Every civilisation has looked at it, measured its phases, and projected myths upon its face. In medieval writing, the moon often symbolises **change, distance, and desire** — themes that also describe the relation between worlds.

As **Edgar Williams** writes, “Virtually every well-known writer has used the moon’s characteristics to set the scene — the romantic moonlit night, the ghostly darkness, or the supernatural full moon” (Williams 2012). **Carol Ann Duffy**, in her anthology *To the Moon and Back*, calls the moon “the supreme image for poets” — a light shared across languages.

Mini-Essay — The Moon as World Literature

To study the moon is to study connection. Its constancy provides a common vocabulary for isolation, exile, and hope. The Global Middle Ages, like the moon, is a way of seeing continuity in diversity: each region reflects the same light differently.

5.18 IV. The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter — Japan, 9th–10th Century

5.18.1 The Earliest Japanese Tale

Across the world, another story of lunar exile was taking shape. **The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter** (*Taketori Monogatari*) is widely considered the **earliest extant Japanese prose narrative**, written in the late ninth or early tenth century. It tells of a moon princess, **Kaguya-hime**, who descends to Earth, is adopted by an old bamboo cutter and his wife, grows into a woman of transcendent beauty, and must eventually return to her celestial home.

Her suitors — princes and nobles — undertake impossible quests to win her hand: to find Buddha’s begging bowl, a jewel from a dragon’s neck, a robe of fire-rat fur. All fail. Even the Emperor, who loves her sincerely, cannot prevent her return to the moon.

5.18.2 Exile in Reverse

Unlike the English legend, where a mortal is exiled *to* the moon, Kaguya-hime is exiled *from* it. She belongs to the celestial realm but is sentenced to inhabit Earth — a reversal that transforms punishment into tenderness.

As she tells her earthly parents:

“When I look at the moon, the world seems lonely and sad. How could I live without gazing at it?”

Her sorrow prefigures the poem’s tragic climax: when the moon people arrive to reclaim her, she dons a feather robe that erases her memory of Earthly love. The Emperor receives her parting gift, the **elixir of immortality**, but refuses to drink it, burning it on a mountaintop — said to be the origin of *Mount Fuji* (literally “immortal fire”).

Mini-Essay — The Exile of Return

The tale reverses the Christian paradigm of fall and redemption. Here, exile from the perfect world (the moon) becomes the condition for discovering love, mortality, and compassion. To return to perfection is to lose feeling. Earth, though “filthy,” is the only place where tenderness exists.

5.18.3 Performance and Symbolism

Richard Okada notes that *Taketori Monogatari* employs a theatrical style of narration, alternating between omniscient prose and direct dialogue, echoing oral storytelling traditions (Okada 1991). The moon thus becomes both stage and spectator — the story’s invisible audience.

The princess’s impossible tasks draw upon a syncretic mix of **Buddhist, Daoist, and Shintō** motifs: the begging bowl (ascetic renunciation), the jewel (imperial power), the robe (purity and transformation). As **Jonathan Stockdale** observes, the tale “reverses the logic of empire”: the Emperor’s authority fails before the moon’s gentle transcendence (Stockdale 2014).

Mini-Essay — The Politics of the Celestial

The tale’s moon-world exposes the limits of human order. Against courtly ambition and masculine conquest, it posits a feminine otherworld governed by sincerity and detachment. Kaguya-hime’s refusal to marry becomes a political act — a withdrawal from patriarchy and power.

5.19 VI. Conclusion: Reading Across Worlds

By juxtaposing an English lyric and a Japanese prose romance, we discover that medieval literature was never provincial. Its imaginative horizons already extended across oceans. The **Global Middle Ages** does not homogenise difference; it reveals how similar desires — for connection, redemption, and home — manifest through diverse mythologies.

The man in the moon strains to hear the Earth’s voice but cannot. The moon princess yearns to stay on Earth but must forget. Between them lies the tragedy of all human relation: to love what we cannot reach.

Mini-Essay — The Ethics of Distance

To read globally is to embrace distance, not abolish it. Comparison is not conquest but conversation. Like the moon, literature reflects light that comes from elsewhere — reminding us that every culture illuminates the others.

5.20 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Local <-> Global	Medieval stories as part of a world system of imagination	Global Middle Ages situates regional myths in a shared symbolic order.
Human <-> Divine	Movement between earth and moon	Articulates moral order and hierarchy through celestial geography.

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Punishment <-> Redemption	English exile vs. Japanese return	Opposite moral logics that converge in shared existential anxiety.
Speech <-> Silence	Failed communication across worlds	Symbolises limits of human knowledge and the ethics of listening.
Temporal <-> Eternal	The moon's unchanging light vs. human mortality	Cosmic perspective relativises earthly time; the moon as eternal witness.
Suffering <-> Compassion	Labouring sinner vs. sorrowing princess	Both figures reveal empathy through endurance — universalising pain as moral insight.
Gender <-> Authority	Male punishment vs. female transcendence	Reconfigures spiritual power and gendered agency in global myth.
Center <-> Periphery	Earth as exile or “filthy place”	Inverts anthropocentric assumptions; decentralises human and European dominance.

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5.22 Introduction: Reading the Female Sacred

Dr Ayoush Lazikani situates medieval women’s devotional writing within a **global history of religious imagination**.

The lecture proceeds in three movements:

1. **Julian of Norwich and Margery Kempe** — English exemplars of visionary writing.
2. **Continental mystics** — Marie d’Oignies, Lutgard of Aywières, Gertrude the Great, Catherine of Siena, Teresa of Ávila.

3. **Comparative perspectives** — Islamic Sufis and Hindu Bhakti poets such as Rābiʿa al-ʿAdawiyya, Lallā Ded, and Mīrābāi:contentReferenceoaicite:1.

Her aim is not encyclopaedic coverage but a “**cartography of devotion**”: tracing resonances between women separated by geography, language, and creed.

Mini-Essay — The Gender of Vision

Women’s visionary writing arises within patriarchal structures that restrict authority to men, yet these visions **authorise their speakers**. Ecstasy becomes epistemology: bodily feeling generates theological knowledge.

5.23 II. Margery Kempe (c.1373–after 1438) — The Body in Tears

A lay woman from King’s Lynn, mother of fourteen, and businesswoman, Margery dictated her *Book* to two scribes.

It is both spiritual autobiography and travelogue: pilgrimage to Jerusalem, Rome, and Norwich — where she consulted Julian:contentReferenceoaicite:3.

Margery’s faith is performed through her body. She weeps uncontrollably at the sight of the crucifix or any violence, and her “boisterous weeping” earns public ridicule and charges of heresy.

Mini-Essay — The Devotional Body

Tears are Margery’s text. In an age that denied women learning, she writes in water what men wrote in ink. Her sob translates vision into sound — a sacramental language of feeling.

In one episode she sees a mother nursing her child and bursts into tears, recalling Mary and the infant Christ. Every maternal scene becomes an icon.

Her meeting with Julian anchors her authority: the older anchorite blesses her tears as “the gift of God.”

5.24 IV. Gertrude the Great (1256–1302) — The Heart as Womb

Author of *The Herald of Divine Love*, Gertrude developed the cult of the **Sacred Heart**.

She describes Christ imprinting His wounds upon her heart:

“Thou hadst imprinted in the depths of my heart the adorable marks of Thy sacred wounds.”:contentReferenceoaicite:6

For Gertrude, Christ’s heart beats within her own; she hears its pulse as speech.

Alexandra Barratt likens the heart to a **maternal space**, where the devotee returns to the rhythm of the divine womb.

Mini-Essay — The Heart as Habitation

Gertrude makes indwelling literal: devotion as cardiac architecture. The heart is both cradle and cathedral of the Word.

5.25 VI. Teresa of Ávila (1515–1582) — Pain as Ecstasy

In her *Life*, Teresa describes a vision of an angel piercing her heart with a flaming spear:

“He plunged it into my heart several times so that it penetrated to my entrails... The pain was so sweet that I would not wish it to cease.”:contentReferenceoaicite:8

Gian Lorenzo Bernini’s *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa* (1652) visualises this moment in baroque marble: bodily surrender as divine rapture.

Teresa’s visions of hell also display psychological depth: a furnace of “filthy wet mud” and “wicked reptiles” more terrifying than physical pain.

Hell is not only place but state of mind — separation from God.

Mini-Essay — The Ambivalence of Pleasure

Teresa's spear-wound and her vision of hell mirror each other: both are penetrations of the soul. Pain and bliss become indistinguishable signs of divine intimacy.

5.26 Conclusion: The Global Mystic and the Scholar's Task

Dr Lazikani ends with a call for **comparative reading as ethical practice**.

To place Julian beside Rābi'a, or Margery beside Mīrābāī, is not to erase difference but to **listen across traditions**.

Mini-Essay — Devotion as Dialogue

Comparative mysticism reveals how cultures meet in attention, not assimilation. Each visionary teaches the same method: to see the divine in the other, and the other in the divine.

5.27 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Body <-> Spirit	Tears, wounds, and ecstasy	Physical sensation as conduit to revelation; holiness felt rather than abstracted.
Gender <-> Authority	Female visionaries' speech	Mystical experience grants women rhetorical and theological power otherwise denied.
Private <-> Public	Contemplation and politics	Mysticism as activism; inner transformation reshapes outer order.
Pain <-> Pleasure	Teresa's "sweet pain"	Affective paradox; divine love transcends moral binaries.
Text <-> Performance	Dictation, tears, pilgrimage	Writing as embodied act; emotion as authorship.
Local <-> Global	England and the wider world	Comparative reading reimagines medieval literature as transnational.
Silence <-> Speech	Julian's secrecy, Margery's outcry	Voice negotiated through obedience and excess; speech as revelation.
Friendship <-> Hierarchy	Mīrābāī's Krishna songs	Love as equalising force; spiritual democracy across faiths.

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5.29 Introduction: The Question that Refuses an Answer

Few questions in literary study are more persistent — or more productive — than “What is literature?” Every attempt to define it seems to dissolve into new questions about language, value, imagination, and power. As the lecturer remarks, “It’s hard to imagine a definition of literature that wouldn’t find room for *To be or not to be*. But why?”:contentReferenceoaicite:0

This lecture moves from Shakespeare to Wordsworth, from Beckett to William Carlos Williams, to show how definitions of literature are themselves acts of criticism — each definition is also a kind of reading.

Mini-Essay — The Question of Literature

To ask “what is literature?” is to perform a literary act: to interpret, to weigh form and meaning, to create connections between texts. The category “literature” is not fixed; it is the record of how cultures imagine the power and limits of language itself.

5.30 II. Aesthetic Form and Ethical Value

5.30.1 Literature and the Moral Imagination

From the Romantics to modern critics such as Martha Nussbaum, literature has been celebrated as a **training ground for empathy**. Reading fiction “allows us to feel our way into the lives of others.” George Eliot’s *Middlemarch* does not merely *depict* society; it asks us to *recreate* it imaginatively.

Yet the lecture warns against sentimental assumptions: aesthetically fine books do not automatically produce moral readers. Stalin, after all, annotated hundreds of books daily, scrawling “rubbish” or “haha” in the margins. “A reader who failed to see that it wasn’t only when opening a work of fiction he held other people’s lives in his hands”:contentReferenceoaicite:2.

Mini-Essay — Reading and Responsibility

Literature exercises empathy, but it does not guarantee virtue. The reader’s ethical test is not emotional sympathy but interpretive attention — the willingness to recognise language as action, not ornament.

5.31 IV. What the Dictionaries Don’t Tell Us

The Oxford English Dictionary’s entry for *literature* lists everything from “the realm of letters” to “written work valued for superior or lasting artistic merit.” This breadth exposes the problem: to define literature is to **draw boundaries around a moving target**.

5.31.1 Terry Eagleton and Family Resemblance

In *The Event of Literature* (2012), Eagleton argues that literary definition works less by strict criteria than by *family resemblances* — a concept from Wittgenstein. Works may share traits (fictionality, formal pattern, imaginative depth), yet none is necessary or sufficient on its own.

Mini-Essay — The Family of Words

Literature resembles a family portrait: no single feature defines kinship, but resemblance appears across generations. As with families, resemblance also includes rivalry — a constant rewriting of lineage.

Raymond Williams traced the word’s shifting meaning:

- **14th century**: “polite learning” — literacy as social polish.

- **Renaissance:** shared knowledge — Bacon’s “erudition, divine and humane.”
 - **Romantics:** creativity and imagination — the “secondary world.”
- By the 19th century, literature meant **imaginative writing**; by the 21st, it risks meaning **everything**.

5.32 VI. Language, Use, and the Literary Function

Does literature use language in a “special” way? The lecture suggests two answers.

5.32.1 1. Defamiliarisation — The Russian Formalists

Viktor Shklovsky’s 1917 essay “Art as Technique” argued that art makes the familiar strange: it “defamiliarises” the world, forcing us to see anew. William Carlos Williams’s *This Is Just to Say* performs this by turning a domestic note into a poem — an act of everyday estrangement.

5.32.2 2. Interpretive Communities — Stanley Fish

Fish’s famous classroom experiment (*Is There a Text in This Class?*, 1980) revealed that meaning depends not on textual properties but on **the expectations of readers**. A list of names becomes a “religious poem” once readers believe it is one.

Mini-Essay — Literature as Agreement

Literature is not a property of language but of *attention*. The literary arises when readers choose to read as if something were literature. The poem, the play, the shopping list — all depend on the interpretive act.

5.33 VIII. Work and Play: Two Modes of Literature

Drawing on Seamus Heaney’s *The Redress of Poetry*, the lecture concludes with a twin model.

5.33.1 1. Literature as Work

Literature **does things**: it acts, persuades, and reshapes ideology. Like a delayed “speech act,” it changes the world indirectly — *Uncle Tom’s Cabin* inspiring abolition, Goethe’s *Werther* provoking suicides. For Marxist critics like Sartre or Macherey, literature reveals hidden structures of power.

5.33.2 2. Literature as Play

Tom Stoppard said, “Art celebrates a world which includes itself.” Literature as play is language freed from duty — “language going on holiday,” in Wittgenstein’s phrase. From Lear’s nonsense to Joyce’s *Finnegans Wake*, such writing re-enchants the medium itself.

Mini-Essay — The Twin Life of Art

The most enduring works do both. Wordsworth’s “*I wandered lonely as a cloud*” is both reflective work and joyous play: a labour of imagination that turns recollection into dancing movement. Its “crowd... host of golden daffodils” is both scene and self-reflection — a mind working and playing at once.

5.34 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Allusion and Echo	Hamlet → Prufrock; Beckett → Shakespeare	Literature as repetition-with-difference.
Family Resemblance	Eagleton via Wittgenstein	Literature as network, not essence.
Canon / Power	Barthes: “what gets taught”	Institutions shape the literary.
Defamiliarisation	Shklovsky; Williams’s <i>This Is Just to Say</i>	Art as renewal of perception.

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Interpretive Community	Stanley Fish's "Jacobs-Rosenbaum"	Reading as social act, not solitary discovery.
Work and Play	Sartre vs. Stoppard	Dual nature of literature's function.

5.35 Exam Relevance

5.35.1 For Oxford Prelims Paper 1B and Paper 3

- Introduces key critical movements (Formalism, Reader-Response, Marxist and Ethical criticism).
- Builds foundation for analysing **form, value, and cultural context**.
- Provides frameworks for essay questions on the definition, function, and ethics of literature.

5.35.2 Model Essay Patterns

1. "Defining Literature: From Family Resemblance to Interpretive Community."
2. "Work and Play: The Two Lives of Language."
3. "Canon and Culture: Who Decides What Literature Is?"

5.35.3 Revision Strategies

- Compare passages (*Hamlet*, *This Is Just to Say*, *Daffodils*) for different models of literary language.
- Trace critical genealogies — from De Quincey's "literature of power" to Eagleton's "event."
- Practise defining literature in a single sentence — then rewrite it five different ways.

6 Own Notes

What it is? How it works? Does it matter?

- allusion both is and is not its original → involves both sameness and difference
- writing by individuals for a larger group of people
- "or" - a model of tolerance and balance → a sort of ethical values conc. in literature rather than everyday life
- "sea of troubles" - ambiguity allows hamlet to take a cliché and rips → use words in a way that gives them new life

what makes literature? - aesthetic form and patterning? - cultural longevity? - expression ethical values? - writers often argue that morality is often closely associated with imagination because it allows us to imagine other's life - "...allows us to rehearse..." - *Middlemarch* doesn't only depict society but encourages us to recreate it in a more nuanced form - BUT aesthetically good ≠ morally good - "make it new"? - a way of refreshing old forms of speech - Beckett *How it Is* - "that's not said... interest"

- when describing literature, one is more likely to come up with theoretical rather than empirical details (e.g. fictional, human experience etc.) [[Eagleton]]
 - less like criteria, more like family resemblances → relationships rather than a set of fixed objects that are always open to expansion
 - some resemblances are strong, looser or non-existent

- // to critical approaches to lit
 - lit as a category that is inherently fuzzy and ever-changing - that in defining something you constrain it
 - the answer of “what is literature” is in between the various debates of this topic
 - in the disagreements and agreements
1. History of the word Literature
 - [[Raymond Williams Keywords]], ” a difficult word”
 - 14th century - polite learning
 - Renaissance - Lit began to take on a sense of shared body of knowledge
 - [[Francis Bacon]]
 - Romantics - narrowed down Lit to mean creative writing, especially poetry as opposed to factual knowledge ==> shift from dissemination of imagination - exercise of imagination (world as it is to the secondary world the writers dreamt up)
 - Literature of Knowledge vs Literature of Power
 - Lit as a special category for writing that has special qualities
 - modern critics have argued that lit has returned to its modern roots of meaning anything
 - argues that Literature should be broadened and democratized to escape the idea that some works are “better”
 - Lit is not just descriptive but evaluative, to be bound up in hierarchical
 - selection involves rejection
 - Thus, to choose everything as literature and therefore not to choose anything
 - Literature as a loose synonym of Culture -> anything that can be expressed in any form,
 2. Literature is “what gets taught” -> centres on the “Canon” - writing that’s been elevated to ‘classic’ status - “canon wars”
 - if lit is a form of linguistic representation, should it not pay homage to social representation, should the canon not reflect the diversity of the society
 - *Harper’s Magazine*, *Arthur Krystal*

Rudyard Kipling - crucial pivot between the Victorian age and modernism

“writers themselves often decide which of their predecessors they want to exist with” (On criticism at the present time)

William Carlos Williams, *This is Just to Say* - does literature use language in a special way? - distract words from their usual burden of representation - usually language has a referential/pragmatic function -> - resists being read as a poem at all, internal echoes that never quite settle in, flirting with literary structures but never truly committing - a poem that struggles with its twin, a non-poem/anti-poem

[[Stanley Fish, How to recognize a poem when you see one]] - Literature not a body of writing but a set of social agreements - judgement of an interpretive community - primed to read it as a poem but because there are other poems in which one eats a poem, feels guilty and means otherwise (Milton’s *Paradise Lost*)

Literature is a complex word - shifting boundaries probably tell us as much about ourselves as they do about writing - what literature means involves us trying to puzzle out what we mean by literature - what we need the concept for and what we hope to get from it

- “The address of Poetry Seamus”
1. Literature as a form of Work
 - Work of literature, what does it do?
 - can have an instrumental function - like a speech act (“I now pronounce you husband and wife”) it can do something in the act of saying it -> not as immediate can produce a delayed response

- reveal ideological structures that are floating around in everyday speech - to prepare the ground for revolutionary action rather than words
 - Russian formalists - to make us look again at everything we thought we already knew
2. Literature as a form of Play
- Playwright Tom - Art celebrates a world which includes itself
 - Language going on holiday - they do re-enchant the medium of writing itself - a response to the world as an irresponsible one
- the most celebrated work does both at once (Wordsworth, 'Daffodils')

7 Transcript

![[CORE Lectures_ Introduction to Literature - PRE3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom).txt]]

8 Files

![[PAPER 1 - What is Literature 2025 handout.docx]]

9 Cleaned Up Notes

9.1 Literature and History: Context, Temporality, and Reading Across Time

9.1.1 Oxford Prelims Paper 1B – Core Lecture

9.2 I. Scales of Context

Moshenska asks: how large or small can context be?

- **Micro**: biographical details — age, gender, class.
- **Meso**: institutions — the university, the city, the nation.
- **Macro**: historical epochs — capitalism, empire, “the internet age.”

A writer may be unaware of these frameworks, yet they structure her imagination. Contexts are always **multiple** and **partly unconscious**. The author is not necessarily “the best arbiter” of her own contexts (Jameson 1981).

9.3 III. From New Criticism to New Historicism

9.3.1 The Reaction Against Autonomy

The **New Critics** (e.g. Cleanth Brooks, W.K. Wimsatt, R.P. Blackmur) treated poems as self-contained “well-wrought urns.” New Historicists rejected this autonomy, insisting that texts are **sites of social energy** rather than sealed aesthetic objects (Brooks 1947).

9.3.2 Stephen Greenblatt and the “Circulation of Social Energy”

Stephen Greenblatt’s work reframes literary texts as participants in cultural flows — political, religious, economic — a project most concentratedly argued in *Shakespearean Negotiations* (1988) and *Practicing New Historicism* (Greenblatt 1988; Gallagher & Greenblatt 2000).

His essay “Invisible Bullets” begins not with Shakespeare but with a spy’s note reporting Marlowe’s heresies; from there he links Elizabethan espionage, exploration, and theatrical politics in a series of associative readings (Greenblatt 1988).

Mini-Essay — The Anecdote as Method

The anecdote embodies the New Historicist belief that history’s meaning is dispersed, not hierarchical. A court record, a travel diary, a play: all transmit the same “social energy.” The critic’s task is to trace these invisible currents rather than to prove causation (Gallagher & Greenblatt 2000).

9.3.3 Limits of the Method

Moshenska notes that this levelling of text and context sometimes re-established old hierarchies: canonical authors (Shakespeare above others) remained central, and broad claims about cultural “circulation” risk reproducing the periodisation New Historicism claimed to critique (Moshenska 2025; Greenblatt 1988).

9.4 V. Case Study: John Donne’s “*The Relic*”

To illustrate these theories, Moshenska turns to Donne’s *The Relic* (c.1611) — a poem obsessed with time, resurrection, and misrecognition.

“*When my grave is broke up again, / Some second guest to entertain...*” (Donne, *The Relic*)

The speaker imagines his bones exhumed, mistaken for saintly relics. Donne’s conceit fuses the **earthly and eternal**, the **sacred and profane**. Historically, relics were contested in post-Reformation England; Donne, who converted from Anglicanism to Catholic-adjacent practices before his Anglican ordination, knew the religious stakes. A historicist reading is valuable, but the poem also stages a deeper **temporal experiment**.

Relics themselves are *objects out of time* — decayed matter imbued with new significance. Donne’s poem mimics this paradox: it survives as a relic of language, a body of words animated by successive readers (Donne c.1611).

Mini-Essay — The Poem as Relic

The Relic enacts what it describes. It is unearthed by each generation, reinterpreted, mistaken, adored. Its temporality is “pleated”: future, present, and past intertwine. To read it is to take part in the miracle of its misrecognition (Donne c.1611; Serres 1995).

Donne’s later prose (*Devotions upon Emergent Occasions*, 1624) makes this temporal anxiety explicit: “Before you sound that word *present*, or that monosyllable *now*, the present and the now is past” (Donne 1624). For Donne, as for Serres, time itself is unstable — a vanishing instant.

9.5 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Context / Text	Milton’s notion of sacred textuality; modern theorists	Context as both internal texture and external network.
Historicising	Jameson’s “two paths”	Reading as historical action; the critic as subject of history.
Social Energy	Greenblatt’s <i>Shakespearean Negotiations</i>	Literature as participant in cultural power.
Polychronic Time	Serres, Latour, Donne	Texts as multi-temporal folds, not linear products.
Chrononormativity	Freeman, Dinshaw	Temporal order as social discipline; anachronism as resistance.
Afterlife	Felski’s “busy afterlife”	The text’s continued agency beyond its origin.

9.6 Exam Relevance

For Paper 1B (Introduction to Literature and History):

- Develops conceptual precision about *context*, *periodisation*, and *temporality*.
- Encourages critical reflection on what it means to “put a text in context.”
- Provides frameworks for analysing historical theory (Jameson, Greenblatt, Serres, Latour, Felski).

9.6.1 Model Essay Patterns

1. **“Always historicise!”** — Discuss Jameson’s two paths of historicising and their implications for literary study (Jameson 1981).
2. **“Every historical era is multitemporal.”** — Explore Serres and Latour through a reading of Donne’s *The Relic* (Serres 1995; Latour 1993; Donne c.1611).
3. **“The busy afterlife of the literary artefact refutes our efforts to box it into a moment of origin.”** — Evaluate Felski’s claim using examples from premodern or modern texts (Felski 2015).

10 Own Notes

11 Transcript

![[CORE Lectures_ Introduction to Literature - PRE3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom)-2.txt]]

12 Files

![[Prelims 1B Literature and History Handout.docx]]

13 Cleaned Up Notes

13.1 Measured Language: Metre and Meaning in English Poetry

13.2 Classical and Philosophical Origins

13.2.1 Plato's Quarrel with Poetry

Plato, in *Republic* X, dismissed poetry as “three removes from reality,” a copy of a copy, a seductively painted shadow. Yet his critique betrays awe as much as suspicion. He saw in **metrical language a power of enchantment** — “a brightly coloured web, a spell” capable of charming its hearers into false belief (Plato 1993).

Plato's anxiety rests on metre's dual nature: it **binds sound to sense**, but also separates them. The rhythmic allure of verse can seem to detach meaning from rational control, letting words “trifle on the ear” while bypassing the intellect. Yet in recognising this, Plato also identifies poetry's cognitive force: its capacity to **make thought memorable by patterning it**.

Mini-Essay — From Plato to Sidney

The Platonic suspicion of rhythm as intoxication is countered by Sir Philip Sidney's defence of poetry as ethical seduction: “Even as the child is often brought to take most wholesome things by hiding them in such other words as have a pleasant taste.” Metre becomes a **sweetened medicine**, where pleasure and instruction fuse. The poem's measured form gives moral gravity to delight — not a distraction from truth, but its most persuasive form (Sidney 2002).

13.3 What Is Stress? The Physics of Rhythm

To study metre is to study **stress** — the dynamic interplay of emphasis, pitch, and duration. English verse, unlike Latin or Greek, is built not on syllabic quantity but on the pattern of stressed and unstressed beats.

Linguists distinguish several types of stress:

1. **Lexical stress** — fixed within words (e.g. *blackbird* vs *black bird*).
2. **Prosodic stress** — formed through syntax and emphasis within sentences.
3. **Focal stress** — used to alter meaning through emphasis (*I went OUT* vs *I went out*).

Stress, therefore, is not a single acoustic property but a **composite effect** — involving loudness, pitch, and duration (Dasgupta 2025). In performance, stressed syllables are often slightly lengthened, louder, and higher in pitch, but none of these features alone defines them.

Old English verse organised its rhythms by **patterns of stress and pitch**, not by syllable count. Modern English preserves traces of this system: the sense that meaning resides as much in emphasis as in words themselves.

Mini-Essay — Stress as Syntax

In a line such as “*The things which I have seen I now can see no more*” (Wordsworth, *Ode: Intimations of Immortality*, 1807), stress falls not simply by grammatical rule but by emotional weight. The crescendo of accent mirrors the loss the line mourns. Metre, in this sense, is a **syntax of feeling**: a system by which emotion finds measurable form (Wordsworth 1807).

13.4 The Passion of Metre

Wordsworth's 1804 letter on reading aloud speaks of two kinds of “passion” — that of the subject and that of the metre. The end of a verse line invites pause, not because sense demands it but because rhythm does. The **metrical beat imposes affect**; it turns mere syntax into experience.

This “passion of metre” is a phenomenon of perception: the way the ear feels form. Even when we no longer scan consciously, rhythm moves us. It carries what Wordsworth called the “still, sad music of humanity” — the measured trace of feeling rendered intelligible through recurrence.

Mini-Essay — The Double Passion

The line’s music does not simply echo emotion; it **creates it**. The reader’s breath, constrained by rhythm, enacts the poem’s drama. To read “*The world is too much with us; late and soon*” is to perform frustration in the very compression of stress. Metre becomes **an emotional machine**, generating sympathy through repetition (Wordsworth 1807).

13.5 The Fall of Metre: Free Verse and Modern Speech

By the early twentieth century, poets began to **abandon traditional metre**, embracing “free verse.” The phrase itself, as shown by digital corpus studies, scarcely existed before 1914; it then “shoots to prominence” (Dasgupta 2025). What had long been the norm became a mark of conservatism. To write in sonnets or strict measure could even, by the 1970s and 80s, be interpreted as politically reactionary — an allegiance to “Reaganism,” as critics jested.

Yet the impulse behind free verse was not a rejection of rhythm but a **redefinition of it**. Modern poets sought the “natural music” of speech, the rhythms of conversation and breath. In this sense, free verse continues the logic of Wordsworth’s blank verse — measured by the “real language of men.”

Mini-Essay — Freedom’s Measure

Free verse is not formless; it measures by **pulse, not pattern**. The ghost of metre persists even in its absence. Each irregular line testifies to an inherited discipline, an echo of constraint. As Meredith Martin argues, the “literary movements around the time of the First World War... erased a vast history of debates about versification.” To recover metre, then, is not antiquarianism but archaeology — uncovering the lost grammar of our listening (Martin 2012).

13.6 Historical Continuity: From Old English to Modern Speech

Even as pronunciation and stress patterns have changed, the instinct for **metrical order** remains. Old English alliterative verse, Chaucer’s iambs, Shakespeare’s pentameters, and modern oratory all trace the same human need: to give emotion a body through rhythm. Metre thus belongs neither to an era nor a school; it is a **cultural constant**, periodically rediscovered.

Some linguistic changes have rendered older metres less “natural” to modern ears, perhaps contributing to the rise of free verse. Yet our daily speech still pulses with metrical possibility. Nursery rhymes, advertising slogans, and protest chants retain the **ancestral beat** of verse: the rhythm of belonging and memory.

13.7 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Interpretive Implication
Form <->	Metre transforms emotion into pattern	Rhythm is the bridge between passion and articulation.
Feeling		
Sound <->	Words “trifle on the ear” yet convey truth	Aesthetic pleasure becomes moral persuasion.
Sense		
Freedom <->	Poetic discipline versus	Art as negotiation between necessity and choice.
Restraint	expressive liberty	
Speech <->	Oral tradition in written form	Metre preserves orality within print culture.
Writing		
Memory <->	Tradition as resource for modernity	Even free verse remembers its metrical ancestry.
Innovation		

Axis	Relationship	Interpretive Implication
Philosophy <-> Poetry	Plato's suspicion versus Wordsworth's defence	Metre as battleground between truth and beauty.

13.8 Conclusion: The Measure of the Human

To speak of metre is to speak of **the human need for pattern** — to find measure within chaos, to make emotion audible. From Plato's suspicion to Wordsworth's reverence, from Dante's rhyme-chains to King's oratory, metre persists as a way of thinking through rhythm. It is both structure and surprise, rule and revelation. The poem measures language so that language may measure us.

Mini-Essay — The Enduring Beat

Even when poets declare themselves free of metre, they remain haunted by its ghost. Rhythm is the oldest inheritance of speech — our first music. To listen for it is to join a lineage that stretches from chant to sonnet to sermon. In learning to hear metre, we learn to hear ourselves.

14 Own Notes

metre

- measured language

14.1 Why does Metre matter?

“even as the child is often brought.... as have a pleasant taste” “is poesy dwelling in a nice culled sound or soft smooth words that trifle on the ear” “do they not said i resemble the faces of adolescents young but not really beautiful, when the bloom of youth abandons them?” - Plato and his ideas of representation on Poetry (the deeper manipulation of sound with sense, the ability of words to modify rules of language but also additional rules that make it memorable, transmissible and incorruptable -> metre was a very important device to transmit information)

- some metrea also acts as restraints
 - dante's rhyming is not only a narrative device but a powerful restraint on textual corruption (aba, bcb, cdc etc.) - a terset cannot be corrupted by a scribe without setting off a kind of metrical alarm

Wordsworth's system of scansion (EY, 434) - when you come to an end of the word you will naturally speak it a little differently

“let us not wallow in the trenches of despair”

before the 20th century, the writers almost never deliberately strayed from metre

in reality there are degrees of stress iambic pentameter - is not just unstressed, stress, but actually Shakespeare's writing is sometimes split into 6-4 “So long as men can breathe (implied caesura here) or eyes can see,”

14.2 what is stress

- added emphasis on particular syllables on a line
- old English poetry is based on patterns of stress/accents but also pitch changes and duration changes (same syllables can be stressed in modern and old English but could have been performed differently, different way of stressing words)
- stressed syllables have clear, but composite, acoustic correlates

- length/duration (a phoneme is the smallest unit of speech distinguishing one word from another)
 - bit vs beat
- intensity/loudness (not phonemic)
- pitch/pitch change (not phonemic)

1. lexical stress on words

- belonging to individual words (only words of more than one syllable)
- two syllable words are usually trochaic when they are nouns (proper, common, compound)
 - *blackbird* vs *black* bird
 - *greenhouse* vs *green* house
- two syllable verbs have the opposite pattern
 - *present* vs *present*
 - *record* vs *record*
 - *torment* vs *torment*
- ==> minimal pair: a pair of words that differ by only one sound (phoneme) but have different meanings

2. prosodic stress

- produced by grouping words together into a compound, phrase or sentence
- this is the only way in which monosyllables become stressed
 - The *things* which *I* have *seen* I *now* can *see* no *more*
- When we build up sentences, the stress clumps towards the end (nuclear stress rule), as more is added, the stress builds up and up
 - So long lives this, and this gives life to thee.
 - I went OUT.
 - I went Out to the SHOPS.
 - I went out to the Shops this MORN
 - I went out to the Shops this morning to buy a Cake
 - The *things* which i have **seen** i now can see **no more**.
- once the crescendo breaks, new sentence/significant clause
- focal stress: emphasis can alter the ordinary stress pattern of a phrase
 - Crow is by TED Hughes
 - to someone assuming it is a written by HUNGSTEN hughes

14.3 Sonnet 42

15 Transcript

![[Metre - PRE 1 & PRE 3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom).txt]]

16 Files

- 17 Cleaned Up Notes
- 18 Own Notes
- 19 Transcript
- 20 Files

21 Cleaned Up Notes

22 Own Notes

- Print separates a voice from its body
 - punctuation helps to restore what the printed page removes
- 2 ways to think about punct
 - syntactic - divides up a piece of writing into grammatical units that help to make sense of the scatter and drift of words on the page
 - elocutionary(?) - shows us where to pause, in order to reproduce the sounds of the author's voice, pacing, emphasis etc. -> see source 2
 - face 3 problems
 - a lot can happen between the act of writing and a piece of published writing
 - different writers have diff expectations when it comes to punctuating their work
 - mark twain was vv precise
 - but wordsworth was vv happy for other people to correct his punctuation
 - punctuation is often ambiguous
 - fullstop and comma, directed primarily towards the ear
 - bracket is directed primarily towards the eye
 - some depends on creative tension between eye and ear - line endings in verse (repeatedly asking us whether the end of line is the end of thought)
- speech vs print
 - punctuation is often bound to much larger ideological questions of what we can or cannot say
 - Who is writing for?
 - earliest punctuation is the paragraph
- individual patterns of speech vs shared rules of grammar
 - punctuation reveals tension btw the individual and a group
 - the writers voice vs the shared conventions of print
 - punctuation can reflect social rules and an individual's thought
- punctuation is a good way to assess the rewards and risks of connecting ideas/people to each other
- punctuation has no intrinsic semantic value; it only connects

Dashes: - Laurence Sterne - unique way to reproduce the narrator's voice as he changes his mind, delay revelations etc. - Emily Dickinson's poem - suggests distant horizons - type of friendship - lifelines - more symbolic - ==> indicates how tightly a writing sticks to/cracks of logic/writing

- *to see how a punctuation works, try to replace it with a conjunction
- punctuation as an indication of tone and sense

23 Transcript

24 Files

![[Handout 3 Practising Criticism (MT 2025).pdf]]

25 Cleaned Up Notes

26 Own Notes

4Ms of poetry 1. Movement (syntax, line breaks, structure etc.) 2. Music (rhyme meter, pacing, etc.) 3. Message (meanings, descriptive content, tone, etc.) 4. Magic (iykyk)

26.1 Introduction: Beyond the Iamb

In previous lectures Dasgupta examined the iambic line as the foundation of English verse.

This lecture turns to **non-iambic metres** — trochaic, dactylic, anapaestic — and to **rhyme** as their companion structure:contentReferenceoacite:0.

The argument throughout is that metre and rhyme are not decorative but conceptual: they shape how meaning, grammar, and emotion move through time.

Mini-Essay — Why Other Metres Matter

English verse has privileged the iamb because its two-beat alternation mirrors the rhythm of speech and heartbeat.

But, as Dasgupta notes, “non-iambic metres place greater constraints on expression,” forcing poets to invent new syntactic patterns to fit new rhythmic possibilities:contentReferenceoacite:1.

The difficulty of such metres becomes their expressive resource.

26.2 II. Free Verse and the Politics of Form

Dasgupta contrasts the fixity of metre with the ideological claims of **free verse**.

For **Ezra Pound**, rhythm should be “a man’s own — his own counterfeiting on counterfeit bills.”

Richard Aldington called free verse “the cadence a poet creates for himself,” while **D. H. Lawrence** likened metrical regularity to “drill sergeants barking orders.”

These poets justified formal freedom as **political freedom** — a rebellion against what Aldington called “childish formality.”

Yet Dasgupta cautions that the binary between individuality and constraint is false: “metrical poetry already contains variation; free verse depends on inherited rhythm even when it denies it”:contentReferenceoacite:4.

Mini-Essay — Liberty and Law

Every free-verse line is haunted by its iambic ancestry.

The poem that rejects metre must still answer its ghost — an act of rebellion that confirms what it resists.

26.3 IV. The Imperative Metre: Donne and Auden

John Donne’s “Go and catch a falling star” (c.1600) uses the same trochaic-dactylic compound pattern. Its rhythm, half-command, half-lullaby, sets impossible tasks:

“Go and catch a falling star, / Get with child a mandrake root...”

Each stanza truncates its last line — again *catalectic* — producing what Dasgupta calls “open-ended sound suggestive of falling away”:contentReferenceoacite:7

The poem’s cynicism about constancy is softened by the meter’s sing-song charm.

W. H. Auden’s “Lullaby” (1937) reworks the same pattern:

“Lay your sleeping head, my love, / Human on my faithless arm.”

Dasgupta highlights the **chain of imperatives** (“lay,” “sleep,” “let”) that link Auden to Donne.

Both use falling rhythm to voice tenderness shadowed by loss.

The metre’s unresolved cadence mirrors erotic transience — what Dasgupta calls “temporal impoverishment”: every lullaby is also elegy:contentReferenceoacite:8.

Mini-Essay — Falling Rhythms, Falling Worlds

Because the trochaic line ends unstressed, it always falls away.

Its motion figures impermanence — the erotic, the mortal, the incomplete.

Donne’s misogynist wit and Auden’s homoerotic tenderness share that formal melancholy.

26.4 VI. Dactylic Memory: Hardy’s “The Voice”

In **Thomas Hardy’s “The Voice”** (1912) the dactylic rhythm turns elegy into echo:

“Woman much missed, how you call to me, call to me...”

Each line drops two syllables at the close, leaving a hollow cadence.

The missing beats become the sound of absence itself — “as if the poem listens into its own silence,” Dasgupta writes:contentReferenceoacite:10.

Seamus Heaney, in *Poems That Make Grown Men Cry* (2014), singled out Hardy’s last stanza as almost physically painful:

the line “Can it be you that I hear?” breaks metre at the instant of recognition and doubt.

Mini-Essay — Meter as Mourning

Hardy’s dactyls translate grief into breath: the regular pulse falters, mimicking the body’s attempt to call the lost.

Metre becomes memory’s measure — the beat that persists when words fail.

26.5 VIII. The Gender of Rhyme

“Masculine” rhymes end on stress (*stand/land*); “feminine” on an unstressed syllable (*feather/weather*).

Critics once echoed Milton in calling rhyme effeminate — “petticoats for Achilles.”

Dasgupta notes the persistence of this gendered metaphor: formal looseness equated with moral weakness.

Mini-Essay — Rhyme and Gendered Labour

Feminine rhyme, with its surplus syllable, performs excess — the decorative “extra” that patriarchy devalues.

Yet poets from Byron to Auden reclaim it as wit, proving that ornament can outthink austerity.

26.6 Conclusion: Constraint and Invention

Dasgupta ends by reframing metre and rhyme not as restrictions but as **creative conditions**.

Each pattern — iambic, trochaic, dactylic — carries its own epistemology, a way of feeling time and truth.

Mini-Essay — The Ethics of Pattern

“To write in metre,” Dasgupta concludes, “is to accept rhythm as responsibility.”

The poet obeys the past only to discover new motion within it.

Freedom, paradoxically, depends on form.

26.7 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Metre <-> Meaning	Form generates emotion and knowledge	Rhythm not as vessel but as argument; time itself becomes theme.
Pattern <-> Deviation	Variation within rule	Expression found in breaking expectation; beauty as controlled disobedience.
Colonialism <-> Aesthetics	Longfellow’s imitation of “Native” chant	Metre as instrument of cultural power and appropriation.

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Gender <-> Ornament	Feminine rhyme and “decoration”	Revaluation of surplus syllable as wit, not weakness.
Freedom <-> Inheritance	Free verse versus traditional metre	Every innovation haunted by its formal ancestry; rebellion validates the rule.
Memory <-> Sound	Hardy’s elegiac dactyls	Metre as temporal persistence; grief measured by recurrence.
Constraint <-> Responsibility	Dasgupta’s closing statement	Poetic discipline as moral stance: form teaches care and patience.

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26.9 Introduction: The Fugitive Form

This lecture introduces students to the critical reading of **drama and performance**, exploring how these two interrelated forms generate and communicate meaning.

Its central question: *why do we need both terms?*

A **play** can mean either a written script or a live event. Yet neither can fully exist without the other. The written play is incomplete without its embodiment in performance; each performance, in turn, realises only one of the infinite possibilities latent in the text:contentReferenceoacite:1.

The play is thus a **fugitive form** — forever escaping fixity between writing and staging, script and event.

Mini-Essay — The Incomplete Object

Drama’s ontology is double. The text exists in time as a book but also in space as gesture, sound, and light.

Reading drama therefore means reading *potentiality*: words awaiting incarnation, and bodies awaiting interpretation.

26.10 II. Eric Bentley's Formula

In 1960, theatre theorist **Eric Bentley** proposed a minimalist formula:

> “A impersonates B while C looks on.”:contentReferenceoaicite:3

This formula captures theatre's triangular relationship among actor (A), character (B), and audience (C). It reveals that drama differs from other literary forms because its meaning arises **between** participants, not solely from language.

Bentley's model foregrounds two verbs:

- “**Impersonates**” — implying artifice, imitation, play.
- “**Looks on**” — suggesting spectatorship, passivity, and judgement.

Mini-Essay — The Triangular Contract

Theatre's power emerges from reciprocity.

The actor lends body to fiction; the audience lends belief.

Meaning flickers in the interval between seeing and knowing it is false.

However, Bentley's formula has limits:

- What if C is not a single spectator but a crowd?
- Where does the playwright (the absent “D”) fit?
- How do set, light, and architecture mediate the exchange?

To answer these, the lecture introduces two critical frameworks: **semiotics** and **phenomenology**.

26.11 IV. Beyond Words: Architecture and Framing

Martin Esslin, another semiotician, argued that a sign must be *recognised* as such; therefore, theatre's **frame** is crucial.

Framing signs include: theatre architecture, lighting before the curtain, programmes, and advertising.

A *proscenium arch* theatre (e.g., the Royal Opera House) separates audience and stage, elevating the spectacle.

An *open or thrust stage* (e.g., the National Theatre's Olivier) creates intimacy but also distance through scale.

A *black box* theatre, by contrast, produces immediacy and risk, minimising hierarchy:contentReferenceoaicite:6.

Mini-Essay — Architecture as Argument

The building itself makes meaning: gold gilt asserts exclusivity; bare brick signals democracy.

To read performance is to read its architecture — every frame is ideology made visible.

Early modern theatres like the **Globe** differed radically: open-air spaces, shared light between actor and spectator.

Modern indoor theatres, darkening the auditorium, isolate the audience and focus attention.

The **frame of light** thus alters the play's social contract: who sees whom, and who can look back.

26.12 VI. Metatheatre and Semiotic Play — *The Two Gentlemen of Verona*

In Shakespeare's *Two Gentlemen of Verona*, the servant Launce performs a mock farewell using shoes and a hat to represent his family:

“This shoe is my father... This shoe with the hole in it is my mother... this staff is my sister... and I am the dog.”:contentReferenceoaicite:8

Launce's comic confusion dramatizes representation itself: props stand for people; the actor for character.

The scene becomes **metatheatrical**, a play about playing.

Mini-Essay — The Fool as Theorist

Launce's farce literalises semiotics. He tests what a sign can mean and how resemblance collapses into absurdity.

Shakespeare’s clown becomes a proto-theorist, parodying the logic of representation while revealing its emotional truth.

The gag also externalises emotion. Launce’s muddled symbols express homesickness more vividly than introspective monologue:
selfhood, Shakespeare suggests, is defined by our external relations, not interior essence.

26.13 VIII. The Phenomenology of the Dog

In *The Two Gentlemen of Verona*, Launce’s dog Crab “steals the show” precisely because he does **nothing**. The animal, unaware of acting, disrupts illusion.
A yawn or tail wag becomes delightful because it is *real*.

Mini-Essay — The Reality Effect

The dog reveals theatre’s paradox: we applaud authenticity in the midst of artifice.
Performance succeeds not by perfect imitation but by the friction between fiction and fact.

The living dog thus exposes the limits of Bentley’s formula: A does not impersonate B; sometimes A simply *is* A while C looks on.
Phenomenology reminds us that **presence itself** can create meaning beyond representation.

26.14 X. The Binocular Vision: Combining Semiotics and Phenomenology

States recommends “**binocular vision**”: reading performance through both systems at once.
Semiotics reveals how meaning is constructed; phenomenology shows how it is *felt*.
Together they account for both theatre’s **intelligibility** and its **affect**.

Mini-Essay — Reading with Two Eyes

One eye analyses the stage as sign; the other attends to the body’s response.
Drama lives in the oscillation between intellect and sensation — a double vision of meaning and feeling.

26.15 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Theatrical Triangle	Eric Bentley’s “A impersonates B while C looks on”	Defines theatre as triadic relationship between actor, character, and audience.
System of Signs	Keir Elam’s semiotics; Kane’s <i>Phaedra’s Love</i>	Every element of staging becomes signifier; the stage read as text.
Silence and Gesture	Opening of <i>Phaedra’s Love</i>	Non-verbal meaning as structural language; the eloquence of inaction.
Architecture and Frame	Proscenium, thrust, and black-box stages	Spatial form as ideological argument; theatre design produces social meaning.
Actor as Iconic Sign	Jude Law’s <i>Hamlet</i> ; casting across gender and race	The actor’s body carries semiotic weight beyond text; performance redefines identity.
Metatheatre	Launce’s speech in <i>Two Gentlemen of Verona</i>	Drama reflecting on its own mechanisms; the clown as theorist of representation.
Phenomenological Presence	Bert O. States; the dog Crab	Reality within fiction; material presence as surplus meaning.
Embodied Perception	<i>King Lear</i> ’s Dover Cliff	The body as truth beyond illusion; proprioception defeating representation.
Binocular Vision	Combining semiotics and phenomenology	Balanced criticism integrating structural analysis and lived experience.
Ethics of Attention	Final conclusion	The critic’s role as observer-participant; reading theatre as act of care.

26.16 Exam Relevance

26.16.1 Core Relevance to Prelims Paper 3 (1830–1910)

- Introduces key frameworks for **drama and performance analysis**.
- Bridges **literary reading** and **theatrical experience** — essential for essays on nineteenth-century theatre, realism, and modern performance.
- Equips students to analyse both **scripts** and **staging** in Paper 3 questions.
- Encourages awareness of **historical and spatial context** — the politics of the playhouse.

26.16.2 Analytical Skills

- Using **semiotic vocabulary** (sign, signifier, code, frame).
- Reading **stage directions**, **silence**, **gesture** as textual evidence.
- Recognising the **actor’s body** and **architecture** as integral to interpretation.
- Balancing **critical theory** with personal response — semiotics and phenomenology combined.

26.16.3 Model Essay Patterns

1. “**All theatre is an act of translation — from page to body.**”
— Discuss using semiotic and phenomenological frameworks.
2. “**Theatre is the art of the instant.**”
— Explore ephemerality and presence in *King Lear* and modern drama.
3. “**Every stage is political.**”
— Analyse how theatre architecture shapes meaning from the Globe to Kane’s black box.
4. “**Meaning is felt as much as read.**”
— Examine the relationship between sign and sensation in performance.

26.16.4 Revision Strategies

- Practise close-reading **stage directions** as poetry.
- Compare multiple productions of a scene — how semiotic choices change meaning.
- Remember **Bentley’s triangle** and **States’s binocular vision** as exam anchors.
- Watch recordings of modern adaptations to attune your **phenomenological eye**.

End of Notes — “Introduction to Literature: Reading Drama and Performance.”

27 Own Notes

28 Transcript

![[CORE Lectures_ Introduction to Literature - PRE3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom)-3.txt]]

29 Files

30 Cleaned Up Notes

30.1 Metre IV: Blank Verse, Syntax, and Sound

30.1.1 Ushashi Dasgupta — Oxford Prelims Paper 1 & 3 (2025)

30.2 I. The Line as Punctuation

30.2.1 From Syntax to Segmentation

Whereas the previous lecture treated the line as a **unit of rhythm**, here it becomes a **unit of grammar** — “a secondary punctuation system laid over the first” (Dasgupta 2025).

Every poem negotiates between **syntactic segmentation** (phrases, clauses, sentences) and **metrical segmentation** (line, caesura, stanza).

Giorgio Agamben, glossing Valéry’s claim that poetry is a “hesitation between sound and sense,” argued that this friction — between sentence and line — is the only sure criterion separating poetry from prose.

Mini-Essay — The Friction of Forms

The poetic line arises from tension between natural and artificial pause. It creates two intersecting systems — syntax (sense) and metre (sound). Meaning occurs not where they coincide, but where they **diverge**.

Dasgupta shows that poetic feeling depends on this divergence:

- A thought that runs **past** its metrical limit creates overflow (enjambment).
- A thought that ends **too soon** creates shock (caesural truncation).

Neither effect exists in prose.

30.3 III. Syntax and Sound: Milton, Inversion, and the Weight of Order

30.3.1 Inversion and Blank Verse

The lecture then returns to **Milton’s *Paradise Lost***, specifically the line:

“But look, the morn, in russet mantle clad.”

Grammatically inverted, it would read in prose as “But look, the morn clad in russet mantle.”

Why invert? Because poetic English prioritises **phonological rhythm over syntactic order**.

Gilbert Youmans, in his work on inversion, claims poets only invert when metre demands it.

Dasgupta disagrees: “Poets choose inversion not out of necessity but desire — to sound heightened, distant, or strange.”:contentReferenceoaicite:1

Mini-Essay — The Poetic Right to Disorder

In English prose, syntax outranks sound. In verse, this hierarchy reverses: phonology rules meaning.

Poets use inversion not as error but as elevation, making the ordinary dramatic.

Dasgupta compares Milton’s inversions to those in prose translations from the same period — notably Nicholas Caussin’s *Treatise on the Motives to Christian Perfection* (1653):

“If we be unknown to God, we must make ourselves known to Him by some good virtue.”

Here syntax remains modern; the grammar is ordinary.

Milton’s inversions therefore signal poetry’s distinctive logic — **sound outranking syntax**.

30.4 V. Wordsworth and the “Blessing in This Breeze”

Dasgupta next reads **Wordsworth’s opening to *The Prelude* (1850 version)**:

“There is a blessing in this gentle breeze,
That blows from the green fields and from the sky...”

He calls this one of the strangest English openings: delayed subject, overqualified clauses, and withheld agency.

The line begins with the dummy “There is,” postponing revelation.

The syntax accumulates prepositional phrases (“from the green fields and from the sky”) before yielding to emotion.

Mini-Essay — The Poise of Beginning

Wordsworth’s delay is philosophical: thought outpaces grammar.

The poet begins with uncertainty — a sentence “askew, like an old-fashioned scale before the weights are applied.”

This postponement enacts Romantic hesitation — the belief that truth arises through process, not statement.

Dasgupta dissects the sound patterning: the repeated *b* in “blessing” and “breeze,” the long vowels, the sibilant endings (*-ing*, *-ze*).

This alliteration and assonance create “patterns of call and response” — the poem listening to itself.

He compares this to the later echo:

“The earth is all before me.”

This line, Dasgupta notes, “alludes metrically as well as lexically” to Milton’s *Paradise Lost*:

“The world was all before them, where to choose / Their place of rest.”

The borrowing is not just verbal but metrical: a **seven-syllable run** followed by caesura. Wordsworth’s blank verse inherits Milton’s music even as it reinterprets exile as freedom.

30.5 VII. Learning to Hear: Memory and Influence

The lecture closes with a meditation on **learning metre**.

Dasgupta warns students that “verse is a language best learned young — like a mother tongue.”

He quotes Wordsworth’s letter to a younger poet:

“If you have not practised metre in youth, I should apprehend that your thoughts would not easily accommodate themselves to those chains.” (Wordsworth, *Letter to Catherine Godwin*, 1829)

Mini-Essay — The Discipline of Habit

Metre, like grammar, becomes second nature through repetition.

The poet who internalises rhythm early can later “move under it with grace and spirit.”

The untrained adult, by contrast, “writes iambics as a foreigner speaks French — fluently but without idiom.”

Dasgupta concludes with Gerard Manley **Hopkins**, who claimed of *The Wreck of the Deutschland*:

“I had long had haunting my ear the echo of a new rhythm which I now realised on paper.”

For Hopkins, novelty was **haunting memory** — a new rhythm emerging from echoes of the old.

Mini-Essay — Metre as Memory

Even the most radical poets build from what they’ve memorised.

Reading and recitation are the apprenticeship of rhythm.

The mind’s ear, not the page, is where poetry lives.

30.6 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Sound <-> Syntax	Collision between auditory rhythm and grammatical logic	Poetic thought arises from the meeting point of noise and meaning.
Visual <-> Auditory	The page's shape vs. the ear's pattern	Modern verse foregrounds the <i>visible</i> line as artistic choice; metre as typography.
Freedom <-> Tradition	Free verse indebted to iambic regularity	No poetic freedom without an inherited order to react against.
Empathy <-> Technique	Williams's measured care	Formal decisions carry ethical consequence: rhythm embodies attention.
Memory <-> Innovation	Hopkins's new rhythm from old echo	Creativity as recursive hearing; progress built on recollection.
Authority <-> Experiment	Milton's inversions, Keats's revisions	Control and error both generate discovery; imperfection as invention.
Philosophy <-> Form	Wordsworth's delayed syntax	Grammar as metaphysics; hesitation as mode of thought.
Discipline <-> Delight	"Nutritious" study of metre	Poetic training as both moral labour and pleasure of mastery.

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30.8 Introduction: At the Edge of the World

The early medieval English lived at what they imagined to be the **outer edge of the earth**, geographically peripheral yet intellectually central. From 410 CE, when Rome withdrew its legions, to the Norman Conquest of 1066, the British Isles became a place of **constant movement — of peoples, languages, and faiths**.

This lecture traces the earliest phases of that transformation: from Roman ruins to Anglo-Saxon settlements, from pagan myth to Christian revelation, and from orality to writing.

Mini-Essay — A Culture of Looking Both Ways

Early medieval England looked outward and backward at once. These islanders, "hungry for imported knowledge," searched in every direction — north to Scandinavia, south to Rome, east to Jerusalem, and backward to their own pagan past:contentReferenceoacite:0. Their literature is a mirror of migration: it preserves what moves.

30.9 II. Migration: The Coming of the Saxons

30.9.1 Gildas and the “Adventus Saxonum”

The Welsh monk **Gildas**, writing c. 550 in *De Excidio et Conquestu Britanniae*, blames the arrival of the Germanic tribes on British sin:

“They sealed their doom by inviting among them, like wolves into the sheepfold, the fierce and impious Saxons.”:contentReferenceoaicite:2

His narrative is **moral, not historical** — a theology of punishment. The Saxons are not colonisers but scourges sent by God.

30.9.2 Bede’s National Vision

Two centuries later, **Bede’s *Ecclesiastical History* (731)** transforms this catastrophe into the founding of a Christian nation. He names the **Angles, Saxons, and Jutes** as ancestors of all English peoples — East Angles, Mercians, Northumbrians — giving England its first myth of unity:contentReferenceoaicite:3.

30.9.3 Acculturation, Not Erasure

Archaeology suggests coexistence, not genocide. The Celtic Britons and Germanic newcomers intermingled — a process of **acculturation**, where languages and burial customs blended:contentReferenceoaicite:4.

Mini-Essay — The Myth of Purity

Later nationalists reimagined this mingling as racial conquest. John Richard Green’s *Short History of the English People* (1892) declared that “English history begins with the landing of Hengest.” Modern white-nationalist rhetoric still invokes “Anglo-Saxon values” to exclude others:contentReferenceoaicite:5. Yet the real early England was never pure — it was, from birth, hybrid.

30.10 IV. Conversion: Pagan to Christian

30.10.1 The Missionaries

- **Irish Missions in the North (Iona, 563 CE)**
Celtic monks like St Columba embraced *ascetic isolation* — the desert in the sea.
- **Roman Missions in the South (Augustine, 597 CE)**
Sent by Pope Gregory the Great to convert King Æthelberht of Kent, they offered not conquest but continuity.

Gregory’s policy of conversion was gradual: “*Do not destroy the temples, but cleanse them with holy water.*” Pagan sites were repurposed, not erased:contentReferenceoaicite:8.

30.10.2 Vision and Conversion

Eusebius tells of Emperor Constantine’s vision: “*By this sign you shall conquer.*” Centuries later, *The Dream of the Rood* rewrites that vision from the cross’s perspective:

“*It seemed to me that I saw a wondrous tree, wound round with light, the brightest of beams... not the gallows of the wicked, but the tree of victory.*”

The poem fuses heroism with faith: Christ climbs the cross as a **warrior-king**, transforming Roman execution into Germanic triumph:contentReferenceoaicite:9.

Mini-Essay — The Hero as Redeemer

Conversion does not abolish the heroic code; it sanctifies it. In *The Dream of the Rood*, Christ is both victim and conqueror, merging pagan courage with Christian humility — the cross as battlefield and altar alike.

30.10.3 Augustine and the Word “Angles”

Bede recounts Gregory’s punning revelation: seeing fair-haired English slaves in Rome, he exclaimed, “*Not Angles but Angels of God they are.*” Wordplay itself becomes prophecy: language as a tool of salvation.

30.11 VI. Rewriting the Past: Beowulf and Christianisation

Though *Beowulf* recounts pagan legend, its poet writes as a Christian moralist. The hero dies seeking “the judgement of the steadfast in truth.” Tolkien called it “a poem from a pregnant moment of poise... faith in the value of doomed resistance”:contentReferenceoacite:11.

Mini-Essay — Between Two Worlds
Beowulf balances on a theological threshold. Its monsters are pagan, its ethics Christian; its elegy for doomed glory becomes the elegy for the old world itself. The poet’s nostalgia is the birth of history.

30.12 VIII. Synthesis: From Pagan Earth to Christian Heaven

By 700 CE, the English imagination had absorbed the classical, Germanic, and Christian worlds. The result is a literature of **transformation**:

- Ruins turned to moral allegories.
- Smiths became saints’ metaphors.
- Warriors became martyrs.
- The runestone became the cross.

Mini-Essay — A Culture of Conversion
Conversion in early England was not a single event but a habit of thought: the continual translation of the old into the new. Every poem, every object, every faith gesture is an act of turning — from stone to spirit, from exile to home.

30.13 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
History <-> Myth	Bede vs. Gildas	Writing as moral interpretation, not fact.
Pagan <-> Christian	<i>Beowulf</i> , <i>Dream of the Rood</i>	Conversion as poetic synthesis.
Oral <-> Written	Runic inscription → manuscript	Transition from memory to text.
Gender <-> Authority	Hild and Cædmon	Monastic women as patrons of art.
Exile <-> Belonging	Irish monks, <i>Deor</i>	Identity through wandering.

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30.15 Introduction: Reading at the Edge of Worlds

The *Early Medieval Literature* paper spans an immense chronological and linguistic range — from the earliest Old English poetry of the seventh century to the emergence of Middle English and Anglo-Norman culture by the fourteenth. The period witnesses extraordinary transformations in language, belief, and identity. Its literature — written, carved, and sung — records how people at the periphery of Europe imagined their place in a world of shifting powers.

Mini-Essay — The Edge as Origin

Early English writing emerges from contact zones: between orality and literacy, pagan and Christian, native and foreign. Its peripherality is its defining feature. What we now call “English literature” begins as a literature of crossings — of seas, of tongues, of gods.

30.16 II. Old English, Old Norse, and the North-Sea World

30.16.1 Contact and Exchange

Old English and Old Norse are sister languages — both West Germanic, mutually intelligible like modern Danish and Norwegian. Their speakers mingled in trade, settlement, and war. From the Viking Age (793–1066), the British Isles formed part of a *North Sea cultural zone*, a world of shared stories and symbols.

Old Norse, though never written down in England, profoundly shaped English vocabulary and place-names:
- **Place-names:** *-thwaite* (“clearing”), *-by* (“farm”), *-gate* (“street”).

- **Loanwords:** *window, law, sky, knife, skirt*, and even the pronouns *they, them, their* — a rare instance of grammatical borrowing:contentReferenceoaicite:1.

30.16.2 The Battle of Maldon: Dialect and Identity

The poem *The Battle of Maldon* (c. 1000) preserves a speech by a **Viking messenger** who demands tribute from the English earl Byrhtnoth:

“Brave seafarers have sent me to you... It’s better for you to buy off this spear-rush with tribute than to face such fierce battle.”:contentReferenceoaicite:2

Linguistic evidence — words like *eorl* (OE *nobleman*, cf. ON *jarl*), *snelle* (OE *quick*, ON *brave*), and *grið* (ON *truce*) — suggests the messenger may be speaking English with a Scandinavian accent, making this the earliest known use of **dialect in English literature**.

The poem’s cast also embodies cultural fusion: Anglo-Saxon *Ælfere* fights beside the Dane *Maccus*; Wulfstan’s son bears the Norse name *Vésteinn*. Ethnic identity, like language, is fluid — an interlacing of English and Norse loyalties.

Mini-Essay — The Politics of Mixture

The *Maldon* poet writes in a world where invader and defender are kin. His “English” heroes have Scandinavian names; his Viking’s speech sounds half-English. The poem turns war into a dialogue of shared tongues — a battle fought as much in language as in arms.

30.17 IV. Conquest and Cultural Transformation

30.17.1 1066 and After

The **Norman Conquest** brings linguistic and cultural revolution. French replaces English as the language of court and law; Latin remains the language of learning. England, once northern-looking, is pulled south into continental Europe.

Key turning points:

- 1096–99: *The First Crusade* — violence recast as sanctified; Christian warriors could now achieve salvation through battle.
- 1215: *Magna Carta* — the idea of **just kingship under law**, a distinctively English political myth:contentReferenceoaicite:5.

30.17.2 The Changing Image of God

- **Old English Christianity** (*The Dream of the Rood*): Christ as warrior — “The young hero stripped himself, strong and resolute.”
- **Later Middle English piety** (*Stond wel, moder, under rode*): Christ as suffering son — “Mother, now I will tell you: if I do not die, you go to hell; I suffer death for your sake.”:contentReferenceoaicite:6

This shift marks the rise of **affective piety** — devotion through shared emotion and compassion, a theology of feeling.

Mini-Essay — The Tears of Power

Early medieval art made God the strongest warrior; later medieval devotion made him the most wounded. Both figures answer the same question: how can divine power enter human pain? The transformation from strength to suffering is the spiritual conquest of the Middle Ages.

30.18 VI. Interiority and the Self

The late medieval period brings a new attention to the **inner life** — from public penance to private confession.

- *Ælfric’s Lives of Saints* (c.995): “True contrition and penance... washes us again from sins.”
- *Ancrene Wisse* (c.1225): “Confession must be accusatory, bitter with sorrow, whole, naked...”
- *Richard Rolle, Form of Living* (1340s): Love is inward, “in the will verrailly, not in work.”:contentReferenceoaicite:7

This movement from external act to inward intent — from fasting to feeling — marks the birth of psychological selfhood in Western literature.

30.19 VIII. The Arc of the Period

From *The Dream of the Rood* to *Havelok the Dane*, early English literature traces a thousand-year meditation on faith, identity, and language:

- **From** pagan heroism → **to** Christian humility.
- **From** exile and survival → **to** law, order, and inheritance.
- **From** Old English verse → **to** Middle English romance.

Mini-Essay — Continuity Through Change

Despite conquest after conquest — Viking, Norman, French — English writing persists by absorbing its conquerors. The language that once borrowed *they*, *them*, *their* now claims the world’s words as its own.

30.20 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Pagan <-> Christian	Continuity and conversion	Literature mediates moral transition.

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Oral <-> Written	Riddles, inscriptions, manuscripts	Memory and monument as twin forms.
North <-> South	Beowulf's Denmark → Norman France	England's shifting cultural compass.
Public <-> Private	Penance → Confession → Selfhood	Emergence of individual conscience.
Masculine <-> Feminine	Warrior Christ <-> Weeping Mary	Compassion redefines strength.

30.21 Reference List (MHRA Style)

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30.22 Introduction: From Conversion to Conquest

By the eighth century, early medieval England stood at the intersection of peace and peril. The conversion of the pagan kingdoms had ushered in a “**golden age of Christian learning**”, marked by figures like Bede, Aldhelm, and Alcuin, and by monastic centres such as Lindisfarne and Whitby. Yet this fragile stability would soon be shattered by a new wave of invaders — the **Vikings**, or *Northmen* — whose raids reshaped the spiritual and political landscape:contentReferenceoaicite:0.

The lecture traces how kingship, faith, and culture responded to these crises — from the **law codes of Æthelberht**, the **abbesses of Whitby**, and **Cædmon's Hymn**, to the Viking onslaught and the **rise of Alfred the Great**. Together, these moments reveal how Old English literature both commemorated and critiqued the making of a Christian nation.

Mini-Essay — England Before England

The eighth and ninth centuries show England imagining itself for the first time. The very word *Angelcynn* — “the English kindred” — unites formerly warring peoples through shared faith and language. Yet unity emerges only through crisis: invasion, conversion, and the struggle to define righteous kingship.

30.23 II. Law, Order, and Gender: The Code of Æthelberht

30.23.1 The Earliest English Law

King **Æthelberht of Kent** (early 7th century) issued the first known written law code in English — the earliest document composed in the vernacular after conversion. Influenced by Roman missionaries, it codified a Christian social order grounded in hierarchy and restitution rather than revenge.

Central to the code is **wergild** (*wer* = man, *gild* = price) — the financial value assigned to a life. Injury or killing required payment, not blood-feud.

Mini-Essay — From Blood to Law

Christianity redefined vengeance as sin and justice as economy. By transforming wrath into compensation, the law recasts violence as order — a moral as well as social reform.

30.23.2 Women and the Law

Women appear frequently in the code, though always in relation to men — as wives, daughters, or property.

- “If a man lies with another’s wife, he shall pay her *wergild* and procure a second wife for the injured husband.”

- “An unmarried woman receives the same compensation as a freeman.”

These clauses expose both constraint and protection: women’s value is acknowledged only through male ownership, yet compensation rates imply social recognition.

Mini-Essay — Gender and Ownership

Æthelberht’s code inscribes patriarchy into law, but it also documents women’s economic existence. The paradox of protection and possession will echo throughout medieval Christian discourse on virtue and chastity.

30.24 IV. Wealth, Wisdom, and the World: Sutton Hoo and the Heptarchy

30.24.1 A Cosmopolitan England

The burial mound at **Sutton Hoo** (c.620) reveals a kingdom of global reach. Gold-inlaid helmets combine Scandinavian and Roman motifs; silver spoons come from Byzantium; bitumen traces from Syria; coins from Francia. Such treasures mark an elite culture trading across continents.

Mini-Essay — The Syncretic Imagination

The artefacts of Sutton Hoo reflect a people in translation. Pagan artistry, Christian symbology, and imperial aesthetics coexist — material proof of a culture reimagining itself through exchange.

30.24.2 The Heptarchy

By the 8th century, Britain was divided into seven principal kingdoms — **Northumbria, Mercia, East Anglia, Essex, Kent, Sussex, and Wessex** — collectively termed the *Heptarchy*. These realms fought for supremacy; the title “**Bretwalda**” (wide-ruler) denoted a king whose power extended beyond his borders.

This political fragmentation forms the backdrop to much Old English poetry: laments like *The Wanderer* mourn not only personal exile but the disintegration of the hall-world — the dissolution of kin, lordship, and memory.

30.25 VI. Alfred the Great: Warrior, Scholar, King

30.25.1 Alfred at War

In **878**, the Vikings overran Wessex, driving the young **King Alfred** into hiding. Yet Alfred regrouped, reclaimed his lands, and established a network of fortified *burhs* (towns). The *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* commemorates 886:

“That same year King Alfred occupied London, and all the Angelcynn turned to him.”:contentReferenceoacite:3

This marks the first recorded political unity of “the English people.”

30.25.2 The Alfredian Renaissance

Alfred’s greatness lies as much in intellect as in arms. In the preface to his translation of **Gregory the Great’s *Pastoral Care***, Alfred laments the decay of learning:

“So completely was learning fallen... there were very few south of the Humber who could understand their divine services in English.”

He interprets the Viking devastations as divine punishment for neglecting wisdom and urges renewal through education.

Mini-Essay — The King as Translator

Alfred's translation project — rendering Latin works into English “that we can all understand” — embodies his philosophy of kingship: to rule is to teach. His kingdom's survival depends not only on walls and swords, but on *wordcraft*.

30.25.3 The *Æstel* and the Gift of Knowledge

Each copy of *Pastoral Care* sent to a bishopric contained an *æstel* — a pointer or stylus “worth fifty mancuses” — symbolising the transmission of wisdom. The **metrical epilogue** likens this knowledge to living water:

“He said that he desired that ever-living waters would flow forth in the world... Some restrain wisdom's stream within the mind's enclosure... Others allow it to disperse in streams across the country.”

The metaphor fuses learning, faith, and kingship: the king as conduit of divine truth.

Mini-Essay — The Flow of Wisdom

Alfred's wellspring of learning redefines the relationship between the sacred and the political. Knowledge, like grace, must circulate — deep and still within the soul, yet freely shared across the land.

30.26 VIII. Conclusion: Kingship and Continuity

From the pagan shrines of *Beowulf* to Alfred's *Pastoral Care*, early medieval literature charts the transformation of authority from **heroic might to moral wisdom**. The poet, the abbess, the monk, and the king all participate in this cultural reinvention: an England born of translation — linguistic, spiritual, and political.

Mini-Essay — The Making of the English Mind

The story of invasion and kingship is ultimately one of synthesis. The warrior becomes scribe; the hall becomes church; the sword becomes stylus. Out of ruin and renewal, the English imagination discovers its first enduring form.

30.27 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Interpretive Implication
Pagan <-> Christian	Conflict and synthesis	Old forms sanctified into new meaning.
Violence <-> Law	From feud to code	Justice redefined through literacy and faith.
Gender <-> Power	Abbesses and queenship	Women as cultural intermediaries.
Wisdom <-> Warfare	Alfred and Edmund	True kingship unites intellect and courage.
Exile <-> Belonging	<i>The Wanderer</i> , <i>Pastoral Care</i>	Earthly loss reframed as spiritual homecoming.

30.28 Reference List (MHRA Style)

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30.29 Introduction: From Reform to Ruin

This lecture concludes the *Old English in Context* series by tracing English literary production from the **Benedictine Reform** of the tenth century through to the **Norman Conquest** and its aftermath (Burns 2025). It explores how a culture of monastic learning and royal stability gave way to political collapse, ethnic violence, and linguistic transformation.

The period between **959** and **1100** witnessed dramatic change:

- The consolidation of the **West Saxon kingship** under Edgar and Æthelred.
- The **renewed Viking incursions** and shifting loyalties within England.
- The **Saint Brice's Day Massacre** (1002) and Danish retaliation.
- The **Battle of Maldon** (991) and the literature of loyalty and failure.
- The rise of **Danish and Norman rulers**, culminating in 1066.
- The survival of **Old English poetics** into an Anglo-Norman world.

Mini-Essay — History as Continuity and Copying

Burns begins by reminding students that Old English texts are often preserved in **eleventh-century copies** of much earlier works. "Why copy Beowulf in the 10th or 11th century?" she asks. Each act of copying reveals not nostalgia but *continuing meaning*: how later monastic scribes repurposed heroic poetry to understand their own turbulent age.

30.30 II. Kingship and the Idea of Peace

30.30.1 Edgar "Pacifcus" — The Peacemaker King

Under King **Edgar the Peaceable (r.959–975)**, England experienced rare stability. Yet "peaceable" (*pacifcus*) should be read, Burns stresses, as "**peacemaker**", not pacifist — peace enforced by violence.

Edgar's reign exemplified **Christian kingship fused with Germanic heroism**. A short poem in the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* commemorates his coronation at Bath in 973:

"Edgar, ruler of the Angles, was consecrated with great ceremony
In the ancient city the Romans called Aquae Sulis [Bath]...
A thousand winters from Christ's birth had passed save seven and twenty."

The poem blends **Christian millennialism** and **Germanic poetic diction**: alliterative half-lines, formulaic epithets ("ruler of men"), and temporal numerology.

Mini-Essay — Syncretic Sovereignty

The Bath coronation poem fuses **three legitimising lineages**: the divine rule of Christ, the imperial grandeur of Rome, and the dynastic succession of Wessex. Its martial lexicon sanctifies priests as warriors — "a *heap* of monks," Burns notes, invoking the Old English *heap* (army). Christian worship becomes a continuation of the heroic past.

30.31 IV. The Saint Brice's Day Massacre (1002)

In 1002 Æthelred ordered the execution of all Danes in England — an event the *Anglo-Saxon Chronicle* defends as necessary.

“The King ordered that all Danes be killed on St Brice’s Day because he had learned that they conspired to kill him and his counsellors.” (*ASC* s.a. 1002)

A royal **charter** further justifies the killings:

“All the Danes who have sprung up in this island, sprouting like cockle among the wheat, were to be destroyed by a most just extermination.”

The charter’s horror lies in its rhetoric: **metaphor as moral cover**. The Danes become weeds, their murder “a just extermination.”

Archaeological evidence corroborates the event: a **mass grave of 37 men** discovered on land owned by St John’s College, Oxford, in 2008, carbon-dated to c.1000–1020. The bodies — mostly young males with sword wounds — likely victims of the massacre (Burns 2025).

Mini-Essay — Language of Erasure

The Saint Brice’s Day decree performs linguistic violence before physical. “Sprouting like cockle among the wheat” dehumanises the Danes into agricultural blight. The rhetoric anticipates the justifications of modern genocide — moral purification by extermination.

30.32 VI. The Wolf’s Sermon: Archbishop Wulfstan’s *Sermo Lupi ad Anglos*

Delivered c.1010–1016, Wulfstan’s *Sermon of the Wolf to the English* (*Sermo Lupi ad Anglos*) laments national sin and divine retribution:

“Beloved men, recognise what is true: this world hastens to its end, and the longer it lasts, the worse it will be... For many years now the devil has led this nation too far astray, and there has been little loyalty among men.” (Wulfstan, *Sermo Lupi*)

Wulfstan interprets Viking devastation as **God’s punishment for disunity**. Burns emphasises its performance context: rhythmic prose, repetitive vocatives (*leofe men*), and escalating syntax designed for orality.

Mini-Essay — Sermon as Social Mirror

Wulfstan’s “Wolf Sermon” translates catastrophe into theology. By turning defeat into divine judgment, he preserves meaning amid ruin. The text’s urgency — its “rhythmic hammering of guilt” — anticipates later apocalyptic preaching.

30.33 VIII. Instructions for Christians — Learning as Moral Duty

The final Old English poem copied in the twelfth century, *Instructions for Christians* (Cambridge, UL Ii.1.33), is a didactic text urging the wise to teach before death:

“He who may learn and will not, is hateful to God...
The hidden good is not wholly good if it is concealed.”

Its verse is rhythmically uneven, more rhymed than alliterative, marking the **dissolution of Old English poetics**.

Mini-Essay — The Ethics of Learning

Burns ends by reading this humble poem as a parable for students themselves: knowledge is a form of stewardship. “If you can learn and choose not to, you are in trouble,” she jokes — but the message is serious. Old English literature ends not in conquest but in **pedagogy**: the persistence of wisdom amid linguistic change.

30.34 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Pagan <-> Christian	Continuity of diction and imagery	Anglo-Saxon poetic form sanctified into Christian theology.

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Heroic <-> Monastic	Byrhtnoth vs. Ælfric	Conflict between martial and contemplative ideals of virtue.
Ethnic Identity <-> Empire	“Bone and blood” → “cockle among the wheat”	Invention of Englishness through exclusion of the Danish Other.
Violence <-> Peace	Edgar’s “peacemaking” through threat	Kingship legitimised by military display; paradox of pacificus.
Copying <-> Creation	Manuscript culture and survival	Acts of transmission as reinvention; copying equals cultural continuity.
Faith <-> Fear	<i>Sermo Lupi</i> and Maldon	Religious interpretation of catastrophe; sin as national narrative.
Old English <-> Anglo-Norman	<i>Rhyme of King William</i> ; borrowed French lexicon	Bilingual poetics as symptom of conquest and creative fusion.
Knowledge <-> Salvation	<i>Instructions for Christians</i>	Education and learning framed as divine duty; wisdom as enduring virtue.

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30.36 Introduction: The Vision of the Cross

Dr Helen Appleton opens the series on the *Old English Set Texts* by situating “**The Dream of the Rood**” within its material, textual, and spiritual contexts:contentReferenceoaicite:0.

The poem survives in one principal manuscript, the **Vercelli Book** (Vercelli, Biblioteca Capitolare, MS CXVII, c.970) — a composite volume of homilies and poems carried, she suggests, by an English pilgrim travelling to Rome:contentReferenceoaicite:1.

The Vercelli Book’s contents are heterogeneous: prose sermons, verse narratives (*Andreas*, *Elene*), visionary fragments (*Soul and Body I*), and homiletic poetry. Its eclecticism resists simple classification as either *homiliary* or *anthology*.

Appleton encourages students to view the Vercelli Book not as random compilation but as a “**pilgrim’s florilegium**” — an ascetic scrapbook of moral and devotional texts offering “the mixed life” (*vita mixta*):

contemplation and teaching intertwined.

Mini-Essay — Manuscript as Theology

The Vercelli Book enacts its own theology of mixture. Homily and poem, Latin and vernacular, prose and verse coexist as spiritual counterparts — an anthology of devotion, not doctrine.

30.37 II. The Monumental Context: Runes and Crosses

30.37.1 The Ruthwell Cross

The *Dream of the Rood*'s earliest echo appears on the **Ruthwell Cross** (8th c.), a monumental stone in what is now Dumfries and Galloway, once Northumbria:contentReferenceoaicite:3.

Runic inscriptions along its vine-scroll borders quote the poem's speaking Cross:

> "Christ was on the Rood... I dared not bow.":contentReferenceoaicite:4

The sculpture's colourful inlay and glass eyes would have dazzled early viewers; it represents a fusion of **text, image, and devotion**.

The inscriptions select only the sections where the Cross speaks, implying early circulation of the poem's core monologue.

Mini-Essay — Sculpture as Scripture

The Ruthwell Cross translates poetry into architecture. Its runes are sermon and ornament at once: the Word literally carved in stone, a tactile theology of incarnation.

30.37.2 The Brussels Cross

Later, the **Brussels Cross** (11th c.) reprises the formula:

> "Drahmal made me. Cross is my name. Once, shaking, I bore a mighty king, blood-bedewed.":contentReferenceoaicite:5

Commissioned by brothers Æthelmær and Æthelwold for Ælfric's soul, its inscription entwines memorial, artistry, and scripture — the speaking object turned liturgical relic.

Mini-Essay — Speaking Objects

Across centuries, the Cross addresses humanity in first person. Such prosopopoeia — "I am the Rood" — transforms wood into witness. The object speaks theology: material redeemed through voice.

30.38 IV. Crosses in the Sky: Visionary Traditions

The dreamer "saw a wondrous tree raised aloft" (*on lyft lædan*, ll.4–5):contentReferenceoaicite:8.

Such celestial crosses recall multiple traditions:

1. **Constantine's Vision** (*Acta Cyriaci*): a cross of light with the inscription *In hoc signo vinces* — "By this sign, conquer.":contentReferenceoaicite:9
2. **Apocalyptic Crosses** in *Christ III* (ll.195–200): "the high rood raised upright as a beacon of power."
3. The **Anglo-Saxon Chronicle (774)**, describing a "red cruciform light" — likely a solar flare — read as divine portent:contentReferenceoaicite:10.

Mini-Essay — The Cross Between Worlds

The celestial cross collapses history: Constantine's triumph, Christ's Passion, the world's end. To dream it is to stand at once in past, present, and apocalypse — time redeemed as vision.

30.39 VI. The Riddling Cross

The Exeter Book *Riddle 30a* speaks in the first person:

> "I am fire-busy, wound about with glory... Proud men and women kiss me.":contentReferenceoaicite:14

Likely answer: *bēam* (tree/cross/beam of light).

Appleton connects this to the *Rood*'s **speaking object** device.

The riddle's erotic and devotional tones prefigure the *Rood*'s fusion of materiality, spirituality, and personhood.

Mini-Essay — Object as Subject

Anglo-Saxon riddles teach readers to perceive holiness in matter. The cross that speaks in riddles prepares the way for the Cross that preaches redemption.

30.40 VIII. The Ending: Harrowing and Hope

The Cross instructs the Dreamer to proclaim the vision, promising salvation for believers.

The poem's close narrates the **Harrowing of Hell**:

"Hope was renewed with glory and joy for those who had endured burning there. The Son was victorious on that expedition..." (ll.148–152):contentReferenceoaicite:18

This scene echoes apocryphal homilies like the *Gospel of Nicodemus*, where Christ descends to hell to liberate souls:contentReferenceoaicite:19.

Mini-Essay — Victory after Descent

The Harrowing rewrites defeat as rescue: descent becomes ascent. The poem's architecture mirrors salvation history — humiliation turning to exaltation.

30.41 X. Reception and Afterlives

Appleton closes with modern reimagings:

- **David Jones**, poet and artist, invokes the *Rood* in *Another Martyr* (1952), translating its visual theology into modernist collage.
- **Laurence Whistler's** engraved glass memorial window (Dorset, 1970s) juxtaposes bleeding and jewelled crosses, visualising the poem's paradox:contentReferenceoaicite:21.

Mini-Essay — The Modern Vision

Twentieth-century artists inherit the *Rood*'s grammar of contradiction — radiant suffering, material transcendence. Its dream still instructs us to see through the gold to the blood, through the past to the present revelation.

30.42 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Pagan <-> Christian	Heroic diction within devotional theology	Continuity rather than conflict; Christian narrative absorbs native idiom.
Object <-> Subject	Cross as speaker	Challenges human-centred theology; agency of material creation.
Ornament <-> Doctrine	Gold as sacrament	Beauty as revelation; aesthetics equated with sanctity.
Dream <-> Reality	Visionary frame	Ambiguous ontology: truth revealed through illusion.
Voice <-> Silence	Prosopopoeia of Cross vs. Dreamer's awe	Speech as divine gift; humility of the listener central to faith.
Authorship <-> Reception	Composite text theory	Medieval copying as creative exegesis; textual layering as tradition.

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Body <-> Spirit	Blood and sap imagery	Incarnation literalised; human and divine fused in organic metaphor.
Local <-> Universal	Ruthwell stone to Italian manuscript	Anglo-Saxon devotion in global Christian continuum; cross-cultural migration.

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30.43.1 The Story of the Story

Henry James, in his *Preface to The Ambassadors* (1909), reflects that his “bag of adventures” as a writer is only half-emptied by telling the story itself; there is also “the story of one’s story.” This self-awareness introduces a major nineteenth-century concern: **fiction’s doubleness** — every novel carries the *story it tells* and the *story of its own making*.

30.43.1.1 Victorian Fiction as a Meeting Point

- Private artistic impulse vs. public form and readership
- History of genre = history of **experiments in narrative voice and structure**
- Fiction = negotiation between **truth-telling and artifice**, or between *realism* and *romance*

30.43.2 Fiction’s Questions: Realism, Romance, and the Art of Fiction

Victorian criticism buzzed with unresolved questions: - What’s the right balance between *realism* and *romance*?
 - Should fiction depict life as it *is* or as it *might be*?
 - Does art cultivate sympathy or selfishness? (*Middlemarch*: empathy vs. private indulgence)
 - Should the novel obey aesthetic rules or represent social truth?

30.43.2.1 The Novel as a Site of Debate Victorian fiction doesn’t just provoke these questions — it **includes** them.

The debates on art, sympathy, and reality unfold *within* the novels themselves, turning them into sites of meta-literary reflection.

30.43.2.2 “On Art in Fiction” → “The Art of Fiction” The shift from Edward Bulwer Lytton’s *On Art in Fiction* (1838) to Henry James’s *The Art of Fiction* (1884) marks a critical evolution: - “In fiction” → art as an ingredient of storytelling

- “Of fiction” → art as the essence of storytelling

Mini-Essay — The Novel Becomes Self-Conscious

By the end of the century, fiction had turned its gaze inward. The novel becomes not just a medium that *contains* art but one that *is* art.

Henry James’s change of preposition encapsulates this transformation: fiction evolves from being a vessel for moral messages to a deliberate construction of perception — a way of *seeing through artifice to truth*.

30.44 Reading, Suspicion, and the Self-Conscious Story

30.44.1 Affection or Infection? — Reading as Moral Crisis

In *Great Expectations* (1860–61), Pip’s letter to Joe — “*MI DEER JO i OPE U R KR WITE WELL...*” — ends with the cryptic “INF XN.”

This phrase can be read as both “**infection**” and “**in fiction**” — a pun encapsulating the moral ambivalence of Victorian reading.

Pip’s narrative splits between: - **Young Pip** — naïve, romantic, longing for elevation.

- **Old Pip** — reflective, chastened, aware of moral contamination.

This double-voiced narrative mirrors the Victorian anxiety that **imagination might corrupt as much as it enlightens**.

Reading was described as both a moral education and a potential sickness. Critics worried that the novel — especially romance — excited the imagination to dangerous degrees, particularly in women readers.

George Eliot, in *The Natural History of German Life* (1856), defends art as “*the nearest thing to life*,” a way of “*extending our contact with our fellow-men beyond the bounds of our personal lot*.”

Yet other commentators (1853–59) warned that novel-reading could cause “*ill health, insanity, and even death*.”

Mini-Essay — Fiction as Contagion

The nineteenth-century novel constantly negotiates this tension: *is fiction a cure or a disease?*

Its power to create sympathy is inseparable from its power to distort reality. Pip’s infection is also his initiation — reading, like storytelling, is the price of self-knowledge. The Victorian novel thus dramatizes a **psychological epidemiology**, where every act of imagination risks contamination.

30.44.2 Style as Thought: Kingsley’s Syntax

Charles Kingsley’s *Alton Locke* (1850) reveals how **form and syntax carry ideological meaning**.

He writes:

> “See what a chaos of noble materials is here — all confused, it is true — polarised, jarring, and chaotic... but only waiting for the one inspiring Spirit to organise and unite and consecrate this chaos into the noblest polity the world ever saw realised!”

The sentence seems on the verge of collapse — dashes fracture it — but those same breaks also **bridge** ideas together.

- Kingsley’s form *enacts* the moral labour of coherence: writing itself becomes an act of redemption.
- The last word, “realised,” resolves not only the sentence but the anxiety of meaning itself.

Mini-Essay — Syntax as Theology

Kingsley's dashes become both fractures and ligatures — typographical metaphors for faith in connection.

His prose performs the drama of thought struggling into order. Victorian style, in this sense, **thinks on the page** — syntax as a spiritual and intellectual choreography.

30.44.3 The Haunted House: Fiction and the Gothic Inheritance

James reworks this metaphor in *The Turn of the Screw* (1898):

the governess enters a “big, ugly, antique, but convenient house” that embodies layers of history — “*half replaced and half utilised.*”

- The Gothic mansion becomes a **palimpsest** — a modern structure haunted by older forms.
- This doubling mirrors Victorian fiction itself: realist surfaces animated by Gothic undercurrents.
- The modern novel acknowledges its ancestry — even when pretending to exorcise it.

Mini-Essay — The Ghost of Genre

In James's fiction, the haunted house stands for the genre's own hauntedness.

Realism never escapes romance; every claim to modernity echoes older mythic forms.

The uncanny, then, is not an intrusion from outside but a **return of the literary repressed** — the persistence of the past within the form of progress.

30.44.4 The Uncanny: Familiar Things Made Strange

Freud's concept of *das Unheimliche* (“the unhomely”) perfectly describes this tension.

Victorian fiction, for all its moral closure, often **renders the familiar strange**.

Dickens, in his preface to *Bleak House* (1853), writes that he has “*purposely dwelt upon the romantic side of familiar things.*”

His description of London's “soft black drizzle,” the “crust upon crust of mud,” and the linguistic degradation of “*Mallard*” for “My Lord” all serve to estrange the everyday.

- The *romantic side of familiar things* is the moment of **defamiliarisation** — the shock of perception that renews vision.
- Art reveals that the ordinary world has always been uncanny, once we look closely enough.

Mini-Essay — Realism as Estrangement

Dickens's realism is not plain mimesis but a **poetics of re-enchantment**.

The familiar is rendered strange so that readers may see it anew — a process of moral awakening through aesthetic surprise.

The uncanny becomes not an exception but the method of realism itself: *to refresh our perception by unsettling what we think we know.*

30.44.5 Parody and Proliferation

With so many writers competing for the same audience, the Victorian age became one of **parody and self-parody**.

Caricature, burlesque, and literary pastiche flourished — the inevitable result of overproduction.

The novel learned to **laugh at itself**.

This self-mockery was also self-preservation: parody became a critical tool, a way of asserting individuality in a crowded field.

It helped fiction to evolve by **testing its own limits**, exposing clichés before they hardened.

Mini-Essay — Irony as Renewal

Parody in the Victorian period is not trivial mockery but a form of critical renewal.

By imitating itself, the novel protects its vitality — burning away convention through laughter.

Irony, then, is realism's immune system: the body of fiction inoculates itself against its own excesses.

30.45 Motif Tracker — Recurring Images and Metaphors

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
House / Home	Henry James's "house of fiction"; Dickens's domestic tableaux	Fiction as moral and perceptual architecture; domesticity as both goal and threat
Fabric / Textile	Bakhtin's "Discourse in the Novel" — the text as woven speech	The novel as a hybrid form interlacing many discourses (dialogism)
Infection / Affection	<i>Great Expectations</i> , Eliot's essays	Fiction as contagion and cure; empathy as both moral virtue and danger
Chaos and Syntax	Kingsley's dashes; Alton Locke	Style as moral labour — syntax turning chaos into coherence
Reading / Dreaming	Egg's <i>Travelling Companions</i> , Leslie's <i>Alice in Wonderland</i>	Reading as creation of private worlds; fiction as mirror of the reader's mind
Ghost / Uncanny	<i>The Turn of the Screw</i> , <i>Bleak House</i>	Realism haunted by romance; the familiar made strange
Labour / Profession	Trollope, the literary market	Fiction as disciplined craft; art as vocation within capitalism

30.46 Exam Relevance — Applying to Oxford Prelims (Paper 3)

30.46.1 Core Skills and Focus Areas

- **Close Reading:** Be ready to analyse *style as argument* — syntax, metaphor, and voice as moral forms.
- **Historical Awareness:** Situate novels within debates about realism, morality, and art (e.g. Lytton vs. James).
- **Comparative Thinking:** Draw links between texts, genres, and critical discourses.
- **Critical Self-Consciousness:** Recognise how fiction comments on its own form — novels as theory in narrative disguise.

30.46.2 Essay Patterns to Practise

1. **Form and Ethics** — e.g. "In what ways does realism involve a moral choice of style?"
 - Compare *Middlemarch* and *Bleak House*: sympathy vs. observation.
2. **The Novel and Self-Consciousness** — e.g. "How do Victorian novels reflect on their own story-telling?"
 - Use *Great Expectations* and *The Ambassadors*.
3. **Home and the Uncanny** — e.g. "Why does the domestic ideal generate unease?"
 - Contrast Dickens's endings with James's haunted interiors.
4. **Art and Labour** — e.g. "Is professional authorship compatible with artistic freedom?"
 - Draw on Trollope and the *Künstlerroman* tradition.

30.46.3 Key Revision Strategies

- Pair **one major realist** (Eliot, Dickens) with **one late stylist** (James, Conrad) to trace the evolution of self-conscious form.
- Annotate **passages where narrative voice fractures** — the double consciousness of narrator and character.
- Practise **mini-close readings** of metaphors of houses, illness, or machinery — these motifs condense Victorian aesthetics.
- Remember the *dialogic* nature of the period: fiction, criticism, and readership form one conversation.

Final Reflection — The Victorian Novel as Thinking Form

The nineteenth-century novel does not merely depict society; it interrogates the act of depiction itself.

It balances moral sincerity with formal innovation, empathy with irony.

Victorian fiction stands at the moment where **art becomes aware of its own thinking**, transforming narrative into a mode of philosophy.

30.47 Introduction: “It Was the Best of Times, It Was the Worst of Times”

Victorian poetry is a literature of **paradox and plurality** — an art of *many voices*. Dickens’s famous opening to *A Tale of Two Cities* (1859) captures the spirit of the age: “It was the best of times, it was the worst of times... we were all going direct to Heaven, we were all going direct the other way”:contentReferenceoaicite:0. This doubleness — the simultaneous pull of belief and doubt, progress and nostalgia — shapes the entire poetic landscape of the nineteenth century.

As *Tennyson’s Ulysses* puts it, the modern world “moans round with many voices” (1842). Victorian poems, like that sea, contain discordant tones: lyric and epic, private and public, faith and scepticism. Their “dialogue of the mind with itself” (Arnold 1853) becomes, as Isobel Armstrong writes, “*the dialogue of the poem with itself*” — the poem’s self-questioning, its capacity to hold contradictory truths at once:contentReferenceoaicite:1.

Mini-Essay — The Age of Twinning

The Victorians inherited Romantic subjectivity but lived in a mechanised world. Their poems respond to this dissonance by doubling and dividing the self — *Jekyll and Hyde*, *Dorian Gray and his portrait*, *North and South*. The result is a poetics of multiplicity: an art that is always talking to itself.

30.48 Tennyson and the “Antiphonal Voice of the Heckler”

Tennyson exemplifies this doubleness: the public poet laureate whose verse harbours private doubt. “*The Charge of the Light Brigade*” (1854) is a case study in conflicted tone.

“*Half a league, half a league,
Half a league onward,
All in the valley of Death
Rode the six hundred.*”

Read superficially, the poem appears to glorify military duty. Yet its rhythm and diction undermine that very heroism. “Their’s but to do and die” flattens the martial slogan “do or die” into fatalistic inevitability. The pause in “Some one had blunder’d” isolates guilt; “half a league” repeats until it sounds like compulsion rather than courage. Even the dactylic metre — the gallop of hooves — wavers between drive and dread:contentReferenceoaicite:3.

Published in *The Examiner* (Dec. 1854), the poem appeared beside reports on the Crimean War and on the Peace Society — a “chorus of paratexts” that refracted its message. The newspaper itself became a

polyphonic anthology, each article echoing or undermining Tennyson's heroic rhythm.

Mini-Essay — The Poet as Rebel-Conformist

T. S. Eliot called Tennyson "the most instinctive rebel against the society in which he was the most perfect conformist." Each Tennysonian lyric is two poems in one: the laureate's patriotic voice intertwined with the antiphonal voice of doubt — what Geoffrey Hill termed "*the antiphonal voice of the heckler*." The poem's true subject is its own inner argument.

30.49 Poetry in an Unpoetical Age

Matthew Arnold lamented in 1849 that "the age and all one's surroundings are unpoetical" — not "unprofound" or "ungrand," but hostile to poetry's very condition (Arnold, letter to A. H. Clough). Industrial England, he feared, left little room for lyric thought. Dickens captures this tension in *Dombey and Son* (1848): Mrs. Skewton's nostalgic cry for "the poetry of existence in these terrible days" becomes self-parody, the Victorians' yearning for beauty commodified into cliché:contentReferenceoaicite:5.

Art was seen as relic or luxury. The Welsh legend of *The Bard*, painted by John Martin (1817), dramatises the gap between poet and audience — the solitary figure on the cliff, singing above the noise of empire. Wordsworth's lament, "Whither is fled the visionary gleam?" (1807), still reverberated; by the time Arnold wrote *Stanzas from the Grande Chartreuse*, the poet was "wandering between two worlds, one dead, the other powerless to be born."

Mini-Essay — The Last Bards

For Arnold, poetry became a "stay" — a support against chaos — but also a sign of loss. The poet in an "unpoetical age" is both prophet and fossil, trying to steady a civilisation that no longer listens.

30.50 Progress and Its Discontents

Tennyson's *Locksley Hall* (1842) cries, "Forward, forward let us range, / Let the great world spin for ever down the ringing grooves of change." Yet the repetition of *forward* stumbles, as though progress catches in its own machinery. His metaphor of railway "grooves" suggests motion without direction — the wheel that "moves onward" yet "returns on itself."

Eliot later quipped: "Tennyson believed explicitly in progress, and believed implicitly that progress consists in things remaining much as they are" (Eliot, *In Memoriam* essay, 1936):contentReferenceoaicite:7.

Victorian "progress" is rhythmic, not linear — each revolution a rhyme with the past.

Mini-Essay — The Circular Groove of Change

Victorian modernity is haunted by recurrence. For every "groove of change," there is the counter-rhythm of nostalgia. Poetry becomes the space where progress and memory coexist — a wheel forever turning on itself.

30.51 Conclusion: The Dark Reverse of the Tapestry

In an early play, *The Devil and the Lady* (c.1823), Tennyson describes the unseen side of embroidery: "the dark reverse of it, / The intertwining and rough wanderings of random threads." That is Victorian poetry's truest image: a surface of order concealing intricate knots beneath:contentReferenceoaicite:8.

Its apparent certainties — faith, empire, propriety — hide countercurrents of doubt, rebellion, and irony. The Victorians may have believed in "the best of times," but they also heard, beneath that harmony, the many discordant voices of their own making.

Mini-Essay — The Fire in the Thread

Hopkins's "fresh-firecoal chestnut-falls" (*Pied Beauty*, 1877) offers the final emblem: the husk split open to reveal "things counter, original, spare, strange." Victorian poetry, too, cracks its own shell — releasing from within the spark of modernity.

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30.53 Introduction: The Drama of Life and Art

“Would you like to know the great drama of my life? It is that I have put my genius into my life – I have put only my talent into my works.”:contentReferenceoaicite:0

Oscar Wilde’s famous boast captures the paradox of his reputation: his life has often eclipsed his art. From his trial and imprisonment to his dazzling epigrams, Wilde’s persona became the most enduring performance of his career. Yet his work — in its wit, irony, and aesthetic philosophy — continually reflects upon that performance, turning life into art and art into life.

Mini-Essay — Wilde’s Self as Artwork

Wilde treated identity as aesthetic material. His flamboyant persona was not a mask concealing truth but a creative act — “the supreme reality” through which life itself became art. His challenge to moral and artistic convention lay in this inversion: to live beautifully was the highest art form.

30.54 II. Masks and Mirrors: *Salomé* and the Politics of Looking

In *Salomé* (1893), Wilde dramatises the act of **seeing as creation**. Each character describes the moon differently — corpse, virgin, madwoman — revealing more about themselves than about what they behold.

HEROD: “Neither at things, nor at people should one look. Only in mirrors should one look, for mirrors do but show us masks.”:contentReferenceoaicite:2

Here Wilde rewrites the **myth of Medusa**: to look directly is to petrify, to destroy; to look through art — the mirror — is to transform. The play’s obsession with vision, desire, and control becomes a meditation on **subjectivity itself**.

Mini-Essay — The Power of the Gaze

For Wilde, perception is possession. To look is to create. *Salomé* turns spectatorship into seduction and art into danger: “the world is a reflection of who we think we are, mirrored back to us.” The mirror becomes both shield and snare — revelation through performance.

30.55 IV. De Profundis: The Letter from Prison

Written during his imprisonment in Reading Gaol (1895–97), Wilde’s *Epistola: In Carcere et Vinculis* (“Letter: In Prison and in Chains”) is both confession and creation — a self-portrait forged in suffering.

30.55.1 Composition and Transmission

Wilde wrote an 80-page manuscript, addressed to Lord Alfred Douglas but intended for multiple readers. He instructed his friend Robert Ross to copy and preserve it “on good paper such as is used for plays, with wide rubricated margins”:contentReferenceoaicite:3. Wilde planned it as both private explanation and public testament — “a literary executor must be in possession of the only document that really explains my conduct.”

Ross later published one-third of it in 1905 under the title **De Profundis** (“Out of the Depths”), suppressing references to Douglas. The full manuscript appeared only in 1962.

Mini-Essay — The Text as Performance

De Profundis is less a letter than a staged confession. Wilde’s request for margins and copies suggests he conceived it as a script — a play of repentance and resistance. It performs the transformation it describes: the artist remaking himself through art.

30.56 VI. Art as Redemption

In *De Profundis*, Wilde revises his earlier disdain for pity. Once a prophet of aesthetic detachment, he now discovers compassion through pain. He redefines Christ not as moral redeemer but as **the supreme artist of the self**:

“[Christ’s] chief war was against the Philistines.... The Jew of Jerusalem in Christ’s day was the exact counterpart of the British Philistine of our own.”:contentReferenceoaicite:6

Christ becomes the model of imaginative sympathy — “the artist of humanity” who finds beauty even in sin. For Wilde, art and religion converge in this creative empathy.

Mini-Essay — Wilde’s Gospel of Art

To create is to forgive. Wilde’s Christ loves through imagination, transforming judgment into art. His religion is aestheticism sanctified — beauty as the mode of moral truth.

30.57 VIII. The Artist as Christ

At the height of *De Profundis*, Wilde fuses autobiography with theology:

“I was a man who stood in symbolic relations to the art and culture of my age.... I treated Art as the supreme reality, and life as a mere mode of fiction.”:contentReferenceoaicite:8

In making himself emblematic — artist as sinner, sinner as saint — Wilde both exalts and critiques his society. His “war with the Philistines” becomes the modern Passion: the artist persecuted for beauty.

30.58 X. Legacy and Critical Afterlives

Wilde’s *De Profundis* bridges Victorian morality and modernist self-consciousness. Its hybrid form — letter, sermon, autobiography, manifesto — anticipates twentieth-century explorations of **the self as text**.

Later critics read Wilde as:

- **Queer theorist avant la lettre** (Ellis Hanson, Alan Sinfield) — identity as performance.
- **Political aesthete** (Regina Gagnier) — art as social critique.
- **Martyr of modernism** (T. S. Eliot, W. H. Auden) — suffering transfigured into art.

The Oxford English Texts edition of *De Profundis* (ed. Ian Small, 2005) now distinguishes between *De Profundis* (Ross’s version) and *Epistola: In Carcere et Vinculis* (the full manuscript), preserving Wilde’s multiple selves.

30.59 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Art <-> Life	Each imitates and invents the other.	Biography becomes aesthetics.
Suffering <-> Redemption	Pain as self-realisation.	Artist as Christ-figure and martyr.
Mask <-> Self	Performance reveals truth.	Identity as creation, not confession.
Criticism <-> Creation	“Criticism is the highest form of autobiography.”	Reading as re-creation of art.
Faith <-> Irony	Devotion through parody.	Wilde’s sanctity is theatrical and self-aware.

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30.61 The Century of Forms: An Overview

Between 1830 and 1910, English literary culture exploded in range and reach. The **serialised novel**, the **public theatre**, and the **lyric poem** became engines of thought and empathy. Industrial print, rising literacy, and imperial expansion made the written and performed word a global commodity (Dasgupta 2025, slide 4; Prelims Handbook 2025, p. 18).

Victorian literature’s defining strength lies in its **double nature**: it seeks both to reflect reality and to remake it through imagination. This tension between **representation and invention** structures its three great forms — prose, poetry, and performance — and links them across genre boundaries that were, in practice, porous.

Mini-Essay — The Ecology of Form

As Ushashi Dasgupta observes, Dickens’s fiction shares DNA with the stage; Browning’s verse is theatrical in its monologues; and the Victorian theatre was itself a mirror of fiction’s moral imagination (Dasgupta 2025, slide 12; McGhee 2025, p. 5).

The era’s literature is thus not a set of separate forms but a **living ecosystem** — a culture of storytelling that moved freely between the page, the stage, and the voice.

30.61.1 Fiction and Empire

By mid-century, fiction’s reach was global. In *The Pickwick Papers* (1836–37), Dickens casually dispatches his comic surgeons to Bengal (Dasgupta 2025, slide 10). In 1864, **Bankimchandra Chattopadhyay’s** *Rajmohan’s Wife* became the first Anglophone Indian novel, published in *The Indian Field*. Written

under empire, it embodies the hybridity of the Victorian form — realist, Gothic, melodramatic, and ironic all at once (Dasgupta 2025, slides 10–11).

Its hero Madhav, gazing past his unread English books toward the “dark but star-besprinkled heavens,” symbolises a colonial subject caught between languages and worlds (Chattopadhyay 1864, ch. ‘What Befell Our Hero’).

Mini-Essay — The Novel Across Borders

Rajmohan’s Wife demonstrates that Victorian fiction was never merely British. Its very disjointedness reveals the imperial circuits of form — how genres travel, mutate, and absorb contradiction (Dasgupta 2025, slide 12). Writing in English becomes both collaboration and resistance: a sign of the novel’s global entanglement and its negotiation between domination and self-expression.

30.62 Poetry: Language, Intimacy, and Experiment

30.62.1 The Poet’s Task

For Fergus McGhee (2025, slide 3), Victorian poetry begins in crisis. After Romanticism, poets like Browning, Tennyson, and Hopkins faced the loss of a unified cultural audience and responded by reinventing the **voice of the lyric** as a medium of discovery rather than declaration.

Browning’s *Sordello* (1840) seeks to “generate speech where an accent’s change gives each / the other’s soul” (Browning 1840, p. 12; McGhee 2025, slide 2), transforming the lyric into a conversation between self and other.

Mini-Essay — Poetry as Thinking in Sound

Victorian poets do not simply express emotion; they use rhythm and syntax to *think*. Their experiments with metre, enjambment, and silence are acts of philosophical inquiry. The poem becomes a field of cognition — where words, in Tennyson’s phrase, “half reveal and half conceal the Soul within” (*In Memoriam*, 1850, st. V; McGhee 2025, slide 3).

30.62.2 Words and Their Limits

Tennyson’s *In Memoriam* (1850) stages both the failure and necessity of language: “I sometimes hold it half a sin / To put in words the grief I feel.”

Its hesitant prosody enacts the trembling of thought under pressure. As R. H. Hutton remarked, the poem is “full of magnifying-glasses for secret feelings, and doubts, and fears, and hopes, and trusts” (Hutton 1851, p. 217; McGhee 2025, slide 4).

Hopkins’s “Sonnets of Desolation” carry this inwardness to its extremity, compressing spiritual anguish into sprung rhythm.

D. G. Rossetti’s *House of Life* (1881) turns the sonnet into a self-conscious artifact of erotic and artistic crisis, while Christina Rossetti’s *Winter: My Secret* (1857) transforms reticence itself into art: “I tell my secret? No indeed, not I” (Rossetti 1857, l. 1).

30.62.3 The Intimacy of the Unseen

Helen Vendler notes that the lyric’s “intrinsic ability to create intimacy is most striking when the object of intimacy can never be humanly seen or known” (Vendler 2005, p. 15). Victorian poetry thus invents an “**invisible listener**”: an imagined reader, lover, or God who guarantees speech even when absent.

A. E. Housman’s *From Far, from Eve and Morning* (1896) captures this solitude — a soul addressing the void, sustained by the rhythm of its own utterance (Housman 1896, st. I; McGhee 2025, slide 12).

Mini-Essay — The Lyric as Relationship

The Victorian lyric is not confession but correspondence — a reaching out toward the unseen. Its faith in address, even without reply, defines its ethical stance: meaning arises in relation, not solitude. To write “to the World / That never wrote to Me” (Dickinson c. 1862, l. 1) is to transform isolation into dialogue.

30.62.4 The Poet and the Nation

Critics like John Stuart Mill and Arthur Hallam framed poetry as both personal and national expression — “the poet’s utter unconsciousness of a listener” balanced against “the general impulse of the nation” (Mill 1833, p. 95; Hallam 1831, p. 102).

Elizabeth Barrett Browning’s *Aurora Leigh* (1856) sought to “catch upon the burning lava of a song / the full-veined, heaving, double-breasted Age” (E. B. Browning 1856, Bk. II, l. 201; McGhee 2025, slide 7), fusing epic scope with domestic intimacy.

Mini-Essay — The Politics of Voice

For Barrett Browning and her contemporaries, the lyric’s inward turn was not withdrawal but engagement. To speak personally was to speak politically: the self became a microcosm of the age.

In this fusion of art and society, Victorian poetry articulates what fiction and theatre enact — the struggle to reconcile individuality with collective vision.

30.63 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
The Bookcase / The Stage	Dickens’s “pleasant fiction”; Punch-and-Judy scene; theatrical realism	The porous boundary between illusion and truth; fiction as performance of belief
Voice and Echo	Browning’s “accent’s change”; Dickinson’s unanswered letter	Dialogue as the condition of thought; language seeking reciprocity
Home and the Uncanny	<i>Bleak House</i> ’s “romantic side of familiar things”; Ibsen’s domestic theatre	Domestic space as moral theatre; realism haunted by its own ghosts
Spectacle and Technology	Pepper’s Ghost; <i>Ben Hur</i> machinery	The modern fascination with the visible; faith in illusion as revelation
The Invisible Listener	Tennyson’s reticence; Vendler’s “unseen other”	Lyric intimacy grounded in absence; communication as ethical act
Empire and Language	<i>Rajmohan’s Wife</i> ; colonial readership	English as both instrument of domination and site of hybrid creativity
Labour and Art	Trollope’s timed writing; Vestris’s theatre management	Art as disciplined craft within capitalism; professionalisation of creativity

30.64 Exam Relevance — Oxford Prelims Paper 3

30.64.1 Core Skills

- **Close Reading:** Analyse how voice, syntax, and rhythm embody moral and psychological tension (e.g., Tennyson’s hesitations; Dickens’s serial irony; Ibsen’s dialogue).
- **Comparative Thinking:** Connect fiction, poetry, and theatre through shared preoccupations — performance, sympathy, experiment, and the uncanny.
- **Historical Awareness:** Ground textual form in social context: industrial modernity, empire, gender politics, and religious doubt.
- **Critical Reflection:** Recognise self-consciousness — literature thinking about its own making (Prelims Handbook 2025, p. 18).

30.64.2 Essay Patterns to Practise

1. **Form and Ethics:** How does aesthetic difficulty become moral inquiry? (*In Memoriam*, *Middlemarch*, *A Doll’s House*.)

2. **Art and Illusion:** What is the truth-value of fiction or performance? (*The Old Curiosity Shop*, *The Octoroon*, Browning's monologues.)
3. **Gender and Performance:** How does Victorian art dramatise identity as role? (Rossetti's secrecy; Nora's dance; Langtry's celebrity.)
4. **Empire and Language:** How does English operate as both constraint and liberation? (*Rajmohan's Wife*, Kipling, Eliot.)
5. **The Reader and the Real:** What kind of moral or imaginative labour does Victorian literature demand from its audience?

30.64.3 Revision Strategies

- Pair one *major realist* (Eliot, Dickens) with one *formalist innovator* (Browning, James, Ibsen) to explore continuity and change.
- Practise mini-close readings of figurative motifs (the house, the stage, the book, the ghost).
- Remember the dialogic nature of the period: fiction, poetry, and drama belong to the same cultural conversation about how art can think.

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30.66 Introduction: The *Fin de Siècle* and the Turn of the Century

The late nineteenth century — the **fin de siècle** (“end of the century”) — was a period of contradiction and experiment. It stood *between* the moral confidence of the Victorian age and the fragmentation of modernism. As Stefan Evangelista notes, writers of the 1880s and 1890s were “neither wholly Victorian nor wholly modern, but both at once” (Evangelista 2025).

This period witnesses a revolt against **realism** and moral didacticism. Instead of depicting society in sober tones, artists sought **intensity, impression, and strangeness**. They turned from the visible world toward the inner, the unconscious, and the dream-like — what Walter Pater called “the quickened, multiplied consciousness” (Pater 1873).

Mini-Essay — The Modern Moment Before Modernism

The *fin de siècle* is a hinge moment: the *Victorian gaze* turns inward. Realism’s mirror of the social world becomes the mirror of the mind. The novel gives way to the lyric essay, the prose poem, and the fragment — short forms suited to fleeting perceptions and unstable selves.

30.67 II. Walter Pater: The Father of Aestheticism

Walter Pater’s *Studies in the History of the Renaissance* (1873) is the foundational text of **Aestheticism**, the movement that redefined art as sensation rather than instruction (Pater 1873).

30.67.1 Aesthetic Criticism

In his Preface, Pater reimagines criticism as **subjective response**:

“To see the object as in itself it really is... one must first know one’s own impression as it really is.” (Pater 1873, Preface)

Criticism is not about moral judgment but **aesthetic experience** — the shifting relationship between work and observer. The critic asks not “What does it mean?” but “What effect does it produce on me?”

30.67.2 Pater’s Style: *The Mona Lisa*

Pater’s description of Leonardo’s *Mona Lisa* embodies this method:

“She is older than the rocks among which she sits; like the vampire, she has been dead many times... the mother of Helen and of Mary... the symbol of the modern idea.” (Pater 1873)

This is no objective ekphrasis but an act of imaginative possession. His “vampire” Lisa represents history and desire fused — beauty tinged with death.

Mini-Essay — Criticism as Creation

Pater’s prose transforms criticism into performance. The critic becomes artist, translating per-

ception into poetry. His “impressionism” anticipates modernist subjectivity — art as the trace of a fleeting consciousness.

30.67.3 The Gospel of Intensity

Pater’s *Conclusion* exhorts:

“To burn always with this hard, gemlike flame, to maintain this ecstasy, is success in life.” (Pater 1873, Conclusion)

Life, like art, is transient; the critic’s task is to **seize intensity** in fleeting moments. Pleasure and perception replace moral purpose.

This creed, soon caricatured as “**art for art’s sake**,” rejects utilitarian art. Meaning lies not in content but in **form**, in “the love of art for its own sake.”

Mini-Essay — The Aesthetic Life

Pater’s call to live “with a quickened sense of life” makes aesthetics an ethics. Beauty becomes the substitute for belief, art the new religion. In a disenchanted world, the critic’s flame replaces the church’s candle.

30.68 IV. Defining Decadence

30.68.1 The Spirit of Perversion

Where Aestheticism celebrated form and intensity, **Decadence** exposed their excess. It is the **twist** of the aesthetic ideal — a beauty aware of its corruption.

Arthur Symons, describing the movement, observed that it “has all the qualities that mark the end of great periods... an intense self-consciousness, a restless curiosity, a spiritual and moral perversity — a new and beautiful and interesting disease” (Symons 1893).

Decadence delights in artifice, sensuality, and over-refinement. Its forms are ornamental, its language overwrought — “*metaphors as monstrous as orchids*.”

Paul Bourget defined it stylistically:

“A style of decadence is one in which the unity of the book is decomposed... the independence of the phrase gives place to the independence of the word.” (Bourget 1885)

Meaning dissolves into texture; **form decomposes into sensation**.

30.68.2 *Dorian Gray*: The Decadent Gospel

In Wilde’s novel, the Paterian pursuit of beauty becomes fatal. Dorian’s wish for eternal youth — “to burn always with this hard, gemlike flame” — turns into moral decay. The yellow book that corrupts him (a nod to J.-K. Huysmans’s *À Rebours*) embodies decadence itself: pleasure turned obsession, art turned poison (Huysmans 1884; Wilde 1891).

Mini-Essay — The Disease of Art

Decadence is aestheticism’s fever. The worship of beauty becomes addiction; the love of form becomes self-destruction. Wilde’s novel shows the cost of turning life wholly into art: when every sensation is pursued, the self disintegrates.

30.69 VI. Masks, Bodies, and the New Woman

Decadence also coincided with shifts in **gender and sexuality**. The 1890s saw the emergence of early sexology and the cultural figure of the **New Woman** — independent, intellectual, and transgressive.

Women readers and writers became both subjects and symbols of the age's anxieties. The female figure in Decadent art oscillates between **fatal beauty** (Salomé) and **autonomous desire** (the reader on *The Yellow Book* cover) (Ledger 1997).

Mini-Essay — Gender and Decay

Decadence mirrors the century's crisis of gender. The masculine rationalism of mid-Victorian culture gives way to the fluid and the feminine — the artist as androgyne, the body as text, the mask as identity.

30.70 VIII. Legacy: From Decadence to Modernism

Though condemned in its time, Decadence became the seedbed of **modernism**. Pater's "impressions," Wilde's "useless art," and Beardsley's fragmentation anticipate the stylistic and psychological experiments of Joyce, Eliot, and Woolf (Pater 1873; Wilde 1891; Beardsley 1894).

The Decadent's obsession with language, sensation, and the instability of meaning prefigures the modernist self-consciousness that art can only represent its own failure to represent.

Mini-Essay — The Afterlife of the Fin de Siècle

The Aesthetes failed as moralists but triumphed as visionaries. Their creed — art as experience, life as art — becomes the foundation of twentieth-century modernity. The "disease" of Decadence proved contagious, and creative.

30.71 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Reality <-> Impression	From realism to aesthetic subjectivity	Knowledge becomes sensory.
Art <-> Morality	Art for art's sake	Beauty replaces ethics as ideal.
Form <-> Content	Ornament as excess	Style becomes substance.
Life <-> Art	Pater's gospel → Wilde's performance	Existence as aesthetic experiment.
Victorian <-> Modern	Continuity through rebellion	Decadence as bridge to modernism.

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30.73 Introduction: Wilde Between Two Worlds

Oscar Wilde (1854–1900) stands on the threshold between **Victorianism and Modernism**, embodying both the confidence of the old century and the fragmentation of the new. His career — from *The Picture of*

Dorian Gray (1891) to *The Importance of Being Earnest* (1895) and *De Profundis* (1897) — spans a period of cultural upheaval when literature itself was being redefined.

Wilde's work critiques **Victorian moralism** while preparing the ground for **modernist experimentation**: he is, as this lecture puts it, a “**midwife to modernism**,” loosening conventions so that new forms could emerge:contentReferenceoaicite:0.

Mini-Essay — Wilde's Janus Face

Wilde looks backward and forward at once. He perfects the paradoxical aphorism, the society play, and the aesthetic essay — yet each of these undermines Victorian certainty. The result is literature aware of its own artifice: at once decorative and destabilising, poised between moral drama and modern irony.

30.74 II. Wilde and the Reversal of Values

30.74.1 The Epigram and the Paradox

Wilde's genius lies in inversion — what George Bernard Shaw called “the dangerous subject” that makes critics “dull.” Shaw wryly noted:

“They protest that such epigrams can be turned out by the score... yet his plays remain unique. That says much for the self-denial of our scribes.”:contentReferenceoaicite:2

The **epigram** — “Work is the curse of the drinking classes,” “I can resist everything except temptation” — becomes Wilde's method of critique. By reversing clichés, he exposes how language itself polices morality.

Mini-Essay — The Ethics of the Paradox

Wilde's wit is philosophy in miniature. Each reversal (“Disobedience is man's original virtue”) reveals the fragility of inherited norms. The epigram, like modernist irony, fractures moral language to free new meanings.

30.75 IV. Art for Art's Sake: The Preface to *The Picture of Dorian Gray*

Wilde's *Preface* (1891) distills the creed of **Aestheticism**:

“There is no such thing as a moral or an immoral book. Books are well written or badly written. That is all... All art is quite useless.”:contentReferenceoaicite:4

These aphorisms reject art's subservience to ethics or didacticism. Beauty alone is its justification.

Mini-Essay — The Uselessness of Art

“All art is quite useless” is not nihilism but provocation. By denying social utility, Wilde asserts art's freedom. The useless becomes the indispensable condition of creativity. This paradox will echo in modernist aesthetics from Joyce to Woolf.

30.76 VI. The Critic as Creator

In *The Critic as Artist* (1891), Wilde redefines criticism as **creation**. Through his interlocutors Ernest and Gilbert, he dismantles Matthew Arnold's dictum that the critic must “see the object as in itself it really is.”

“The proper aim of Criticism is to see the object as in itself it really is not... To the critic, the work of art is simply a suggestion for a new work of his own.”:contentReferenceoaicite:6

Wilde reverses Arnold's objectivity into subjectivity: art's meaning lies in perception, not intention. The critic becomes artist, transforming the work through interpretation.

Mini-Essay — The Death of Objectivity

Wilde anticipates Barthes's “Death of the Author.” Meaning is relational, not fixed. Criticism becomes an imaginative act — the modern essay as art form. Subjectivity, once heresy, becomes the source of aesthetic truth.

30.77 VIII. Realism and “The Decay of Lying”

Wilde’s dialogue *The Decay of Lying* (1889) parodies realism’s obsession with fact:

“Lying, the telling of beautiful untrue things, is the proper aim of Art.”

He denounces the “modern mania for morality” in literature and celebrates invention. Art does not copy life; life imitates art.

Mini-Essay — Imagination as Truth

For Wilde, truth is not correspondence but creation. Art’s lies are higher truths — those that make reality imaginable. The artist’s lie becomes the modernist symbol: subjective, unstable, endlessly productive.

30.78 X. From Aestheticism to Modernism

Wilde’s writings — especially the essays in *Intentions* — dismantle Victorian hierarchies between artist, critic, and audience. His defence of subjectivity, irony, and impressionism opens the door to **modernist experimentation**:

Victorian Ideal	Wildean Reversal	Modernist Legacy
Objectivity	Subjectivity	Stream of consciousness, interior monologue
Morality	Aesthetic autonomy	Art for art’s sake, formal innovation
Truth	Imagination	Symbolism, abstraction
Authority	Individualism	Anti-traditionalism, irony
Realism	Artifice	Metafiction, fragmentation

Mini-Essay — Wilde as Midwife to Modernism

Wilde’s contradictions — his insistence on beauty and his mockery of truth — make him the hinge of literary modernity. Without Wilde’s irony, there could be no Eliot; without his aesthetic self-consciousness, no Woolf. His century ends where ours begins.

30.79 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Victorian <-> Modernist	Continuity and rupture	Wilde dissolves realism, invents aesthetic self-consciousness.
Art <-> Morality	Inverse proportion	Ethical art is not moral but imaginative.
Critic <-> Creator	Fusion	Reading as creation; meaning as invention.
Society <-> Self	Conflict	Social control breeds artistic rebellion.
Truth <-> Artifice	Mutual dependence	The lie as vehicle for beauty and insight.

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30.81 Introduction: Poetry That Looks and Pictures That Speak

Victorian poets were obsessed with **making art speak** — translating visual art into words, emotion, and time. Fergus McGhee notes that the late nineteenth century saw an unprecedented vogue for poems about pictures: “*Never before had so many poems been written about pictures; the genre became a site of extraordinary experimental energy*” (McGhee 2025).

These experiments belong to the ancient tradition of **ekphrasis** — from the Greek *ekphrazein*, “to speak out.” In classical rhetoric, the term meant vivid description (*enargeia*), a way to animate the mind’s eye. By the Victorian period, it had narrowed to mean a **literary response to a visual artwork** — not just description but interpretation, imitation, or even rivalry.

Mini-Essay — Ekphrasis as Encounter

Ekphrasis is a *meeting of the arts*: painting’s stillness meets poetry’s voice. Each poem must decide whether to *speak to*, *speak for*, or *speak about* the artwork — an ethical as well as aesthetic decision. The poet’s words risk trespassing on the painter’s silence, yet they also reveal how both arts depend on imagination to bridge what can be seen and what can be said.

30.82 II. Michael Field: *Sight and Song* (1892) — The Poem as Translation

Among the richest Victorian experiments in ekphrasis is *Sight and Song* (1892), a collection by **Michael Field** — the shared pseudonym of Katherine Bradley and Edith Cooper. The book contains thirty-three poems, each based on a specific painting viewed in European galleries. No reproductions were included; the reader must imagine each picture through words alone (Field 1892).

Critics such as W. B. Yeats dismissed the collection as “a guidebook to the picture galleries of Europe.” Yet its restraint conceals daring innovation. The poets present themselves not as interpreters of feeling but as **translators of visual form**. Their aim, stated in the preface, is “to express not so much what these pictures are to the poet, but rather what poetry they objectively incarnate” (*Preface to Sight and Song*).

Bradley explained the method in a letter: “*There are poems in them, and one has only to stare and wait till they give up their secret*” (Bradley to Costelloe, 1891). The poet becomes an instrument of perception — waiting, listening, translating.

30.82.1 Impersonality and Imagination

In the preface, Bradley and Cooper cite **Flaubert’s** dictum: “*One must, by an effort of mind, transport oneself into the characters and not draw them towards oneself.*” Substituting *paintings* for *characters*, they advocate impersonality: to see things “from their own centre.” Yet, as Walter **Pater** noted in his review of Flaubert, total objectivity is impossible: “*The artist will be felt; his subjectivity must and will colour the incidents*” (Pater 1888).

The Fields acknowledge this paradox: to translate an image “honestly and with persistence” still leaves “the inevitable force of individuality.” Their art aspires to efface the self while recognising its shadow.

Mini-Essay — Translation as Ethics

Sight and Song transforms looking into moral practice. To translate without domination — to see as the image sees — becomes an ethical ideal. The poet must suppress ego and habit to encounter the artwork’s “otherness.” Ekphrasis thus models attentive, self-forgetting observation: an art of humility.

30.82.2 Painting and Prosody

Michael Field’s preface declares their purpose “to translate into verse what the lines and colours of certain chosen pictures sing in themselves.” The goal is not paraphrase but **transposition** — turning brushstrokes into rhythm, pigment into metre. As Pater had warned in *The School of Giorgione* (1877), it is a mistake to treat art forms as mere translations of a shared “quantity of imaginative thought.” What matters are the “sensuous elements in art” — colour, sound, texture — which *Sight and Song* seeks to render verbally.

This aspiration challenges Lessing’s separation of time and space: the poets make poetry **painterly**, using rhythm as line and page-space as canvas.

30.82.3 *Venus, Mercury, and Cupid* — Correggio and the Education of Desire

In *Venus, Mercury, and Cupid*, the poets describe Correggio’s Renaissance painting (National Gallery, c.1525), in which Mercury teaches Cupid to read while Venus looks on. The poem’s structure mirrors the painting’s triadic composition: three stanzas of interlaced rhyme (aba ccc). The syntax pauses and suspends, mimicking the painting’s stillness.

McGhee notes that each stanza is catalectic — missing the final syllable of its metre — forcing the reader into silence at each line’s end (McGhee 2025). This incomplete rhythm emulates the *poised tension* of the painted figures: Venus’s contemplative stillness, Cupid’s concentration, Mercury’s gesture.

Mini-Essay — Poetry that Looks

The Fields’ verse aspires to *stillness*. By truncating its metre, it holds time in check, turning verse into image. Yet even as the poem freezes, syntax flows; the artwork’s spatial harmony becomes a temporal sequence. Ekphrasis becomes not imitation but **transformation** — poetry discovering its own pictorial mode.

30.83 IV. Rossetti, Wharton, and the Speaking Picture

30.83.1 Rossetti’s *Proserpine* (1872): The Art of Listening

Dante Gabriel Rossetti’s *Proserpine (For a Picture)* (1872) gives voice to the mythic figure he painted: the goddess trapped in Hades after tasting the pomegranate. Unlike most ekphrastic poems, this one is written in the **voice of the image itself**. Proserpine speaks — yet her speech is haunted by distance and echo:

*“Afar from mine own self I seem, and wing
Strange ways in thought, and listen for a sign.”*

As **Jerome McGann** notes, the poem creates “an uncanny sense that Proserpine is listening for the very poem she herself appears to be authoring.” The artwork, silent and static, becomes an active listener. Ekphrasis turns inward: **the image hears us**.

Mini-Essay — The Speaking Image

Rossetti reverses the hierarchy of voice and silence. The poem no longer speaks *for* the picture; it imagines the picture speaking *back*. Ekphrasis becomes reciprocal, not possessive — a dialogue across media and worlds.

30.83.2 Rossetti's *For Spring, by Botticelli* (1881): Mystery and Silence

In *For Spring (by Botticelli)*, Rossetti questions the painting's meaning:

> “What mystery here is read / Of homage or of hope?”

The image refuses to answer. McGhee notes that this reticence recalls **Plato's *Phaedrus***, where writing, like painting, “seems to speak, yet remains silent.” The painting's silence becomes its eloquence: a mystery that rebukes the poet's impatience.

Pater, in “The Myth of Demeter and Persephone” (1876), reminds us that *mystery* derives from *muein* — to close the lips. Silence, then, is not lack but depth.

Mini-Essay — The Silence That Speaks

For Rossetti, Botticelli's mute figures embody the sacred reserve of art. To “make art speak” may mean to listen more closely to its silence. Ekphrasis becomes contemplation — a reverent form of reading that honours what remains unsaid.

30.83.3 Edith Wharton: *The “Apollo and Marsyas” of Perugino*

Wharton's sonnet (c.1890s) imagines the mythic contest between the god Apollo and the satyr Marsyas. The poem knows what the painting does not: that Marsyas will soon be flayed alive.

> “Inscrutably serene the young god stands / In prescience inaccessible, his eyes / Bright with the fumes of mortal sacrifice.”

Here, ekphrasis gives the poet narrative omniscience — the power to restore the temporal dimension the painting withholds. Yet Apollo's calm detachment becomes an emblem of art's *inhuman serenity*: the price of aesthetic distance.

Mini-Essay — Knowledge and Violence

Wharton's poem turns knowing into cruelty. To see ahead of the image is to wound it. Ekphrasis thus stages an ethical drama between insight and invasion: to interpret may also mean to harm.

30.84 Conclusion: The Speaking Picture and the Reading Eye

Victorian ekphrasis transforms a classical rhetorical exercise into a **modern meditation on art, gender, and sympathy**. From Pater's sensuous criticism to Michael Field's impersonal translation, from Rossetti's haunted silence to Lee's responsive gaze, poets and critics alike explore what happens when the visual and verbal cross.

To “make art speak” is not to conquer its silence but to enter into it — to learn that every act of description is an act of relation. Ekphrasis, in McGhee's words, “*shows that the experience of art is never detached from the experience of the world and the people in it*” (McGhee 2025).

Mini-Essay — The Final Dialogue

The poet and the image stand as mirrors: one seeking to speak, the other to be heard. Between them lies the true subject of ekphrasis — not art itself, but the human capacity for attention, imagination, and empathy.

30.85 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Image <-> Word	Mutual translation between visual and verbal arts	The boundaries between arts are porous; meaning is created through crossing forms.
Speech <-> Silence	The poet's voice versus the painting's mute presence	Ekphrasis dramatizes power, gender, and the ethics of interpretation.
Time <-> Space	Lessing's distinction between temporal poetry and spatial painting	Victorian ekphrasis collapses this division; verse becomes visual.

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Self <-> Other	The viewer's projection into the artwork	To look ethically is to imagine without appropriation.
Gender <-> Authority	Female artists reclaiming voice in male-dominated discourse	Ekphrasis as feminist rewriting of the "mute" female image.
Description <-> Creation	From observation to invention	The poet's "translation" becomes new art: description as re-creation.
Silence <-> Mystery	The ineffable as aesthetic ideal	The painting's refusal to speak sustains the poem's reverence and humility.

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30.87 Introduction: What Is Real?

Sophie Ratcliffe opens by posing the question that realism can never quite settle: **what is real, and to whom?** (Ratcliffe 2025). "Realism," "real," and "realistic" are distinct — and keeping them distinct, Ratcliffe insists, is an *ethical duty*.

- *The real* — a **philosophical** and **political** question. It concerns perception, materiality, and power: “whose world counts as real?”
- *The realistic* — a **judgement** about plausibility. “That’s not realistic” means “that doesn’t fit my sense of what’s possible.”
- *Realism* — a **literary mode or method**, often mistaken for transparency, but fundamentally a *representation of representation*.

Mini-Essay — The Real, the Realistic, and Realism

The term “realism” has always been unstable because it claims both to describe the world and to interpret it. What counts as “real” shifts with power: whose story, whose language, whose image stands for the truth?

Ratcliffe begins with an anecdote from *The Amateur Photographer* (24 July 1885):

“She had never been satisfied with the portraits which professional photographers made for her... She has thus far made one hundred and sixty-seven different pictures of herself.”

This early “selfie” captures realism’s core dilemma: **the conflict between representation and reality**, between the desire to see oneself truly and the limits of technology and self-perception. The image is never identical to the self; yet the attempt to reproduce truth generates endless versions.

The story also appears in a journal that itself fretted about authenticity: “letters must be authenticated by the name and address of the sender.” Reality, already in 1885, was a matter of verification and performance — a precursor to *fake news*.

Mini-Essay — The Self in Representation

The girl’s 167 self-portraits parody the realist project: a pursuit of truth through repetition, a faith that one more exposure might finally reveal the real. But her camera captures not essence but process — the infinite deferral of self-knowledge.

30.88 II. Expanding the Canon: Hannah Crafts and the Gothic Real

Ratcliffe turns to **Hannah Crafts’s** *The Bondswoman’s Narrative* (c.1850s, pub. 2002) as a counterexample to white, Anglophone definitions of realism. Likely the first novel by an African-American woman, it complicates every critical category.

30.88.1 Reading and Power

Crafts’s heroine, Hannah, hides behind damask curtains “with a book” — a scene that echoes *Jane Eyre* and *Bleak House*. She reads secretly, using literacy to claim selfhood. This small act of reading is itself *realist resistance* — asserting that “reading novels” is a thing that really happens, a form of lived experience.

30.88.2 Realism and the Gothic

In one scene, an illiterate field slave, Joe, reports seeing a ghost. The narrative shifts from realism to Gothic:

“Oh, Missus, de ghost, de ghost, sabe me from de ghost.”

Ratcliffe reads this as a deliberate collapse of genre boundaries. What looks like “unreal” Gothic fantasy becomes the most *realistic* depiction of enslaved fear imaginable.

Hilary Mantel, reviewing the novel, argued that “**the Gothic is an apt form in which to express the feelings of the powerless...** because they are the victims of caprice, and rationality cannot save them.” (Mantel 2002)

Mini-Essay — Gothic Realism

For those denied agency, Gothic exaggeration can become realism. What seems “melodramatic” to a privileged reader may simply reflect the extremity of another’s truth. The Gothic thus

becomes realism's unacknowledged twin — the mode that tells emotional and political realities invisible to the “sane” world.

30.88.3 Whose Reality?

Crafts's novel exposes realism's blind spot: its presumption that “the real” belongs to the secular, rational, and European. If “realism” depends on whose experience is central, then *The Bondswoman's Narrative* redefines the real as the struggle for safety, literacy, and survival.

Mini-Essay — Realism as Liberation

Realism's power lies not in reproducing surfaces but in representing *lived pain*. For Crafts, to write fiction at all is to declare one's existence — an act of realism more radical than mimetic verisimilitude.

30.89 IV. Realism, Class, and Representation

Zola famously claimed that the novelist should “trace out the thread which leads mathematically from one man to another” — a scientific naturalism (Zola 1871). But Ratcliffe highlights the contradiction: the “raw material” of society was already writing and representing itself.

The **working classes** were no longer merely objects of depiction but new producers of text and image — through cheap novels, periodicals, and photography. The so-called “democratisation” of realism thus reimposed a boundary between **representors** and **represented**.

Mini-Essay — The Anxiety of Authorship

As literacy expanded, the realist author's authority shrank. The anxiety that photography or mass print might capture reality more directly haunted novelists. Realism became self-protective: an art of asserting mediation rather than denying it.

George Moore's *Esther Waters* (1894) illustrates this paradox. Its illiterate heroine is described with aesthetic violence:

“Her face was a blunt outline, and the grey eyes reflected all the natural prose of the Saxon.”
(Moore 1894)

Her illiteracy becomes fetishised — a symbol of purity untouched by artifice. The “raw” working-class woman is rendered through the stylised prose of a middle-class man.

George Eliot once wrote that “these fellow-mortals must be accepted as they are,” but Moore's “natural prose” exposes the artifice of that acceptance.

Mini-Essay — The Raw and the Cooked

Realism's “humble study of nature” often masks voyeurism. The “raw” becomes a rhetorical device — the illusion of access to an unmediated world produced through the most mediated of means.

30.90 Conclusion: Realism's Refracted Mirror

Realism was never a single method but a spectrum of tensions — between truth and artifice, democracy and hierarchy, seeing and believing. Its evolution, from Howells's “truthful treatment” to Hardy's “disproportioning,” from Hannah Crafts's Gothic realism to Dickens's comic distortions, reveals not the stability but the multiplicity of “the real.”

Mini-Essay — Realism as Relation

To write realism is to negotiate distance: between author and subject, image and truth, viewer and viewed. The realist novel's enduring lesson is not that art mirrors life, but that life itself is a network of representations — the “nearly real.”**

30.91 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Transparency <-> Mediation	From mirror to frame	Realism depends on acknowledging its artifice; “clear prose” always refracted.
Ethics <-> Aesthetics	Eliot’s “faithful study of nature”	Artistic truth aligned with moral vision, yet dependent on hierarchy of gaze.
Author <-> Subject	Zola’s “scientific” detachment vs. Crafts’s resistance	Representation as power relation; realism as both documentation and domination.
Image <-> Text	Photography and literature	The novel learns from and competes with visual technology; seeing as reading.
Realism <-> Gothic	Mantel’s “spot on the map where it is literally true”	Gothic exaggeration reframed as emotional realism.
Realism <-> Modernity	Hardy’s distortion, Dickens’s metaphor	Realism anticipates modernist self-reflexivity; truth through estrangement.
Seeing <-> Believing	“Looked like” in Dickens	Appearance and perception entangled; vision as epistemological limit.
Democracy <-> Authority	Realism’s liberal promise	Representation extended to new classes, yet filtered through elite authorship.

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30.93 Introduction: Wilde, Identity, and Anachronism

Oscar Wilde remains one of the most recognisable figures of modern sexual history. Yet, as Fergus McGhee cautions, “**Wilde as the first modern homosexual**” is as much a **retrospective invention** as a historical fact (McGhee 2025).

Following the 1895 trials, Wilde became synonymous with “the homosexual” — a new type produced by the **pathologising discourse of sexology**. As Alan Sinfield argues, the idea of homosexuality as a totalising identity, complete with “attributes, habits, and pathology,” was **manufactured at the fin de siècle**, not discovered (Sinfield 1994).

Before this invention, there existed **acts**, not identities — “same-sex desire,” not “homosexuality.” The notion that Wilde “embodied” an essence called gayness belongs to a post-1895 culture of **classification and moral panic**.

Mini-Essay — The Invention of Visibility

Wilde did not *become* the homosexual type; he was *typed* as it. The Wildean qualities — aestheticism, wit, effeminacy — retrospectively coded as “gay” were, in the 1880s, attributes of artistic excess, even heterosexual sensuality. Visibility, paradoxically, was created by scandal.

30.94 II. From Acts to Identity: Pathology and Performance

30.94.1 The Petition from Prison

After his conviction for “gross indecency” (under the 1885 Labouchere Amendment), Wilde’s 1896 **petition to the Home Secretary** betrays internalised pathology:

“He does not attempt to palliate the offences of which he was rightly found guilty, but to point out that such offences are forms of sexual madness... diseases to be cured by a physician, not crimes to be punished by a judge.” (Wilde, *Letter to the Home Secretary*, 2 June 1896; Holland & Hart-Davis 2000, p.656; handout p.1)

Here Wilde adopts the very **medicalising discourse** he resisted in his art. McGhee calls this “the tragedy of capitulation”: a man whose writings dissolved categories forced to describe himself in the language of pathology.

Mini-Essay — The Pathologised Artist

Wilde’s plea transforms sin into sickness, vice into symptom. His petition shows how thoroughly the new science of sex had colonised subjectivity — even the artist of ambiguity compelled to claim diagnosis as mercy.

30.94.2 “The Love That Dare Not Speak Its Name”

At his trial, Wilde delivered one of the most celebrated — and ambiguous — defences in literary history:

“It is that deep, spiritual affection that is pure as it is perfect... misunderstood, so much misunderstood, that it may be described as the ‘love that dare not speak its name,’ and on account of it I am placed where I am now.” (Hyde 1973, p.201; handout p.2)

The speech reclaims same-sex love as **intellectual and artistic** rather than carnal, linking it to **Plato, Michelangelo, and Shakespeare**. Yet its emphasis on “purity” and “intellect” invites multiple readings: defence, denial, and redefinition at once.

Mini-Essay — Speaking and Unspeaking Love

Wilde elevates eros into philosophy but also desexualises it. His rhetoric, both bold and evasive, performs what McGhee calls “the ethics of the unsaid” — a poetics of desire constrained by legality yet liberated through art.

30.95 IV. The Picture of Dorian Gray — Style, Scandal, and Censorship

30.95.1 The Lippincott's Text (1890)

Upon its first publication, *Dorian Gray* provoked outrage:

“Why go grubbing in muck heaps?... It is false art, for its interest is medico-legal... If he can write for none but outlawed noblemen and perverted telegraph-boys, the sooner he takes to tailoring the better.” (*The Scots Observer*, 5 July 1890; handout p. 2)

The insult — “outlawed noblemen and perverted telegraph boys” — alludes to the **Cleveland Street scandal** (1889), in which aristocrats were discovered patronising a male brothel. Reviewers thus **coded same-sex desire** without naming it.

When challenged, Wilde refused moral correction but subtly revised the text for the 1891 edition, excising explicit confessionals like Basil Hallward's declaration:

“I have worshipped you with far more romance of feeling than a man usually gives to a friend... Somehow, I had never loved a woman.” (*Lippincott's text*, 1890; handout p. 3)

Mini-Essay — Revision and Repression

Wilde's excisions do not erase desire; they reframe it as **style**. The novel's eroticism migrates from plot to prose — into colour, texture, rhythm. Style becomes the refuge of the unspeakable.

30.95.2 “False to Morality”

In later letters to editors, moralists complained that Wilde “lacked the tact and restraint to give us the artistic representation of a hero who is half Jack the Ripper, half Gaveston” (*Scots Observer* letter, July 1890; handout p. 2).

The comparison of Dorian to Gaveston — the favourite of Edward II — marks an early **critical linking of homosexuality and violence**, a pairing Wilde's prose resists by aestheticising both.

Mini-Essay — The Aesthetic of Ambiguity

Wilde refuses to “distance” the reader from sin. The problem, critics said, was not that he depicted vice, but that he made it beautiful. In making vice pleasurable, *Dorian Gray* transforms morality into aesthetics — and thus destabilises both.

30.96 VI. The Importance of Being Earnest (1895) — Double Lives and Double Meanings

McGhee ends with Wilde's final, and most subversive, comedy. *The Importance of Being Earnest* celebrates duplicity: every character performs a **double life**.

“Bunburying” — the act of inventing a second identity — mirrors the double existence forced upon queer Victorians. Yet the play refuses exposure or punishment; all lies are rewarded.

At the close, Jack discovers that he really *is* called Ernest.

“It is a terrible thing for a man to find out that all his life he has been speaking nothing but the truth.”

“Of course,” replies Gwendolen, “I feel you are sure to change.”

Mini-Essay — Truth in Disguise

Wilde turns farce into philosophy: every mask conceals a truer self. *Earnest* sanctifies deceit as creativity. Its world rewards invention, wit, and self-fashioning — the hallmarks of queer survival.

In McGhee's words, “It is gay in every possible sense: in humour, in self-creation, in defiance.” The play's joyous artifice closes the circle opened by the trials: Wilde's greatest defence of identity is comedy itself.

30.97 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Unspeakable Desire	“The love that dare not speak its name”; <i>The Portrait of Mr W. H.</i>	Explores how same-sex desire becomes articulate through evasion, irony, and aesthetic language.
Acts <-> Identity	Wilde’s 1896 petition; <i>The Trials of Oscar Wilde</i>	Traces transformation of sin and behaviour into medicalised identity; Wilde’s self-diagnosis as tragedy.
Law and Pathology	Petition to Home Secretary; Boulton & Park trial (1871)	Shows emergence of legal-medical discourse; criminalisation reframed as disease.
Art and Morality	<i>The Picture of Dorian Gray</i> ; <i>Scots Observer</i> reviews	Illustrates collision of aesthetic autonomy with moral panic; beauty as ethical subversion.
Performance and Doubling	<i>Earnest</i> , “Bunburying”; <i>Lady Windermere’s Fan</i>	Theatrical doubling as model for queer self-fashioning; performance as truth.
The Fallen Woman / Double Standard	<i>A Woman of No Importance</i> ; Wilde’s interviews	Challenges gendered moral codes; women’s transgression mirrors male sexual freedom.
Silence and Speech	“Dare not speak its name”; courtroom rhetoric	Tension between confession and discretion; the politics of saying nothing.
Aestheticism and Eros	Basil’s adoration of Dorian; <i>Salomé</i> imagery	Eroticisation of art and artifice; beauty as moral danger and liberation.
Comedy and Defiance	<i>The Importance of Being Earnest</i>	Comedy as resistance; laughter as queer survival strategy.
Visibility and Anachronism	Du Maurier’s cartoon (1881)	Shows how Wilde was coded as deviant before sexology; “gay” retroactively imposed.

30.98 Exam Relevance

30.98.1 Core Relevance to Oxford Prelims Paper 3 (1830–1910)

- Places Wilde within **Victorian discourses of sexuality, morality, and censorship**.
- Demonstrates how **aestheticism intersects with legal and medical definitions** of deviance.
- Highlights the evolution from **unspeakable act to named identity**, central to cultural modernity.
- Links Wilde’s dramatic form to **queer performance, doubling, and irony**.

30.98.2 Analytical Skills

- Reading **legal and literary language** comparatively.
- Identifying **subtext, irony, and coded desire** in Wilde’s prose and drama.
- Integrating **historical context** (trials, reviews, caricatures) with textual analysis.
- Discussing **gender alongside sexuality** — “fallen woman” and “fallen man” as mirrored tropes.

30.98.3 Model Essay Patterns

1. **“The love that dare not speak its name speaks through art.”**
— Analyse how Wilde’s language transforms silence into aesthetic discourse.

2. **“Performance is Wilde’s form of confession.”**
— Discuss Wilde’s theatrical self-fashioning in *Earnest* and his trials.
3. **“No law for anybody.”**
— Explore how Wilde’s plays destabilise gendered and moral hierarchies.
4. **“Beauty is itself a scandal.”**
— Examine *Dorian Gray* as a confrontation between aesthetic pleasure and Victorian propriety.

30.98.4 Revision Strategies

- Review **trial transcripts and petitions** alongside Wilde’s texts — law as rival narrative form.
- Compare Wilde’s rhetoric to **contemporary sexological discourse** (Lombroso, Nordau).
- Trace Wilde’s influence on **later queer modernism** (Forster, Huxley, Bowen).
- Revisit his comedies for how **wit disguises seriousness** — irony as philosophy.

End of Notes — **“Oscar Wilde and Sexuality: The Love That Dare Not Speak Its Name.”**

31 Own Notes

32 Transcript

![[Oscar Wilde - PRE3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom)-3.txt]]

33 Files

![[Wilde Lecture 4 Sexuality handout.pdf]]

34 Cleaned Up Notes

35 Art for Art's Sake?

35.0.1 Fergus McGhee — Art and Imagination IV (Oxford Prelims Paper 3: 1830–1910)

35.1 I. Origins of the Slogan

35.1.1 Kant and Disinterested Pleasure

The roots of *art for art's sake* lie not in Wilde or Pater, but in **Immanuel Kant's** *Critique of Judgment* (1790).

Kant's idea of aesthetic judgment as “**purposiveness without a purpose**” proposed that beauty is apprehended through *disinterested pleasure* — pleasure neither moral, practical, nor sensual:contentReferenceoaicite:2:contentReferen

Kant defined the beautiful negatively — as that which gives satisfaction “without interest.”

The pleasure of beauty arises not from utility or gratification but from **the free play of imagination and understanding** — a kind of purposeless activity with its end in itself.

Mini-Essay — The Freedom of Uselessness

Kant liberated art from moral and functional criteria. The beautiful need serve no purpose; its justification lies in the autonomy of feeling. This emancipation, however, was fragile: the moment art claims to have “no purpose,” it risks being dismissed as frivolous.

35.1.2 The Romantic and French Transformations

Kant's ideas filtered into nineteenth-century France through **Josephine de Staël's** *De l'Allemagne* (1810) and **Victor Cousin's** *Sorbonne lectures* (1818), which declared:

“There must be religion for religion's sake, morality for morality's sake, just as there must be art for art's sake.”:contentReferenceoaicite:4

By the 1830s, the phrase had become polemical. **Théophile Gautier**, in the notorious preface to *Made-moiselle de Maupin* (1835), attacked critics who demanded that art serve “the needs of society.”

“A book does not make gelatine soup; a sonnet is not a syringe; a drama is not a rail-road.”:contentReferenceoaicite:5

Gautier redefined beauty by excess:

“Nothing is really beautiful but that which is useless... The most useful part of a house is the privy.”:contentReferenceoaicite:6

His irony made **uselessness itself** a kind of defiant moral stance — beauty against progress.

Mini-Essay — Uselessness as Protest

Gautier's “useless” beauty was not indifference but rebellion: a critique of industrial capitalism and moral utilitarianism. His aestheticism refuses conversion — a beauty that will not be useful to you, a refusal that becomes ethical in itself.

35.2 III. Morality, Sensuality, and the Body: Rossetti and the Fleshly School

Dante Gabriel Rossetti's *Bocca Baciata* (1859) marked a decisive shift from symbolic Pre-Raphaelitism to sensual immediacy.

The painting's title — “The Kissed Mouth” — provoked moral alarm. **William Holman Hunt** accused Rossetti of “mere gratification of the eye... animal passion to be the aim of art” (letter to Thomas Combe, 1860):contentReferenceoaicite:9.

The scandal culminated in **Robert Buchanan's** 1871 attack, “The Fleshly School of Poetry.”

Rossetti replied in *The Stealthy School of Criticism* (1871):

“The delights of the body are as naught if not ennobled by the concurrence of the soul.”:contentReferenceoaicite:10

He refused both prudishness and hedonism, fusing spiritual and physical perception:

“Thy soul I know not from thy body.” (*Heart’s Hope*, 1881):contentReferenceoaicite:11

Mini-Essay — Embodied Thought

Rossetti rejects dualism. Thought and expression, soul and body, are one.

For him, art’s physical beauty *is* its intellect — colour and form are the soul’s language.

This integration anticipates Walter Pater’s later insistence that “form and matter... present one single effect to the imaginative reason” (*The School of Giorgione*, 1877):contentReferenceoaicite:12.

35.3 V. Whistler and the Music of Paint

James McNeill Whistler radicalised Pater’s ideal of autonomy.

In his *Ten O’Clock Lecture* (1885) he mocks moralistic critics:

“The painter’s poetry is lost to them... They praise virtues we would blush to possess, while the great qualities that distinguish the masterpiece have never been seen at all.”:contentReferenceoaicite:17

Whistler renamed his paintings *Nocturnes* and *Symphonies*, rejecting narrative for composition:

“A nocturne is an arrangement of line, form, and colour first.” (Old Bailey trial, 1878):contentReferenceoaicite:18:contentReferenceoaicite:19

When Ruskin accused him of “flinging a pot of paint in the public’s face,” Whistler sued for libel — and won, though awarded only a farthing.

His triumph symbolised art’s independence from moral arbitration.

Mini-Essay — Arrangement as Ethics

For Whistler, “arrangement” is not escape from meaning but a moral stance: refusing reduction.

Form is its own justification; to see rightly is itself virtue.

35.4 VII. Nietzsche and the Limits of Autonomy

Friedrich Nietzsche, in *Twilight of the Idols* (1888), exposed the paradox of the slogan:

“The struggle against purpose in art is always the struggle against the moralising tendency in art...

But once you exclude the purpose of sermonising and improving people, it does not follow that art is totally purposeless.”:contentReferenceoaicite:22

Art, Nietzsche argues, still “praises, dignifies, selects.” It cannot escape value; it *creates* it.

Thus, “better no purpose at all than a moral purpose” is mere “passion.”

Mini-Essay — The Paradox of Purposelessness

Nietzsche rescues *art for art’s sake* from nihilism. The rejection of didacticism need not deny art’s value-making power.

Even aesthetic autonomy, he shows, is a moral choice — a revaluation of values through style.

35.5 Conclusion: What Art For Art’s Sake Meant

McGhee closes by reclaiming *art for art’s sake* as a mode of **serious attention**, not mere decadence.

Its proponents — Kant, Gautier, Swinburne, Pater, Whistler, Leighton — sought to defend **the integrity of experience** against the reduction of art to use, politics, or sermon.

Mini-Essay — Attention as Ethics

“To look at art rightly,” McGhee concludes, “is itself a moral act.”

Art for art's sake asks not for detachment but devotion: a form of looking that honours the world by seeing it more clearly, sensuously, and freely.

35.6 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Moral <-> Aesthetic	From Kant to Nietzsche	Aestheticism both opposes and replaces ethics; art as new moral code.
Form <-> Content	Pater's monism; Rossetti's synthesis	Beauty is thought embodied; the distinction between form and meaning collapses.
Use <-> Freedom	Gautier's uselessness; Whistler's "arrangement"	Denial of utility as social critique; independence as protest.
Body <-> Spirit	Rossetti's "Fleshly School"	Sensual expression as intellectual sincerity; the body re-enchanted.
Religion <-> Art	Swinburne's parody of scripture	Aestheticism as secular faith; moral transcendence through sensation.
Politics <-> Autonomy	Gautier's rebellion; Nietzsche's critique	"Art for art's sake" as resistance to instrumental politics, not apolitical retreat.
Discipline <-> Pleasure	Pater's "fine discrimination of pleasure"	Refined perception as ethical labour; aestheticism's moral seriousness.
Surface <-> Depth	Whistler's "picture frankly as picture"	Surface valued not as superficiality but as site of infinite return.

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35.8 Introduction: Reading across Language Difference

This collaborative lecture stages the very principle it discusses: *translation as dialogue*.

Evangelista and Reynolds alternate voices to model how meaning travels between speakers, languages, and academic traditions:contentReferenceoacite:1.

Their argument begins with a provocation: nineteenth-century British literature was *never monolingual*. “Victorian literature,” Evangelista insists, “was written **with English, not in English**.”

To write in English was always to negotiate other linguistic presences — French, Italian, Latin, Greek, Sanskrit, or dialect.

Modern readers, too, inhabit varied “**language repertoires**”: fragments of dialect, code-switching, online speech, musical or programming idioms.

Reading, therefore, becomes an act of navigating between these repertoires rather than remaining inside a single, self-sufficient tongue.

Mini-Essay — The Continuum of Language Difference

“There are no languages, only varieties,” Reynolds suggests.

What we call *English* is a slice cut from a continuum of speech stretching into neighbouring tongues.

Translation, then, is not movement between sealed systems but **communication within a field of difference**.

35.9 II. Foreign Language within English Texts

35.9.1 Charlotte Brontë — *Jane Eyre* (1847)

In the storm-tossed scene after Jane’s failed wedding, she overhears voices speaking German through a window.

The novel prints the German lines without translation, forcing readers into Jane’s position — outside, listening, uncertain:contentReferenceoacite:2.

Some readers recognise Schiller; others do not. The unglossed passage creates **hierarchy and estrangement**, reminding us that English fiction often stages untranslatability.

Mini-Essay — Encountering the Untranslated

Foreign words on the page dramatise exclusion and longing.

The untranslatable moment becomes part of the novel’s moral structure: empathy born from not understanding.

35.9.2 Robert Browning — Multilingual Dramatic Monologue

Browning’s speakers — Italian dukes, French clerics, Greek playwrights — occupy linguistic worlds readers cannot hear directly.

Early monologues, like *My Last Duchess*, depend on the “myth of instant translation,” the fantasy that we can overhear another culture in our own tongue.

By the 1860s Browning foregrounds difficulty: *Aristophanes’ Apology* mixes Greek, English, and Italian. Meaning fragments into code-switching, making readers stumble phonetically.

Mini-Essay — Hearing through Babel

Browning’s polyglot lines dramatise the impossibility of total empathy.

His poems reveal how art both bridges and exposes linguistic difference.

35.9.3 Arthur Hugh Clough — *Amours de Voyage* (1858)

Clough litters his epistolary poem with foreign epigraphs and colloquial French (“*mettre en rapport*”).

The mild foreignness both unites and separates speaker and addressee, suggesting that **true connection requires mistranslation**.

35.10 IV. George Eliot — Epigraphs and Difficulty

Eliot’s novels, especially *Daniel Deronda*, open chapters with foreign-language epigraphs.

She could easily have translated them but chose not to.

“Why does she leave them?” Evangelista asks.
 To slow the reader down, to create “an encounter with difference.”

Eliot transforms translation into **pedagogy**: by making comprehension laborious, she models the ethical patience her novels demand.

Mini-Essay — The Ethics of Difficulty

Eliot’s untranslated epigraphs remind readers that moral understanding, like linguistic understanding, requires work.
 Difficulty becomes a virtue — reading as slow hospitality.

35.11 VI. Edward FitzGerald — *Rubáiyát of Omar Khayyám* (1859)

First issued anonymously as “*translated into English verse*”, not as an original poem, FitzGerald’s *Rubáiyát* erased its translator’s identity.
 Only later was it canonised as an “English classic.”

FitzGerald’s Persian manuscript reached him from Calcutta; thus the text’s trajectory reversed Dutt’s — **Asia translating into England**.

His self-effacement enacts the paradox of translation: to make another voice audible, the translator must disappear.

Mini-Essay — The Erased Translator

FitzGerald’s anonymity performs humility as authorship.
 Yet later canonisation re-inscribes ownership, turning translation back into property — a parable of empire’s linguistic appropriation.

35.12 VIII. The History of Victorian Translation

Evangelista offers a panoramic chronology:

Decade	Example	Significance
1840s–50s	George Eliot’s translations of Strauss and Feuerbach	Philosophical mediation; translation as apprenticeship to thought.
1861	D. G. Rossetti’s <i>Early Italian Poets</i>	Recovery of origins; Pre-Raphaelite primitivism in verse.
1870s–80s	William Morris’s Icelandic sagas	Archaeology of the North; revival of myth through craft.
1879–1910	Max Müller’s <i>Sacred Books of the East</i>	Imperial translation project linking linguistics and Orientalism.
1880s	Russian novels via French	Triangular mediation: Tolstoy and Dostoevsky filtered through Paris.
1890s	Scandinavian drama and French Symbolism	Ibsen and Baudelaire translated as moral and aesthetic shock.

Mini-Essay — Translation as Empire and Exchange

The century’s translation networks mirror global power structures but also unsettle them: knowledge circulates unpredictably, challenging the hierarchy of “original” and “copy.”

35.13 X. Heterolingual Address: The Reader as Translator

Drawing on the theorist Naoki Sakai, Reynolds defines **heterolingual address**: the condition of always speaking across difference.
 Even “native speakers,” he reminds students, are **learners trained by correction**; fluency is social fiction.

Reading and essay-writing are therefore acts of translation — moving a text’s language into our own interpretive idiom.

To study literature in English is to study **English as a multilingual practice**.

Mini-Essay — Translation as Criticism

Every act of interpretation is translational: the critic becomes a second author.

Reading, writing, and thinking are modes of listening across the gap between voices.

35.14 Conclusion: Reading as Translational Practice

Translation, in this lecture, is not supplement but **definition of literature itself**.

From Rossetti’s Italian poems to Dutt’s Calcutta sonnets, from Eliot’s epigraphs to Field’s red-ink fragments, nineteenth-century writing exists in a spectrum of linguistic relation.

Mini-Essay — The Reader as Polyglot

To read responsibly is to hear the foreign in the familiar, to let English speak in many accents.

Literature in English is, and always has been, literature **with English** — a chorus rather than a monologue.

35.15 Critical Lenses

Axis	Relationship	Implication
Original <-> Copy	Translation as imitation or extension	Challenges hierarchy of authenticity; translation as creative continuation.
Language <-> Power	Colonial translation projects	Reveals linguistic borders as instruments of empire and taxonomy.
Reader <-> Text	Heterolingual address	Every reader becomes translator; meaning negotiated across distance.
Comprehension <-> Estrangement	Untranslated passages	Difficulty as ethical encounter; alienation generates empathy.
Print <-> Speech	Typography versus accent	Standardisation silences local voice yet enables transnational dialogue.
Faithfulness <-> Freedom	Dutt’s adaptive translations; FitzGerald’s <i>Rubáiyát</i>	Fidelity redefined as relational creativity rather than servitude.
History <-> Modernity	Pater’s Latinised English	The ancient survives through stylistic translation; continuity through anachronism.
Gender <-> Voice	Michael Field’s Sappho	Translation as queer resurrection; feminine voice recovered through re-creation.

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35.17 Introduction: Insincerity and Multiplicity

The final lecture in the Wilde series turns to **the plays** — the height of Wilde’s theatrical achievement and the most paradoxical expression of his philosophy of performance.

Prof. Sos Eltis begins with Gilbert’s claim in *The Critic as Artist*:

“What people call insincerity is simply a method by which we can multiply our personalities.”:contentReferenceoaicite:0

Wilde transforms **insincerity** from moral flaw into creative principle.

In *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, Dorian himself echoes this credo:

“Is insincerity such a terrible thing? I think not. It is merely the method by which we can multiply our personalities.”:contentReferenceoaicite:1

For Wilde, performance — deceit, pretence, fantasy — is not hypocrisy but **freedom**.

Multiplicity defies judgement: the self cannot be fixed into “types” or “moral categories.”

Every human being, Wilde insists, contains “myriad lives and myriad sensations.”:contentReferenceoaicite:2

Mini-Essay — The Moral of Masks

Wilde’s theatre turns morality inside out. The mask does not conceal truth; it reveals that truth is plural.

Sincerity becomes another costume — a pose more dangerous than artifice because it mistakes convention for authenticity.

35.18 II. Theatrical Contexts: Melodrama and Modernism

35.18.1 Melodrama’s Moral Certainties

Victorian melodrama, Eltis notes, depended on revelation and resolution:

hidden sins exposed, false identities revealed, virtue rewarded.

As Peter Brooks observed in *The Melodramatic Imagination* (1976):

“Nothing is spared because nothing is left unsaid... characters utter the unspeakable and dramatize the whole of their relationship.”:contentReferenceoaicite:4

Melodrama replaces theology and law: truth appears through **recognition and confession**.

Wilde inherits these conventions — the fallen woman, the hidden letter, the blackmail — but subverts them.

Mini-Essay — Wilde’s Anti-Melodrama

Wilde rewrites revelation as reinvention. His characters confess only to change the terms of guilt; exposure becomes another mask.

Where melodrama ends in moral clarity, Wilde’s theatre ends in ambiguity — a re-knotting rather than an untying.

35.18.2 Ibsen and Psychological Modernism

By the early 1890s, Ibsen’s *A Doll’s House* (1889) and *Ghosts* (1891) had revolutionised English theatre with layered psychology and social critique:contentReferenceoaicite:5.

Ibsen’s “well-made plays” expose self-deception rather than evil, showing how **society manufactures identity**.

Wilde draws on both Ibsen and melodrama, blending high moral debate with witty artifice. Where Ibsen's Nora walks into the dark to discover herself, Wilde's heroines walk into society's light — performing rather than escaping their roles.

Mini-Essay — Wilde after Ibsen

Ibsen sought truth through sincerity; Wilde finds truth in performance.

His characters achieve freedom not by rejecting masks but by choosing which to wear.

35.19 IV. *An Ideal Husband* (1895): Politics and Performance

35.19.1 Plot in Brief

Sir Robert Chiltern, a respected politician, is blackmailed by Mrs Cheveley for having sold a cabinet secret in his youth.

His wife, Lady Chiltern, worships him as “the ideal husband.”

Meanwhile, Lord Goring — the languid dandy — manipulates secrets, brooches, and love letters to engineer a resolution that exposes everyone's hypocrisy:contentReferenceoaicite:7.

The play fuses **political intrigue, moral debate, and drawing-room comedy**, appealing simultaneously to gallery and stalls.

Mini-Essay — The Play of Publics

Wilde, asked which “public” he wrote for, replied: “Which public? There are as many publics as there are personalities.”:contentReferenceoaicite:8

His drama refuses a single audience or a single moral; it performs multiplicity even in reception.

35.19.2 Melodrama in Reverse

Reviewers described *An Ideal Husband* as “genteel melodrama.” One complained that it would “fill us with joy over the escape of a sinner from the penalty of his sin through a trick with a diamond bracelet.”:contentReferenceoaicite:9

But Wilde inverts melodramatic justice: the corrupt politician triumphs, the blackmailer fails, and morality remains uncertain.

Mini-Essay — The Criminal as Hero

Sir Robert's sin is enterprise, his success a reward for intelligent wrongdoing.

Wilde's sympathy for the fallen man transforms the Victorian cult of virtue into a satire on political hypocrisy.

35.19.3 Shaw's Review

George Bernard Shaw grasped the paradox best:

“In a certain sense, Mr Wilde is our only thorough playwright... He plays with everything — wit, philosophy, drama, actors, audience.”:contentReferenceoaicite:10

Shaw praised the play's **playfulness**, its refusal of thesis or sermon.

He also noted its sentimentality: Wilde the satirist is “the most sentimental dramatist of the day.”

This mixture of levity and tenderness defines Wilde's theatre.

Mini-Essay — The Seriousness of Play

Wilde's “plays without a thesis” dramatise freedom itself — not moral lessons but ethical thinking-in-motion.

His wit becomes dialectic, a conversation without conclusion.

35.20 VI. The Criminal as Christ

Wilde's sympathy for transgression, Eltis notes, recalls his argument in *The Soul of Man under Socialism*:

“Disobedience, in the eyes of anyone who has read history, is man’s original virtue... It is finer to take than to beg.”:contentReferenceoaicite:12

Crime, in Wilde’s imagination, is creativity misnamed.

Sir Robert Chiltern’s fraud becomes an act of survival within a corrupt order — a version of Wilde’s Christ-like rebel.

Mini-Essay — The Gospel of Rebellion

Wilde’s moral heresy is theological: sin is sanctified as self-expression.

In a world of false laws, only the lawbreaker can embody truth.

35.21 VIII. Wilde’s Curtain Speech

At the première of *Lady Windermere’s Fan*, Wilde addressed the audience:

“Ladies and gentlemen, I have enjoyed this evening immensely... I congratulate you on the great success of your performance, which persuades me that you think almost as highly of the play as I do myself.”:contentReferenceoaicite:14

The joke makes the audience his collaborators — performers of meaning.

This blurring of playwright, actor, and spectator completes his philosophy of theatre.

Mini-Essay — The Audience as Artist

Wilde’s theatre invites interpretation as participation.

Every laugh, every judgement, is another performance — the critic becomes co-creator.

35.22 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Insincerity / Multiplicity	Gilbert’s dictum; Dorian’s echo	Moral freedom through self-division; identity as creative performance.
Mask and Revelation	<i>An Ideal Husband</i> ; Wilde’s public persona	The mask discloses hidden truths; sincerity redefined as aesthetic pose.
Performance as Resistance	Wilde’s dandified self; Gilbert’s essays	Conscious acting as rebellion against moral conformity and social policing.
Melodrama and Subversion	Hidden letter and blackmail tropes	Wilde inverts moral justice; exposure becomes new concealment.
The Criminal / Christ Parallel	Sir Robert Chiltern’s redemption; <i>Soul of Man</i>	Transgression sanctified; rebellion framed as moral virtue.
Gender and Spheres	Lady Chiltern’s idealism; Mrs Arbuthnot’s refusal	Collision of moral codes; feminine purity and masculine pragmatism re-scripted.
Audience as Collaborator	Wilde’s curtain speech; Shaw’s reviews	Theatre as reciprocal creation; spectators perform interpretation.
Surface and Depth	Gowns, décor, costume	Aesthetics as ethics; morality visualised in ornament.
Melancholy Beneath Wit	Wilde’s sentimental finales	The plays balance irony with compassion; laughter shadowed by loss.
The Freedom of Play	Wilde’s wit and epigram	Ethical experimentation through humour; the stage as space of imaginative liberty.

35.23 Exam Relevance

35.23.1 Core Relevance to Prelims Paper 3 (1830–1910)

- Introduces Wilde’s **philosophy of performance** and selfhood — central to Victorian and modern drama.

- Illuminates how **melodrama, social comedy, and aestheticism** intersect in late nineteenth-century theatre.
- Prepares students for essays on **gender, morality, and theatricality** across Aestheticism and Modernism.
- Builds conceptual links between Wilde’s prose (e.g. *The Critic as Artist*) and his stagecraft.

35.23.2 Analytical Skills

- Interpreting **dialogue as dialectic**: how repartee enacts ethical debate.
- Analysing **stage direction, costume, and décor** as visual rhetoric.
- Contextualising Wilde within **melodrama and Ibsenite realism**.
- Balancing textual analysis with **performance history and reception**.

35.23.3 Model Essay Patterns

1. **“All art is a mask.”** — Examine Wilde’s use of disguise, irony, and performance across the plays.
2. **“The criminal is the truest artist.”** — Discuss Wilde’s moral inversion in *An Ideal Husband* and *A Woman of No Importance*.
3. **“Comedy is Wilde’s form of criticism.”** — Explore how wit and humour operate as ethical method.
4. **“To act is to live.”** — Analyse Wilde’s philosophy of performance as liberation from Victorian sincerity.

35.23.4 Revision Strategies

- Compare *An Ideal Husband* with Ibsen’s *A Doll’s House*: exposure vs. ambiguity.
- Review Wilde’s public writings (*Soul of Man*, *Critic as Artist*) for his aesthetic theory.
- Practise reading scenes in both **textual and performance** modes — attention to tone, gesture, and costume.
- Note Wilde’s contradictions: satire of hypocrisy intertwined with nostalgia for emotion.

End of Notes — **“Oscar Wilde V: The Plays — Performance, Politics, and the Mask.”**

36 Own Notes

37 Transcript

![[Oscar Wilde - PRE3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom)-4.txt]]

38 Files

![[Wilde Lecture 5 Plays handout.pdf]]

39 Cleaned Up Notes

39.1 Victorian Stuff I: Dickens and Paperwork

39.1.1 Prof. Sophie Ratcliffe — Oxford Prelims Paper 3 (1830–1910)

39.2 I. The Age of Paper

The nineteenth century, Ratcliffe notes, was literally an “**Age of Paper**.”

Thomas Carlyle lamented that England had exchanged divine revelation for bureaucracy:

> “Call it at least the Age of Paper... beautiful art, not only of revealing thought, but also of so beautifully hiding from us the want of thought!” (Carlyle, *The French Revolution*, 1837):contentReferenceoaicite:1.

Mass production from rag pulp, advances in cheap printing, and the explosion of periodical culture filled homes and streets with bills, posters, share certificates, and novels.

Paper meant both *communication* and *clutter* — *red tape*, waste, bureaucracy, and debt.

Jane Frith Panton, recalling Dickens’s readings, quipped that she “had not much sympathy with paper sorrows.”

Her phrase, Ratcliffe suggests, encapsulates Victorian ambivalence: **the fear that feeling itself might be mass-produced**:contentReferenceoaicite:2.

Mini-Essay — Paper Sorrows

A “paper sorrow” is both fictional and structural — grief mediated through print, feeling flattened into commodity.

Yet paper also preserves; its fragility sustains empathy across centuries.

39.3 III. Curl-Papers and Serial Culture

Curl-papers recur obsessively in Dickens: Miggs in *Barnaby Rudge* (1841) appears “a strange revelation of blue and yellow curl-papers.”:contentReferenceoaicite:4

Such colour — blue and yellow — mirrors the *advertising leaves* bound into Dickens’s serial issues.

When Dickens published *Master Humphrey’s Clock* (1841), the weekly parts were printed on thin blue paper, interleaved with yellow advertisements for stoves and bonnets.

Ratcliffe reveals that **the very hues decorating women’s hair recur in the novel’s material form**.

Mini-Essay — The Self-Consuming Novel

Dickens feared his own fiction might become waste: paper meant to enlighten turned to paper curlers or kindling.

The “paper woman” thus embodies the writer’s anxiety of disposability — his art literally recycled into domestic trivia.

Dickens called serialization “perplexing and difficult,” lamenting how the weekly format cramped both body and imagination:contentReferenceoaicite:5.

His novels became victims of the “City of Unlimited Paper” satirised in *Household Words* (1857), where people “marry paper wives” and eat “paper food”:contentReferenceoaicite:6.

39.4 V. Paper Overload: Mr Snagsby in *Bleak House*

Dickens’s most papery character is **Mr Snagsby**, the law-stationer of *Bleak House* (1852–3):

> “In Cook’s Court... Mr Snagsby has dealt in all sorts of blank forms of legal process... in parchment, foolscap, brief, draft, brown, white, whitey-brown...” :contentReferenceoaicite:9.

The endless list of goods produces both comedy and claustrophobia.

The text chokes on its own catalogue — *forms without content*, echoing Chancery’s self-perpetuating paperwork.

Mini-Essay — The Hypnotic List

Dickens turns bureaucracy into litany. The repetition of “ink, India-rubber, pounce, pins” is mesmerising, but meaning collapses into enumeration.

Listing becomes an aesthetic of paralysis: writing that forgets why it writes.

The inventory, Ratcliffe observes, is a moral warning: fascination with things risks moral shade. Chancery’s paper world devours reality; its clerks become stationary in every sense — inert, absorbed, consumed by matter.

39.5 VII. From Dickens to Braddon and Trollope: Paper and Crime

Mary Elizabeth Braddon’s *Lady Audley’s Secret* (1861–2) stages metamorphosis through paperwork. A woman falsifies her name by altering newspaper notices; later, characters’ faces blanch “to a sickly, leaden pallor” at the sight of printed revelations:contentReferenceoaicite:11. Identity becomes a function of print: to exist is to be legible.

In Anthony Trollope’s *The Way We Live Now* (1875), paper drives financial scandal. Mr Melmotte forges signatures on “thin tissue paper,” later destroying the evidence: > “He tore [the documents] into small fragments and burned the bits... This one he chewed into a pulp till he swallowed it.”:contentReferenceoaicite:12

Mini-Essay — Eating Paper

The ultimate absorption: the forger devours his own medium.
Paper, once instrument of exchange, becomes bodily matter — guilt ingested, text digested.

39.6 IX. The Ellipsis and the Unspeakable

Ratcliffe ends with the typographical sign itself. From 1850 onward, critics note, the ellipsis — “...” — proliferates in fiction, marking what cannot or need not be said:contentReferenceoaicite:14. In Joyce’s story, the dots between clauses are **counterparts** of each other: the bureaucratic omission and the emotional void.

Mini-Essay — The Dots of Despair

The ellipsis translates silence into print.
On paper, pain becomes punctuation — a minimal mark carrying maximal feeling.
To “join the dots,” Ratcliffe concludes, is to re-enter the affect beaten out of the mechanised page.

39.7 Motif Tracker

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Paper as Material and Metaphor “Paper Sorrows”	Carlyle’s “Age of Paper”; Dickens’s <i>Pickwick Papers</i> Jane Frith Panton; Dickens’s sentimental fiction	Symbol of modernity’s fragility: medium of thought and waste alike. Emotional life commodified; printed grief as both counterfeit and preservation.
Curl-Papers and the Body	<i>Pickwick Papers</i> , ch. 22	Paper’s intimacy with flesh; the cerebral becomes comic materiality.
Colour and Commerce	Blue and yellow curl-papers; Dickens’s serial advertisements	Print culture mirrored in the domestic sphere; art turned commodity.
Flatness and Feeling	Critical charges against Dickens’s “flat” characters	Surface depth: emotion conveyed through repetition and texture, not introspection.
Bureaucratic Paperwork	Mr Snagsby’s inventories; Chancery in <i>Bleak House</i>	The paralysis of enumeration; lists as symbols of institutional stasis.

Motif	Example(s)	Interpretive Use
Paper Consumption	Melmotte's tissue contracts; "eating" documents	Text literally embodied; guilt ingested; the collapse of medium into matter.
Copying and Counterparts	Dickens's Nemo; Joyce's Farrington	Repetition as dehumanisation; clerical routine erases identity.
Ellipsis / Omission	Joyce's "..."; bureaucratic blanks	Punctuation as pathos; silence represented typographically.
Modern Afterlife of Paper	The paper clerk → modern bureaucracy	Transition from Victorian print to twentieth-century mechanisation; the persistence of paperwork as metaphor for alienation.

39.8 Exam Relevance

39.8.1 Core Relevance to Paper 3 (1830–1910)

- Illuminates the **material history of literature** — print, paper, and serial culture.
- Offers insight into **Dickens's realism and form**, focusing on how material "stuff" carries moral and emotional weight.
- Bridges **Victorian to modernist transitions**, tracing bureaucracy and repetition from Dickens to Joyce.
- Engages with the **ethics of attention to the ordinary**, a skill central to close reading.

39.8.2 Analytical Skills

- Reading **objects as symbols** within literary description.
- Connecting **material form** (paper, typography, serial format) to **thematic content** (emotion, bureaucracy).
- Using **intertextual comparison**: Dickens → Braddon → Trollope → Joyce.
- Recognising **periodical context** and visual culture as literary evidence.

39.8.3 Model Essay Patterns

1. **"The Victorians lived and felt on paper."** — Discuss using Dickens and *Bleak House*.
2. **"Flatness is the form of feeling."** — Analyse surface and sentiment in Dickens's characters.
3. **"The copy clerk is the first modern."** — Compare the bureaucratic body from *Bleak House* to Joyce's *Dubliners*.
4. **"To read Dickens is to handle paper."** — Explore the material imagination of Victorian fiction.

39.8.4 Revision Strategies

- Review *Bleak House* passages describing Snagsby, Nemo, and Chancery's documents.
- Memorise key metaphors (curl-papers, ledgers, advertisements, ellipses).

- Note links to **print technology and gender** — female labour and domestic paper culture.
- Practise connecting **material form to emotional tone** — how paper mediates feeling.

End of Notes — “Victorian Stuff I: Dickens and Paperwork.”

40 Own Notes

41 Transcript

![[Victorian Stuff - PRE3 (copy)_Captions_English (United Kingdom).txt]]

42 Files

![[VictorianStuff1Handout.doc]]

43 Cleaned Up Notes

44 Own Notes

- breaks the rules, innovates, does something new
- sense of security, loose ends will be tied up, that a criminal will be caught

detective fiction: Todorov vs Moretti

Moretti - a crime that has already happened rather than a new story

critics don't find detective fiction as 'proper literature' but yet spend so much time studying it... why?

- writerly formulae and readerly expectations
 - sustained way to thrash, sustain, meet these expectations

literary relatives: - oliver twist: New Gates Calendar

- newgate novel - glorified notorious villains
 - real fear that reading this novel would corrupt people
 - criminality, class and impact of reading
- sensation fiction
 - make us think about horrors it might appear on our doorsteps
 - ordinary life has the horrifying potential to turn into smth horrifying

** detection plays a role, but just one strand

The Beetle (detective who solves supernatural)

Penny Dreadful

- set of genres that tread on each other toes, pseudo-detective fiction
- today we see the genre as formulaic but that wasn't necessarily the case

19th century - start of modern policing (growth of cities and need for order and stability)

- what do newspapers do for the culture?
 - holmes reads the agony column and...

rs btw newspapers and 19th century fiction - The Novelty of Newspapers

** realising that mysteries are absolutely everywhere and newspapers become a conduit for these kind of stories

the detective restores order and is unbreakable - the world as a series of tidy, solvable puzzles - a way to deal with the chaos

modernity generates fear and anxiety - new things we don't understand -> need a detective - detectives as real-world superheroes

but TWE is the detective an agent of social justice? - detective - romance of liminality, counter-cultural - holmes - solution is abt elegance, detective work is not about money, intelligence is about pleasure, not abt money, to solve a crime is to do something beautiful, not useful! - x/ the police

ennui - super decadent - detective fiction as an interesting way to look at decadence [[PRE3W2 Nineteenth-Century Forms and Ideas Circus - Aestheticism and Decadence]]

- objects aren't object but clues
- re;evance becomes order (which is useful for the solving of mystery)

'ordinary vs outré (excessively outrageous crime)' - Poe the murder of the -> first ever detective fiction - flouts the rule/parody of the fair-play formula (reader shld be given enough clues to solve the mystery)

themselves) -> a century before the formula comes about - Doyle - The blue cabuncle - solving puzzle is more important than dispensing justice (thief walks free at the end) - light hearted and christmassy

when we read detective fiction, we read for plot (not for beautiful language, characters etc.) - disposable; we only read them once

44.0.1 Detective Fiction and Gender

- Poe's dupane story
 - first dupane has some interesting fiction
 - second dupane - Poe tries to solve a real-life crime, tries to fictionalise it
 - Marie Roget turns into a sexualised body,
 - in holmes and watsons world, friendship and profesisonal rs leaves no room for women
- Fantasy Ecle debates - victorian transatlantacism - the American Girl
 - Isabelle ??? type - Henry James (the Noble Bachelor, the Scandal in Bohemia, Doyle)

loveday brooke - genius - practicality - central conflict in 2nd story // middlemarch (dorothea and Casaubon)
- loveday is particularly fascinating, has no love interest - New Woman, Odd/Surplus woman - lady detective as a trope -> a corrective feature to the amchismo of Doyle's fictional universe

44.0.2 Literary Theory

44.0.2.1 Psychoanalysis & Poststructuralist

- 3rd Dupane story, the Purloined Letter
 - Lacan:
 - we nvr actl find out abt what is in the letter
 - the way that the letter moves from person to person, reflects working of unconscious, particularly that of trauma
 - Derrida
 - the letter contetns remain a mystery is ey
 - like language, the latter is a signifier but the signified is just out of sight, unavoidable disconnect btw a word in language and the word it is trying to reflect/represent
 - ** this is why so many poeple write detective fiction (postmodernists)
 - Todorov: fabula (story) vs syuzhet (plot)
 - bcs detective stories are about acts of reconstruction -> point to the construtedness of all plots -> show the inescable gap btw plot and story
 - so many detective stories point to the act of narration, the sliperiness of language and the elusiveness of absolute truth
 - 'You have attempted to tinge it with romanticism, which produces much the same effect as if you worked a love-story or an elopement into the fifth proposition of Euclid' (Sign of Four, Ch.1)
 - they look like theyre abt the truth but also about subjectivity
 - we hear only what we think we hear

"The Purloined Poe"

The Novel and the Police - policeman ethos becomes internalised by normal people - the world in which a detective can exist is a fundamentally paranoid world - every insignificant detail becomes important - a world where no one can really keep their secrets

Moretti - more Marxist than Foucauldian - Innocence is conformity; individuality, guilt. It is, in fact, something irreducibly personal that betrays the individual: traces, signs that only he could have left behind. The perfect crime - the nightmare of detective fiction - is the featureless, deindividualized crime that anyone could have committed [...] Detective fiction [...] exists expressly to dispel the doubt that guilt might be impersonal, and therefore collective and social - crime is alw presented as an exception - detective fiction is distracting at best, insidiously deceiving at worst - locates criminality in an individual bad guy - the clue

maps onto the truth - the criminal and the crime scene open up possible interpretations - the detective with his master code and shuts that down

The limits of Critique (PRE1)

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46 Files

![[DetectiveFiction_Handout__2025 (1).pdf]]

- poetry sounded different to the language of prose or of everyday speech
 - a heightened and specialised poetic register

guma secg → simple as opposed to compound words (simplex) - 270 simple words which appear to have been particularly 'poetic' in register (that we know of) - 3450 compounds (*guma gilp-hlæden*; *eal-fela*) restricted to verse in the surviving corpus - emphasises that these words are used by choice instead of necessity

- dynamic tension between compression and expansion - trying to compress as much meaning within one word; saying a lot within one space but by doing so, the poet expands the capacities of the word
 - *hlāford* (lord) vs. 'dryhten'/'frēa' (simplex lord in poetic register) vs. 'winedryhten' (friend-lord); 'folcfrēa' (people-lord)

hapax legomena (unique words) - any word that occurs only in a single poem *gilphlaeden ealdgesegen*

kennings - emphasises a certain quality of a person or thing, used in place of the plain, abstract designation

![[IMG_2678.jpeg]] - structure of exeter // another latin manuscript - sense of pleasing order (?) -> but not vv sure if correct, just a theory

language is not expected of the mid 10th century (west-saxon) - a poem that is significantly earlier than that of its manuscript (probs golden age of northumbria?)

- division btw text and hierarchy of texts between manuscripts?
- dont use the title to understand the poems -> titles are an editorial imposition
 - so is punctuation an editorial imposition

how to classify the wanderer? - tended to be called Elegy - applying a label from centuries later - inflected with romantic and post-romantic ideas - ==> need to be conscious about terming them Elegies

46.1 Who is talking?

- a single speaker who is anonymous
 - a very deliberate, loss of personal and social identity - section of BEowulf talking about loss of survivor as he puts treasure into the ground
- who is speaking the opening of the poem? - line 6, 7
 - looking towards the rest of the poem or looking back at the front of the poem?
 - envelope of narratorial voice, bookending the speech of the anhaga (former, as a narrative force)

46.2 Wyrð?

- Wyrð as a pre-christian context -> hard to access since all produced in a christian formate
 - in christian tradition, need free will in order to choose to sin or not to sin -> so the idea of Fate as predeterminism goes against this christian need for free will
 - MS Bodley 180 OE Boethius -> answer to free will + God's omnipotence
 - 520s in prison, writes a latin text called the Consolation of Philosophy. discuss fortune, free will, providence
 - extremely influential text for old english
 - God operates in a diff temporal space
 - Wyrð vs foreþonc
 - does our speaker have the christian understanding of Fate or is it something as pre-determined? does the speaker have a christian outlook on the world

46.3 Exile

- culture that doesnt have a prison system
- ** social, secular death
- can also end up in exile because someone is intending to murder you (fleeing from threats <- a culture that doesnt have a culture of _____, all adult males have the opportunity to be in line for the throne)
- wanderer: lost their lord and seems to be looking around for another lord
- but religious exile is seen positively (hermit)
 - wanderer might be playing around with this meaning -> anhaga // ansitla(?) (one who sits alone, common old english word for a hermit)
 - Seafarer // The Wanderer: imagery thats really similar to Wanderer but resolves much more positively in a spiritual exile -> rejecting the world in order to focus more positively on heaven

46.4 Sorrow and Sleep

- bed burial culture for high-status women

46.5 Transience

- conflation of Anhaga with the sea-birds,, memories fuse with the cries of the sea bird and the mental space blurs with the physical space which is decaying

46.5.1 Walls and Ruins

- building is an important image -> human constructions that can outlive human lifespan
- halls as representative of human society, halls as metonym for humans themselves
- decaying, crumbling building to suggest the inevitable failure of human endeavour
- buildings in the wanderer tends to be stone (/x wooden that lifespan is shorter than human) -> stone as a symbol of endurance but even then decays ##### The Work of Giants
- enta geweorc
 - from Maxims: something about wondrous things that lead them to be called work of giants -> more of cultural giants rather than actual giants that are being built
- exemplifies the way the world decays -> marvelous objects that cant be replicated
- maps out onto scripture time
 - final age of the apocalypse -> christian tradition of things falling apart that Wanderer taps into

46.6 Ways of Dying

- catalogues of terrible things that can happen to one -> typical of Wisdom texts
- Wanderer elicits a specific trope of the BEasts of Battle (wolf, raven, eagle etc.)
 - not just an old english motif but also old norse texts (germanic motif?) but also can be seen in Medieval Welsh poems
 - cross-cultural image
 - animals that come to eat corpses -> heralds of oncoming violence
 - in the wanderer, part on the sense of decay

46.7 Ubi Sunt - “Where are” (Latin())

- 92 -96
- very common genre in Latin verse asking where things are
 - not unsurprising for old english poets to be well versed in Latin works
 - using/borrowing Latin genres even if not directly translating Latin texts

46.8 Life is Loaned

- 108-10
- core christian concept (læne lif)
- beginning of christian understanding from the speaker, from everything is gone to everything being n loan and therefore must be on loan from someone or somewhere
- // Old Norse Corpus Havamal -> then not potentially a christian perspective, but Wanderer might be taking a common lament and then reshaping it to demonstrate a Christian worldview
 - same as Boethius -> from initially stuck thinking (binding, constriction), understanding of transience, arriving at a point of consolation // Wanderer

46.9 Stability in Heaven

- ** change of speaker
 - 111-15
 - notice how the anhaga and eardstapa has become the wise one
 - explicit offer of christian consolation
 - central figure in the text that doesnt have access to the knowledge -> audience is given access to the heavenly knowledge but the Wanderer might still be thinking
- thgis ending is competed
 - some people think its added
 - but mostly currently, we see the christian tradition as being embedded into the poem (very explicit christian context)
 - makes consolation look very easy, but cataloguing of misery is so extensive
 -

Sundor æt rune' - article that talks about the wanderer as moving from social exile to spiritual exile -> exile as a spiritual exile - but like still need to see if the anhaga makes the final spiritual step himself

Bernard O'Donoghue Farmers Cross - The Wanderer's adaptation

![[Intro to OE Set Texts 3 Handout (Wanderer).pdf]]

47 Cleaned Up Notes

48 Own Notes

ideas from science embedded in fiction in deep levels - manifest in specific diction and words

why consider them tgt - science provides us w concepts for ordering the world - natural history is also narrative-esque - so does narrative - borrows or mimics scientific concepts

- scientific ideas inform narrative form (the shape texts take and also its narrative)

methodological science tends to enter a scientific romance differently from realism - science fiction creates an alternative reality - acknowledgment that something is different about its world - novum

reality of the novel is continuous with the reader's novel - middlemarch is a fictitious town but resembles a victorian town (realist) - scientific ideas rather than being explicitly transformative, they ripple under the surface, the unconscious of the text (textual unconscious - ONLY for realism texts) - George Eliot was vv well versed with scientific texts - Dorothea grows new organs figuratively as an index of her transformed life and new reality (ch. 50 - "stirring of new organs")

science deals solely in facts and literature deals with feelings? - no

scientists too are creative thinkers - their thinking involves analogy and metaphors

science vs religion

plurality of sciences as well as religion

specialisation and inaccessibility - 19th century it was possible to range more widely across the sciences - possible to write in a non-specialised language as well - Gillian Beer, *Darwin's Plots* (1983), pp. 6-7 - scientific texts could be read very much as literary texts. - scientists ... drew openly upon literary, historical and philosophical material - traffic, then, was two-way. - non-scientific influences impinging on the scientist (immersed in society at the time)

science only accessible at the cost of being misunderstood - how do we gauge the creative reworking of a science? - while its useful to compare the account of scientist and that of novelists - we should look at why did they get it wrong, why did they reshape it/rework it

analogy and metaphor - thermodynamics -

- metaphor as a tool of thought (not as something to dress an idea up)
 - express new understandings using something familiar (comparing one domain of thought w another)

traces of culture in Darwin's theory - Malthus: belief that scarcity and competition was a fact for life for humans - Darwin → selective pressures → natural selection - Karl Marx, letter 1862: Darwin rediscovers, among the beasts and plants, the society of England, with its division of labour, competition, opening up of new markets, 'inventions' and the Malthusian 'struggle for existence' -

- verbal traces of scientific ideas
 -

prelude to middlemarch (3rd para): - "limits of variation" // ch. 1 Variation under Domestication // ch. 2 Variation under Nature

- reading victorian fiction for the FORM that the story takes
 - narratorial emphasis

uniformitarianism vs catastrophism - Eliot's narrator is reminding us of stuff that we missed (ch. 11) - moments of wills being read, suspect deaths and so forth, world of melodrama underneath it but attempt to narrate something that isn't melodrama

thermodynamics - energy and entropy - dominance of coal-powered technologies (steam - heat into movement)
- entropy as always tending towards increase

- “dissipation, flows, running down (spring, boiler, sun etc.)
- • dialogue on energy allows various entitties to be perceived as if they are leaky steam energies
 - sun as a leaky engine where energy is always leaking out
 - human bodies as having a finite easily depleted source of energy
 - sex-based (patriarchy, men as having more than women, women spend more easily, women need to save it for childbirth) -> language of scientific used to assert cultural ideologies
 - decline irreversibility and disorder -> biblical temples(?) - not waste anything given to you
- dissipation - physical and moral domains

is a moral concept drawn into physics or physics drawn into moral judgment?

sun being red - sunset? - finite lifespan of sun/time on earth - Conrads' Heart of Darkness, ch. 1 - “the sun sank low....” - idea of heat death -> novels concern with efficiency then takes on a diff set of resonances (bleak house: blocked flows, wasteful expenditure etc.)

unseen universe (where the dead go)

changes authority of science

influence of science on literature can take a long time to process - by the time its moved into diff cultures it might take different symbolisms - entrop 1906 - gloomy; 1960s california - groovy

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